

CBC 22201/13/0008/2627



Committed to Nari Shakti Vandan

#NariShaktiVandan



Nearly 12 crore women received safe maternity care



Mothers and children are getting vaccinated on time



Crores of children are getting better nutrition



GREAT OFFERS!



Scan to Subscribe

PIONEER IN SHORT



In this photo provided by NASA, the Orion spacecraft with Artemis II crewmembers aboard splashes down in the Pacific Ocean off the coast of California on Friday

PTI

Face-to-face, US-Iran talk truce

First round of negotiations conclude; 2 naval destroyers transit Strait of Hormuz

ASHOKE RAJ
■ New Delhi

High-stakes ceasefire negotiations between the United States and Iran were underway in Islamabad till late Saturday night with Pakistan mediating, marking the first face-to-face talks between the two adversaries since the Islamic Revolution of 1979.

A senior White House official confirmed that direct tri-lateral engagement involving US and Iranian delegations, with Pakistani facilitation, was underway in Islamabad.

The discussions, ongoing for over four hours, reportedly went into a scheduled break for internal consultations before resuming, underscoring the complexity and sensitivity of the issues under negotiation. The talks are being held under tight security arrangements and closely monitored by regional and international stakeholders, given their potential implications for broader stability in the West Asia.

A senior White House official provided detailed insight into the composition of the US



Security personnel stand next to signs regarding US and Iran negotiations outside a media facilitation centre in Islamabad on Saturday

delegation, confirming that Vice-President JD Vance was leading the American team. He is joined by special envoy Steve Witkoff and US President Donald Trump's son-in-law Jared Kushner, forming the core negotiating group.

"The core delegation is on the ground and fully engaged," the official said, adding that the broader US team also includes national security adviser Andrew Baker and Asian affairs adviser Michael Vance. "We also have subject-matter experts present in Islamabad, with additional analytical and policy support being coordinated from Washington, DC to assist real-time decision-making," the official said. The inclusion of

delegations paused for internal coordination and review of positions. Following the break, negotiations resumed with both sides attempting to narrow differences and explore possible pathways toward a ceasefire framework. While no breakthrough has been announced, the direct engagement itself is being viewed as a rare and significant diplomatic opening after decades of indirect contact.

Diplomatic sources said both sides entered the talks with deeply entrenched positions, and significant gaps remained on core issues. However, the fact that face-to-face engagement is taking place is being seen as a notable shift in diplomatic practice. Iran's news agency reported that the US and Iranian delegations exchanged written texts outlining the issues under discussion as the first phase of talks concluded, signalling a structured effort to define the parameters of the negotiations even amid ongoing disagreements.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Atrocities on women to end with BJP Govt in WB: Modi



Prime Minister Narendra Modi during a public rally ahead of the West Bengal Assembly elections in Dakshin Dinajpur, West Bengal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday launched a blistering attack on the ruling TMC, accusing it of turning West Bengal into a state run by "syndicates", while promising action on atrocities against women if the BJP comes to power.

Addressing a rally at Kushmandi in Bangladesh-bordering Dakshin Dinajpur district, Modi said the TMC had "handed over even the game of football to its syndicates", referring to the fiasco during Argentine football legend Lionel Messi's visit to Kolkata last December. "The entire

world watched those shameful pictures. TMC has handed over football, too, to its syndicate," he said.

Claiming that the State had become synonymous with lawlessness, Modi said, "In West Bengal, the syndicate is the Government and the Government is the syndicate." The prime minister said the 2026 assembly polls would be a contest between "TMC's fear and BJP's trust".

"This battle is to defeat fear and take West Bengal forward with trust. TMC's shop of loot and lies is about to be shut down. Fear will exit West Bengal, making way for trust," he said.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

ASTRONAUTS RETURN AFTER LUNAR FLYBY

Amid claps and cheers, four astronauts of NASA's Artemis-II mission splashed down in the Pacific ocean after a historic flight to the moon — the first by humans in more than 50 years. "The path to the moon is open but the work ahead is greater than the work behind," Amit Kshatriya, Indian-origin NASA Associate Administrator told a press conference shortly after the Artemis-II crew returned to earth off the coast of San Diego at 8:07 eastern time on Friday.

DETAILS ON P9

ASHA BHOSLE RUSHED TO HOSPITAL

Legendary playback singer Asha Bhosle was admitted to Mumbai's Breach Candy Hospital on Saturday evening after suffering cardiac arrest, sources said. The 92-year-old singer also had pulmonary issues, they said. Bhosle, with a career spanning eight decades, is known for her versatility. She is the younger sister of the late legendary singer Lata Mangeshkar. Some of Bhosle's popular songs are 'Chura Liya Hai Tumne Jo Dil Ko', 'Abhi Na Jao Chhod Kar', 'Intaha Ho Gai Intezar Ki', among others.

MOB ATTACKS HINDUS IN BANGLADESH AGAIN

A Muslim spiritual leader was hacked to death for allegedly insulting Islam while shops and households owned by Hindus were vandalised in two separate mob attacks in western Kushtia and northwestern Rangpur in Bangladesh on Saturday. An irate mob attacked several Hindu households and businesses in pre-dawn hours over the death of a Muslim youth in their neighbourhood in Rangpur, about 300-odd kms northwest of Dhaka.

A "third party" carried out the vandalism to divert the case and police's attention from the overnight murder of a person named Rakib Hassan, police claimed. Prothom Alo newspaper said more than a hundred members of the Hindu community live in the Daspara market area where Hassan was murdered allegedly by drug peddler Mohammad Momin over a previous dispute. Police said the attack took place even when the deceased youth's family said the Hindu community had nothing to do with his murder. "We have no issues with them (Hindus)," Hassan's mother Nur Jahan Begum told the local reporters. "But we are tracking down the real killers. We have also identified who have vandalised the Hindu households and shops," Rangpur's police commissioner Mohammad Majid Ali told reporters.



Prime Minister Narendra Modi greets Congress MP and Lok Sabha LoP Rahul Gandhi during the 200th birth anniversary celebration of Mahatma Jyotiba Phule, at the Parliament premises, in New Delhi on Saturday. Union Minister JP Nadda (left), MoS Arjun Ram Meghwal (right) and others are also present

13 killed in Bihar road mishap

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Katihar (Bihar)

Thirteen people were killed and 30 others injured following a collision involving a bus, a truck, and a pickup van in Bihar's Katihar district on Saturday evening. The accident took place at 6.30 pm on NH-31 in Kodha block of Katihar, Superintendent of Police Shikhar Choudhary told reporters. Those travelling in the pickup van were coming from Purnea district, said a local police official adding that the bus driver also suffered severe injuries.

Deported gangster back in police custody

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi/Chandigarh

The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI), acting in tandem with the Interpol and the Thai Police, have successfully repatriated dreaded gangster Sahil Chauhan (27), alias Sahil Rana, from Thailand. Chauhan is a dreaded history-sheeter and a key member of the notorious Bhupi Rana-Bambiha gangs. Wanted in dozens of criminal cases involving murder, extortion and kidnapping, Chauhan had escaped to Thailand.

He was traced to Bangkok



Gangster Sahil Chauhan

through Interpol channels. A dedicated CBI team got cracking to seek his deportation from Bangkok. Chauhan was handed over to a team of Haryana Police's Special Task Force (STF) that lay in wait at Delhi's Indira Gandhi

International Airport. "On request of the Haryana Police, the National Central Bureau (NCB)-New Delhi published an Interpol Red Notice against Sahil Chauhan. The subject was geo-located and deported from Bangkok and arrived in India at Delhi International Airport on April 10, 2026, where he was taken into custody by a team of Haryana Police.

Sahil Chauhan, a resident of Shahzadpur in Ambala district of Haryana, is a notorious gangster and has been involved with the underworld since 2016. There are 16 cases registered against him

across Haryana, Punjab, and Chandigarh and Delhi. He is wanted for multiple serious offences, including murder, attempt to murder, dacoity, extortion, robbery, criminal intimidation and violations of the Arms Act.

As a feared member of the Bhupi Rana gang, he also linked to the rival Bambiha gang network. Chauhan was involved in an inter-state organised crime syndicates notorious for contract killings, extortion rackets and gang rivalries. He was involved in a daring attack on a rival gangster in Yamunanagar district.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Delhi Govt makes EV policy attractive with subsidies



HIGHLIGHTS

- 100% road tax & registration fee waiver for EVs
- For the first time, 50% road tax concession for strong hybrids

PURCHASE INCENTIVES

- E-2Ws: up to ₹30,000 (phased)
- E-3Ws: up to ₹50,000
- E-goods vehicles: up to ₹1 lakh

SCRAPPING INCENTIVES

- ₹10,000 (2Ws), ₹25,000 (3Ws), ₹1 lakh (cars), ₹50,000 (goods vehicles)

Policy valid till March 31, 2030

RAJESH KUMAR
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government's Transport Department has officially published the draft of the Delhi Electric Vehicle (EV) Policy 2026, offering a 100 per cent exemption from road tax and registration fees for most EVs. For Strong Hybrids (under ₹30 lakh), you will get a 50per cent exemption.

If you are buying electric two-wheelers in Delhi, you may get a subsidy of up to ₹30,000 in the first year from the date of notification of the policy. As per the draft policy, electric auto-rickshaw buyers will receive a fixed incentive

of ₹50,000 in the first year, and two-wheeler buyers may get up to ₹30,000. If you scrap an old Delhi-registered BS-IV or below vehicle and buy a new EV within six months, you get an extra 'Scrapping Incentive'. The incentive will be provided on the purchase of a new EV if the purchase is made within six months of the issuance of the certificate of deposit (CoD) from an authorised scrapping facility.

The draft EV policy setting out a detailed roadmap to accelerate the capital's shift to electric mobility through time-bound restrictions on petrol vehicles, stricter fleet regulations, incentives for

EV adoption, and a large-scale expansion of charging infrastructure.

The draft, issued by the Transport Department's EV Cell, has been placed in the public domain for 30 days of stakeholder feedback (citizens and experts) before finalisation. The policy aims to reduce vehicular emissions, which remain a key contributor to Delhi's air pollution crisis, particularly during winter smog episodes.

In one of the most significant proposals, the draft lays down clear electrification deadlines for key vehicle segments.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Aadhaar settles long-pending identity issue of Ladakh residents

MOHIT KANDHARI
■ Jammu

Ladakh residents will now have 'Ladakh' listed as their State in Aadhaar records, replacing the earlier 'Jammu & Kashmir' entry.

The change, which fulfils a long-standing public demand, was implemented following the intervention of Lieutenant Governor Vinai Kumar Saxena.

Despite the formation of the Union Territory of Ladakh in 2019, after being carved out of Jammu & Kashmir, Aadhaar records of the people of Ladakh continued to reflect the erstwhile State name — J&K — instead of Ladakh, causing widespread concerns and hassles.

The Lieutenant Governor, taking



a serious note of the prolonged pendency in this important matter, directed the UT Administration to resolve the issue at the earliest.

The Lieutenant Governor said that the development would greatly benefit Ladakh's residents by removing procedural hurdles

and enabling seamless access to services. "Ensuring that the identity of Ladakh is accurately reflected in official records is not only an administrative necessity but also a matter of identity and convenience for our people. The successful resolution of this long-pending issue reflects the UT Administration's commitment to responsive governance, ease of living, and ensuring that the unique identity of Ladakh is properly represented across all official platforms," Saxena said.

According to the spokesperson of the Lok Bhavan (Leh), the UT administration took up the matter with the Unique Identification Authority of India (UIDAI) at higher levels. This long-awaited correction has now been successfully imple-

mented, ensuring that Ladakh's distinct regional identity is accurately represented in Aadhar.

The continued reflection of 'Jammu & Kashmir' in Aadhaar records of Ladakh residents has been causing considerable inconvenience to the people. Residents were facing difficulty using Aadhaar as a valid document for identity and address when availing various services, as the 'State' field in Aadhaar did not correspond to the post-reorganisation status of Ladakh.

The issue not only created hardship for citizens but also affected the proper representation of the Union Territory in Aadhar-linked records and progress reports.

According to the spokesperson of the Lok Bhavan, to resolve the issue, the UT Administration, in

coordination with UIDAI, devised an innovative mechanism to centrally update the State field. Instead of requiring each resident to visit Aadhaar centres for corrections, the updation of records was carried out based on PIN codes specific to Ladakh. These PIN codes were verified in coordination with the Department of Posts and shared with UIDAI.

This development has brought significant relief to the people of Ladakh, as they no longer need to visit Aadhaar centres individually to update their records. Residents can now easily download their updated e-Aadhaar from the official UIDAI portal, and those wishing to obtain a PVC Aadhaar card may order it online by paying a nominal fee, the spokesperson added.

Police arrest two ISI agents from Bijnor

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi/Lucknow

The Uttar Pradesh Police has arrested two ISI agents from the Bijnor district in Western Uttar Pradesh, who were working for the notorious Inter-Services Intelligence (ISI) of Pakistan. The duo was found to be in regular touch with a Pakistan-linked, Saudi Arabia-based handler identified as Aqib.

The accused, identified as Uvaid Malik and Jalal, were taken into custody by Bijnor Police following intelligence inputs about their ties to the handler, Aqib. The Circle Officer (CO), Najibabad, Anjani Kumar Chaturvedi, confirmed the arrests of Uvaid and Jalal.

They reportedly confessed during interrogation to being in regular touch with Aqib, a native of Sathla village in Meerut's Mawana area, now residing in Saudi Arabia. Aqib was recruiting new agents and was actively expanding his network via social media handles.



Aqib was working on a strategy at the behest of his Pakistan-based handlers and was actively involved in spreading inflammatory and radical content to incite young men from his community against Hindus. His modus operandi involved exploiting the social fault lines for promoting enmity towards Hindus. Uvaid Malik and Jalal Haider came into contact with Aqib when they were working in Surat and connected with another associate, Maizul, a native from Bijnor and currently based in South Africa. Investigations have revealed

that the handler used sustained digital engagement to build and coordinate with the group across borders.

It may be noted that in November 2025, a video surfaced on Instagram in which Aqib was seen displaying an AK-47 rifle and explosives. An initial local probe by Bijnor Police had dismissed the weapons as toys and filed a closure report.

However, the case turned on its head after the UP Anti-Terrorism Squad (ATS) got fresh evidence which linked it to a larger network. UP Police top brass initiated depart-

mental proceedings against erring officers, and the then station house officer and investigating officer were suspended while the CO was removed from his post pending enquiry.

On April 2-3, the UP ATS had arrested four other individuals, Saqib alias 'Devil', Arbaab, Vikas Gehlawat alias Raunak, and Lokesh alias Papla Pandit alias Sanju from Meerut and Gautam Buddh Nagar for allegedly planning arson on railway infrastructure and conducting reconnaissance of key installations. The Bijnor arrests point to an overseas digital radicalisation arm of the same or a connected network.

Authorities have issued Lookout Circulars (LOCs) against key suspects abroad: Aqib (already facing three LOCs), Maizul (South Africa), Azad (reportedly a driver in Dubai), and another individual named Sameer from Najibabad who is still being traced. Proceedings to cancel the passports of all accused

are underway, and the probe has been extended across multiple states in India as well as internationally to map the full digital and cross-border footprint.

A senior official of the UP Police said that Uvaid Malik was planning to flee to Nepal on the advice of his overseas contacts. Investigators are examining their phones and social media accounts for evidence of communication, shared content, and any operational instructions from the handler.

Central security agencies have alerted the state police forces over the use of social media by foreign handlers, often linked to Pakistan's ISI, to radicalise Indian youth, spread communal discord, and recruit for anti-national activities. UP Police and ATS officials have described it as part of a "wider terror-linked network" being run remotely through digital platforms. The investigation continues, with teams tracking leads both domestically and overseas.

Traffic curbs near Qutub Minar, Mehrauli Archaeological Park

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Traffic police have issued an advisory announcing restrictions and diversions around Qutub Minar and DDA Mehrauli Archaeological Park on Sunday in view of expected high vehicular movement and number of commuters.

According to the advisory, the curbs will be in place from 4 pm to 9 pm on Saturday, or as required, to ensure smooth regulation of traffic in the area.

No heavy or commercial vehicles will be allowed to move towards Qutub Minar from Anuvrat Marg via the Phool Mandi approach road or from Crescent Marg through Masjid Haji Ali Jan, Delhi Traffic Police said.

Similarly, movement of such vehicles will also be restricted from Kalka Dass Marg towards the monument, while halting or parking of heavy and commercial vehicles on connecting roads, including Anuvrat Marg, Crescent Marg and Kalka Dass Marg, has been



prohibited. Violators will be towed away and prosecuted as per law, the advisory stated. All major roads, including Aurobindo Marg, Anuvrat Marg, Crescent Road and Kalka Dass Marg, will remain open for regular traffic, but access to Qutub Minar will be allowed only via Kalka Dass Marg.

Parking will be permitted only at designated parking lots on Kalka Dass Marg in Mehrauli, police said.

Emergency vehicles, including ambulances, the fire brigade and police, will be

allowed free movement on all restricted routes.

The advisory also urged commuters to avoid the affected stretches, use public transport to reduce congestion, and plan their journeys in advance, especially those heading to the IGI Airport, New Delhi Railway Station and ISBT.

People have also been asked to report any suspicious objects or persons to the police immediately and cooperate with traffic personnel to ensure smooth management in the area.

Delhi Metro launches awareness drive to promote safe use of escalators, lifts

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

With passenger safety in focus, the Delhi Metro has launched a week-long awareness drive from April 7 to April 13 across stations to encourage the safe use of lifts and escalators.

The Delhi Metro, at present, is operating and maintaining 965 lifts, 1297 escalators and 42 travelers in its total network. The Kashmere Gate Metro station holds the distinction of having the highest number of escalators anywhere in the world in a metro station, with a record 53 escalators.

Described as a first-of-its-kind initiative in India's metro sector, the campaign forms part of a dedicated Safety Awareness Week aimed at educating passengers on the responsible use of these facilities.

As a part of the drive in progress from 7th to 13th April 2026, scout and guide volunteers, along with DMRC staff, are being deployed



near lifts and escalators at some of the stations with placards to make the passengers aware of the safe use of these facilities.

In addition, Nukkad Nataks (street plays) are also being organised at select stations with high ridership to make the passengers aware of the importance of safety. Leaflets are also being distributed to passengers with important messages on the safe use of these facilities.

The focus is on educating passengers about the safe use of elevators and escalators, promoting awareness of preventive measures, and sharing the best practices for

Parvesh conducts inspections of arterial roads to assess monsoon preparedness

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Public Works Department (PWD) Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh on Saturday conducted an inspection of the city's arterial roads to assess monsoon preparedness ahead of the monsoon season.

Travelling across South Delhi under the "Government on Wheels" initiative, the Minister was joined by senior officials from multiple departments, turning the inspection into a moving assessment of critical stretches. The inspection covered Moolchand Crossing, AIMS Crossing, the Chattarpur Metro stretch, Nelson Mandela Marg, the Munirka Flyover, Vivekanand Marg, and BJ Marg, along with several underpasses that are known pressure points during the monsoon.

"When you come to these locations yourself, the situ-



ation becomes very clear. You can see what has improved, where work is slow, and what could turn into a problem once heavy rain begins," Parvesh Sahib Singh said.

At multiple stops, the Minister got down to examine drains, desilting work, and road conditions. In some areas, incomplete cleaning and potential choke points were identified, with immediate instructions given to address them within strict timelines.

"These are not small

issues. A partially cleaned drain or a blocked outlet is enough to disrupt an entire stretch. The focus right now is to remove every such weak point before the rains test the system," the minister said.

Particular attention was given to low-lying areas and underpasses, where even short spells of heavy rain can lead to water accumulation and traffic disruption. Officials were directed to ensure that these locations remain fully functional during peak rainfall.



Gupta launches civic improvement works

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Legislative Assembly Speaker Vijender Gupta on Saturday laid the foundation stone for a series of civic improvement works in Rohini, aimed at delivering visible and tangible change at the grassroots level.

"Local infrastructure must deliver visible and tangible change on the ground. Roads, water supply and sanitation are central to dignified urban living and must be strengthened with clarity and urgency," Gupta said while inaugurating the projects.

The initiatives, with a total estimated cost of ₹50 lakhs, cover Sectors 7 and 8, including Naharpur Village. The works focus on constructing new lanes, replacing old water pipelines, and upgrading sewer and drainage systems to address long-pending demands of residents.

In sector 8, construction of new lanes across multiple residential pockets to improve internal connectivity, reconstruction of drains in Pocket B4, redevelopment of RMC lanes in

Pocket A-1 and replacement of water pipelines in two drains in Pocket A-16 have been completed.

In Naharpur Village, renovation of sewer lines at two locations to enhance sanitation and drainage, replacement of water pipelines in drains at Pockets D12 and G22 for more reliable watersupply in sector 7.

Speaking on the occasion, Gupta emphasised that sustained focus on neighbourhood-level infrastructure is essential for meaningful and inclusive development.

"Targeted improvements in roads, water systems and sanitation directly impact everyday life and must be implemented with efficiency and accountability," he added.

He stressed the need for timely execution so that these interventions translate into real benefits for residents and strengthen public trust in governance.

The projects are being executed in close coordination with local stakeholders to ensure they precisely meet on-ground requirements.

Police solve 1991 murder case, arrest absconding accused after 35 years

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Police cracked a 35-year-old murder case with the arrest of a proclaimed offender who allegedly killed his landlady and injured her son in a robbery case in 1991, an official said on Saturday.

The accused, identified as Chhavi Lal Verma. Police said that he deliberately avoided returning to his native place for years to evade arrest and also skipped major family events, including his children's marriages.

"The case dates back to August 2, 1991, when a PCR call was received regarding a

violent incident at West Vinod Nagar. A police team rushed to the spot and found the woman lying unconscious with multiple stab injuries on her neck, while her son, aged around 18-20 years at the time, had sustained stab wounds on his face," the police officer said.

Both victims were shifted to Lok Nayak Jai Prakash (LNJP) Hospital, where the woman succumbed to her injuries, while her son survived after treatment. During the investigation, it emerged that Verma, aged around 25 at the time of the incident, was a tenant in the victim's house in east Delhi's Trilok Puri area. He had



attacked the duo with a sharp-edged weapon, police said.

Police said he targeted the woman with the intention of robbery, believing that she possessed substantial cash as her husband was residing abroad. "When the landlady

and her son resisted, he attacked them repeatedly with a chopper and fled," the officer said.

Following the incident, Verma went into hiding and managed to evade arrest despite efforts by the local

police. He was eventually declared a proclaimed offender by a Delhi court on May 10, 1996. "The case remained pending for decades, with the accused successfully staying under the radar by constantly changing his identity and location," the officer said.

The breakthrough came when a team from the Crime Branch reopened the case and began fresh efforts to trace the accused. A dedicated team was tasked with tracking him down.

Over the past six months, the team worked meticulously, combining technical surveillance with field intelligence. "Officers revisited old

case records, tracked down past associates and conducted extensive inquiries in the accused's native village in Sultanpur in Uttar Pradesh as well as other locations linked to his relatives," the officer said. Despite multiple leads turning cold, the team persisted and developed fresh inputs regarding his possible whereabouts.

He is learnt to have moved across several cities, including Kolkata, Mumbai, Nagpur and Goa, before eventually settling in Punjab. During this period, he frequently changed jobs and identities, working in low-profile roles to avoid attracting attention.

Capital continues to see rise in temperature

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The National Capital continued to see a rise in the temperature on Saturday, with forecasts by the India Meteorological Department (IMD) suggesting a further rise in the coming days.

Safdarjung, representative of the city's weather, recorded a maximum temperature

of 34.7 degrees Celsius, 1.4 degrees below the normal and 1.9 degrees more than a day before. The minimum temperature was logged at 18.6 degrees Celsius, 2.4 degrees below normal but a 2.3 degree rise from the day before.

Other weather stations also logged a significant rise in both maximum and minimum temperatures. Palam recorded a maximum of 34.4 degrees Celsius, a 2.6-degree rise from Friday, and a minimum of 19.5 degrees Celsius, 3.9 degrees more than the day before. Lodhi Road recorded a minimum of 17.8 degrees



Celsius, a 2.6-degree rise from the day before.

Meanwhile, the IMD has forecast the minimum temperature to be around 18-20 degrees Celsius by Sunday and 20-22 degrees Celsius by Tuesday.

The maximum temperature is likely to be around 35-37 degrees by Sunday and 38-40 degrees Celsius by next Wednesday.

The Met department has

also forecast gusty winds of speed 15-25 kmph, even reaching 35 kmph, to continue through the daytime hours of Sunday.

Meanwhile, the city's air quality index (AQI) saw further improvement on Saturday morning. The 24-hour average AQI was recorded at 123 (moderate) at 4 pm, compared to an AQI of 151 (moderate) recorded at the same time on Friday.

The Pioneer Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, hitherto known as Dhirendra alias Dhirendra Kumar Mishra S/o Subodh Kumar Mishra R/o A-180, Kirari Village, Suleman Nagar, North West Delhi-110086 have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as Swtantra Mishra.

PD(842)C
I, Taran Singh S/o Tarsem Singh R/o IC/166 Namdhari Colony Kirti Nagar Delhi-110015 have changed my name to Taran Singh Rainu.

PD(843)C
I, Kaminee Das, Mother of No.8037603L Hav(GD) Salil Kumar Das, R/o- Vill & PO- Kakudibhag, Teh & Dist- Dhenkanal, Odisha- 759015, have changed my name from Kaminee Das to Kamini Das, vide affidavit dated 11/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(844)C

I, JC-706608X Sub Surendra Kumar Sharma, R/o- Vill & Post- Badounkalan, Teh & Dist- Datia, M.P.- 475685, declare that in my service documents, my Father's Name is wrongly written as Om Prakash, whereas his correct Name is Om Prakash Sharma, which may be amended accordingly.

PD(845)C
I, No.15586461A Hav Ishwarkar Subhash Nagorao, R/o- Siddivinayak Nagar, Ner, Yavatmal, Maharashtra- 445102, have changed my Daughter's name from Shreya to Shreya Subhash Ishwarkar, vide affidavit No. IN-DL92034226059913Y dated 11/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(846)C
I, Suman W/o Jitender Kumar, R/o C-70, C-block, Naya Bazar, Najafgarh, New Delhi-110043, have changed my name from Suman to Suman Kalkal for all future purposes.

PD(847)C

LOST & FOUND

To be known to all that I Rita Rani Kharbanda W/o Kanwal Kharbanda, R/o D-6/391/1 First Floor, Sector - 6, Rohini, Delhi - 110085 declare that I have Lost the Original Allotment Letter, and Original GPA, Agreement to Sell, Will, Receipt and Notary File Dated 04/08/1988 executed by Mr. Kishan Lal Mittal in favor of Mrs. Amarjeet Kaur while getting the same photocopied. An NCR in this effect has been lodged vide LR No. - 226214/2026 dated 11-04-2026 Finder Contact : 9871429215

ADMISSION NOTICE

IIM Ranchi invites applications from foreign citizens for its MBA/MBA-BA/MBA-HRM /IPM programmes. For more details and to apply visit <https://iimranchi.ac.in/admissions/>. Last date to apply: 17 May 2026 (at 2:00 PM IST).

www.iimranchi.ac.in
Prof. Dr. R. K. Singh, Director, IIM Ranchi
Prof. Dr. R. K. Singh, Director, IIM Ranchi
Prof. Dr. R. K. Singh, Director, IIM Ranchi

NORTHERN RAILWAY E-TENDER NOTICE

AMM/EMU/GZB acting for and on behalf of President of India invites E-Tender against Tender No. 46265133 The details are as under.

1	Name of Work	Rs. 5524524/-
2	Approx. cost of work	01 Set.
3	Quantity	
4	Last Date & Time of Submission of tender bid of tender	15.05.2026 (11:00 Hrs.)
5	Date & Time of Opening of tender document.	15.05.2026 (11:00 Hrs.)
6	Website particulars where complete details of tender documents can be seen	www.iimps.gov.in

Note: (i) The tenderers must be registered on the Indian Railways E-Procurement System (IREPS) site i.e. www.iimps.gov.in. (ii) Please refer to the tender document for all terms and conditions. (iii) No manual offers are acceptable. NIT No. - 46265133 Date: - 10-04-2026 1221/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

Khan Market set for overhaul, new 300-metre walkway planned

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi's Khan Market, one of the most happening places in South Delhi, famous for its super-expensive brand shops, multi-cuisine restaurants, super-hot pubs and lounges, is set for a makeover, with authorities planning a series of infrastructure upgrades aimed at improving pedestrian movement and reducing frequent disruptions in the high-footfall shopping hub.

The New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) is considering the development of a dedicated walkway along the cir-

cumference of the market, around 300 metres long, after completion of a pilot project currently underway on the front side of the market, they said.

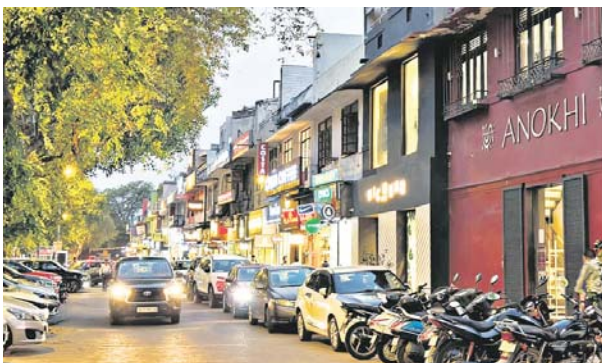
They added that on the front side of the market, granite cobblestones are also being laid, with the work expected to be completed within the next few weeks.

"The walkway is likely to be constructed using granite cobblestones or granite blocks at least 2.5 inches thick to ensure durability and ease of movement for visitors," officials said. "Khan Market is the 22nd most

expensive high street globally. It is not only a prime shopping destination but also a symbol of a high-end lifestyle in the heart of the Capital," he said.

NDMC Vice Chairman Kuljeet Singh Chahal said that the series of infrastructure improvements is expected to provide a better experience in the coveted market for shoppers and establish a new development model.

Officials said that alongside this, work is underway to upgrade the middle lane in a manner that would reduce the need for frequent road cutting in the future, partic-



ularly for utility services. The redesign is aimed at minimising disruptions to traders and shoppers, they said.

In addition, night-time washing and deep cleaning are being carried out regularly to maintain cleanliness in the market area.

The measures are aimed at

improving both the functionality and upkeep of the market while ensuring a smoother experience for visitors, they said.

Khan Market was established in 1951 and is among the most expensive rental spaces in the country, home to many popular eateries, bookstores and shopping outlets. The double-storey market complex originally had 154 shops and 74 flats on the first floor for shopkeepers.

Before independence, a barrack market used to exist on the site to cater to the needs of British soldiers. The market will celebrate its plat-

inum jubilee in another two years. The market is named after Khan Abdul Jabbar Khan, a Pashtun political leader and the brother of Khan Abdul Ghaffar Khan.

According to Cushman & Wakefield's 35th edition, Khan Market in New Delhi ranks 24th globally, maintaining its position as India's most expensive retail location with rents at USD 223 per square foot per year (psf/yr), up 3 per cent year-on-year. While its global ranking slipped slightly from 23rd to 24th, Khan Market remains India's most expensive high street, reflecting resilience

and enduring appeal amid a competitive global landscape.

London's New Bond Street, meanwhile, has been crowned the world's most expensive retail destination for the first time, where rents have risen by 22 per cent in the past year to USD 2,231 per square foot per year (psf/yr). New Bond Street has leapfrogged Milan's Via Montenapoleone (\$2,179 psf/yr), which last year became the first European street to top the global rankings, and New York's iconic Upper Fifth Avenue (\$2,000 psf/yr).

CM Rekha earmarks ₹3,954 crore for new electric vehicle policy

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Saturday earmarked a total outlay of ₹3,954.25 crore for the implementation of the new Electric Vehicle policy 2026. This comes after the unveiling of the draft Electric Vehicle (EV) Policy 2026 in the public domain, inviting suggestions and feedback from stakeholders and citizens within 30 days.

According to Rekha Gupta, this includes ₹1,236.25 crore for purchase incentives, ₹1,718 crore for scrapping incentives and ₹1,000 crore for charging infrastructure development.

Year-wise expenditure has also been outlined, with ₹965.5 crore planned for the first year, ₹1,012.75 crore for the second, ₹1,231.5 crore for the third and ₹744.5 crore for the fourth year.

The Chief Minister said an EV fund will be created to finance the policy, drawing from budgetary allocations, central and state schemes, environmental funds and other sources. An apex committee chaired by the transport minister will oversee

DELHI EV POLICY 2026: EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Financial Outlay & Allocation

Total Budget: 3,954.25 Crore

Category	Amount (in Crore)
Scrapping Incentives	1,718.00
Purchase Incentives	1,236.25
Charging Infrastructure	1,000.00

YEAR-WISE EXPENDITURE PLAN

■ Year 1

■ Year 2

■ Year 3

■ Year 4

₹965.5 crore

₹1,012.75 crore

₹1,231.5 crore

₹744.5 crore

MANDATORY ELECTRIFICATION DEADLINES

■ Jan 1, 2027: Only Electric 3-wheelers permitted for new registrations.

■ April 1, 2028: Only Electric 2-wheelers permitted for new registrations.

■ Jan 2026: No new conventional ICE (Petrol/Diesel) vehicles for fleet aggregators.

■ School Buses: 10% (Year 2) → 20% (Year 3) → 30% (by March 2030).

"The proposed Delhi EV Draft Policy 2026 is a significant step towards establishing a clean, accessible and sustainable transport system in the capital. Extensive financial incentives, tax exemptions, mandatory provisions and infrastructure development have been emphasised to promote electric vehicles in Delhi," the Chief Minister said.

She said that priority will also be given to electric vehi-

cles in the government fleet. After the policy notification, all vehicles hired or leased under GNCTD will be electric only, except for emergency or specially exempted vehicles.

Furthermore, all new interstate buses to be inducted by the Delhi Transport Corporation and the Transport Department will be electric.

A key feature of the draft is the phased introduction of

Draft EV policy: New projects by MCD, NDMC to be equipped for EV charging

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

All new infrastructure projects undertaken by urban local bodies, including MCD and NDMC, will be required to be equipped for electric vehicle charging, according to the draft EV Policy 2026 released on Saturday.

According to the draft policy, departments, autonomous bodies and civic agencies, including the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD), New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) and Delhi Cantonment Board, will have to ensure that new civil projects are EV-charging-ready, with adequate electrical capacity for installing charging infrastructure.

The policy also places responsibility on civic and land-owning agencies to

periodically identify suitable land parcels for setting up public charging and battery swapping stations and extend support for their planning and implementation. The move is aimed at expanding charging infrastructure alongside the expected rise in electric vehicle adoption in the city.

Separately, the draft policy proposes a wider framework for developing charg-

ing and battery swapping infrastructure, with Delhi Transco Limited designated as the nodal agency for planning and coordination.

The draft policy also provides for a single-window clearance system to facilitate faster approvals for setting up charging stations and related infrastructure.

As per the draft policy, Delhi Transco Limited has been designated as the

nodal agency responsible for planning, implementation, and grid integration of the charging and battery-swapping network.

The draft proposes a single-window clearance mechanism to fast-track approvals, a unified digital platform for infrastructure management, and coordinated planning with land-owning agencies and district authorities to ensure optimal rollout and grid readiness. The policy places strong emphasis on sustainable battery management.

The Delhi Pollution Control Committee will oversee the implementation of Extended Producer Responsibility (EPR) rules, battery collection systems, recycling frameworks, and safe disposal mechanisms.

Draft EV policy offers up to ₹1 lakh scrapping incentive on purchasing new electric car

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Residents of Delhi will get up to ₹1 lakh as a scrapping incentive on purchasing a new electric car in exchange for scrapping their old BS-IV and below vehicles, under the draft EV policy released by the city government.

According to the draft Delhi Electric Vehicle Policy 2026-2030, the incentive will be applicable if the purchase is made within six months of issuance of the Certificate of Deposit (CoD) from an authorised scrapping facility.

It stated that a scrapping incentive of ₹1,00,000 will be provided for the purchase of a new electric car, subject to an ex-factory price not exceeding ₹30 lakh.

The benefit will be available for the scrapping of Delhi-registered BS-IV and below cars and will be limited to the first 1,00,000 eligible applicants under the policy.

For electric four-wheeler goods carriers (N1 trucks), the policy proposes a scrapping

incentive of ₹50,000 under similar conditions, including scrapping of BS-IV and older vehicles and purchase within six months of CoD issuance. In the two-wheeler segment, a scrapping incentive of ₹10,000 has been proposed for those purchasing a new electric vehicle after scrapping Delhi-registered BS-IV and below two-wheelers.

Similarly, buyers of electric three-wheelers (L5M) will be eligible for a scrapping incentive of ₹25,000 under the same conditions.

The draft stated that all scrapping incentives will be disbursed through direct benefit transfer to individuals, who will have to apply for subsidy claims through a mechanism notified by the Transport Department.

NO NEW PETROL, DIESEL VEHICLES FOR AGGREGATORS FROM THIS YEAR

New Delhi: Petrol and diesel vehicles will no longer be added to delivery and ride aggregator fleets in Delhi from this year, while only electric auto-rickshaws will be allowed new registrations from 2027, according to the draft Electric Vehicle policy 2026 released by the city Government.

The draft Delhi Electric Vehicle Policy 2026-2030 proposes, "No conventional internal combustion engine (ICE) vehicles running purely on petrol or diesel shall be inducted into existing fleets of two-wheelers and light goods vehicles operated by aggregators and delivery service providers from January 1 this year."

However, induction of BS-VI emission standard two-wheelers will be permitted in aggregator fleets till December 31, 2026, after which a complete shift to electric vehicles will be mandatory.

The policy also outlines incentives for electric three-wheelers, including auto-rickshaws, with financial support of ₹50,000 in the first year from the date of notification of the new policy, ₹40,000 in the second year, and ₹30,000 in the third year, to promote EV adoption.

The incentive will be applicable to the replacement of old CNG auto-rickshaws as well as new auto-rickshaws registered in Delhi. In a parallel move targeting the public transport segment, the draft stated that from January 1, 2027, only electric three-wheelers, including auto-rickshaws, will be permitted for new registrations in the capital. The provisions are part of a broader push to prioritise high-usage vehicle segments such as two-wheelers, three-wheelers and goods carriers, which contribute significantly to vehicular emissions due to extensive daily operations.

OUR CENSUS

OUR DEVELOPMENT

(First Phase of Census 2027)

Common queries on Self-Enumeration (SE) and their Answers (Part-2)

WHAT IS SELF-ENUMERATION?

Self-Enumeration is an online process in which you fill and submit your household details on the SE portal (se.census.gov.in) yourself, without waiting for an enumerator

❖ What are the benefits of Self-Enumeration?

• Fill details conveniently

• Ensures privacy

• Makes the Census process faster and efficient

❖ How to log in to the Self-Enumeration portal?

• Select State/UT

• Enter name of head of the family, mobile number and email (optional)

• Verify through OTP

• Start Self-Enumeration

❖ How to mark the correct location of your house?

• Select district/PIN code

• Enter area/landmark

• Zoom on map and mark location near your house (Do not worry if exact address is not displayed)

• Correct location marking is necessary

❖ Can I edit my information later?

• Yes, you can edit before final submission during State/UT SE period

• After final submission changes can be done during enumerator's visit

❖ Can SE portal be accessed outside India?

No, this facility is available only within India's geographical boundaries

❖ What if an error is found after submission?

Correction can be made when the enumerator visits your house

❖ Can I save and complete the form later?

Yes, you can save progress and complete the form within the stipulated time

CBC 19108/13/0009/2627

TOLL FREE - 1855

Let us fulfill our responsibility, Let us participate in the Census

CensusIndia2027

IN FOCUS



People and children trying to walk amid a dust storm at the banks of the Sangam in Prayagraj, Uttar Pradesh

PTI

Major flight disruptions hit Ahmedabad Airport

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ahmedabad

Passengers faced major inconvenience at Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel International Airport on Sunday after widespread disruption to flight schedules triggered chaos at the terminal.

According to reports, around 15 flights were delayed, while a key international flight to Sharjah operated by SpiceJet was cancelled. Several domestic flights bound for metro cities such as Bengaluru, Chennai, Delhi, and Kolkata were also delayed for hours, leaving passengers stranded many of whom were travelling for business or emergency purposes.

Frustrated by the prolonged delays, poor management, and lack of clear communication from the



airline, passengers staged protests inside the airport and raised slogans against the authorities.

The cancellation of the Sharjah flight further worsened the situation, as travellers faced complications related to visas and connecting flights. The tense atmosphere at the airport prompted security personnel to intervene and bring the situation under control.

Indian LPG tanker crosses Strait of Hormuz after US-Iran Ceasefire

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India's LPG tanker Jag Vikram has successfully navigated the Strait of Hormuz, becoming one of the first Indian vessels to pass through the volatile corridor following a temporary ceasefire between the United States and Iran.

The crossing, completed between Friday night and Saturday morning, highlights both the fragility of maritime trade in the region and the global dependence on this narrow but vital oil and gas transit route.

Owned by The Great Eastern Shipping Company, Jag Vikram is among a small group of Indian-flagged vessels resuming movement from the Persian Gulf since early March, when escalating tensions had disrupted shipping and raised fears of a wider energy crisis.

The Strait of Hormuz, one of the world's most strategi-



cally important chokepoints, handles a significant share of global oil and gas shipments.

Any disruption in this passage has immediate ripple effects on international energy markets, supply chains, and prices.

For India—the world's third-largest energy consumer—the stakes are particularly high. A substantial

portion of its liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) and crude oil imports passes through this corridor, making safe navigation essential for maintaining both industrial activity and household energy access.

The temporary ceasefire between Washington and Tehran has offered a narrow window for shipping opera-

tions to resume, easing some of the pressure on global supply chains. The passage of Jag Vikram reflects a tentative return to normalcy, though risks remain elevated.

Industry observers note that while shipments have restarted, companies are continuing to monitor the situation closely, with insurance costs, rerouting decisions, and naval activity still influencing maritime operations.

Despite this breakthrough, the broader geopolitical environment remains uncertain. Any renewed escalation could once again threaten the flow of energy through the region, affecting not just India but economies worldwide. For now, the successful transit of Jag Vikram stands as a cautious but important step—one that underscores how closely global energy security is tied to stability in the Gulf.

PM Modi to address youth via video message at My Bharat Budget Quest 2026 in Jaipur

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Jaipur

Prime Minister Narendra Modi will address youth through a video message at 'My Bharat Budget Quest 2026' programme in Jaipur on April 13, an official said on Saturday.

Rajasthan Chief Minister Bhajanlal Sharma will also attend the event and interact with the winners of the programme, Additional Chief Secretary of the state sports department Praveen Gupta said.

The two-day 'Viksit Bharat Youth Dialogue' finale will be held at the Rajasthan International Centre (RIC) here on April 13, he said.

As part of the programme, a 'Women Youth Parliament' will be held on April 12 for women participants, while the evening will feature 'Sundays on Cycle'



event at Malaviya National Institute of Technology (MNIT), Jaipur, in collaboration with the Sports Authority of India to promote the message of "Fit India, Developed India", he said.

On April 13, the event will begin with an inaugural session followed by 'My Bharat sessions' and two expert panel discussions. The event will also be

attended by Rajasthan Governor Haribhau Bagade, Deputy Chief Ministers Diya Kumari and Prem Chand Bairwa, and Sports Minister Rajyavardhan Singh Rathore, along with other State ministers and senior officials.

'My Bharat Budget Quest 2026' (Zone 14 Rajasthan) saw participation of 75,591 youths from the state in an online quiz held between February 1 and February 22 this year. Of them, 3,453 participants moved to the essay stage, and around 984 were selected for the state-level Viksit Bharat Youth Dialogue, including 423 women and 561 men.

Additionally, 100 participants from each district will join virtually from various sectors including school education, higher education, startups, agriculture, and technology.

Undertrial inmate dies of burn injuries in jail, 3 officials suspended

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Pratapgarh (UP)

The Director General of Prisons has suspended three personnel, including a deputy jailor, following the death of an inmate at the district jail in Pratapgarh, a jail official said on Saturday.

The inmate died on Friday after sustaining burn injuries inside the prison under suspicious circumstances.

District Jail Superintendent Rishabh Dwivedi identified the deceased as Deepak alias Rahul, an undertrial prisoner from Unnao who was facing charges under rape and the POCSO. He has been in jail since November 1, 2025, following orders of a special POCSO court. The suspended personnel include deputy jailor Dhruv Narayan Srivastava, chief warder



(bandi rakshak) Akhilesh Singh, and another staff member, Prasad. The DIG (jails) has been directed to initiate a departmental inquiry.

"Prima facie, the incident appears to be a case of suicide. The inmate suffered critical burn injuries within the jail premises," Dwivedi

said, adding that the exact sequence of events would be established after a detailed investigation. The case against him had been registered at the Kandhai police station in Pratapgarh.

The body has been sent for postmortem examination, while a forensic team is conducting a probe.

Mukesh Ambani pledges ₹7 lakh crore investment as PM boosts Gujarat growth push

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gujarat

In a major boost to Gujarat's industrial and technological ambitions, Mukesh Ambani has announced an investment of ₹7 lakh crore to develop clean energy and artificial intelligence hubs in the State.

Meanwhile, Narendra Modi is set to visit Rajkot on Sunday to inaugurate the Vibrant Gujarat Regional Conference for the Kutch and Saurashtra regions at Marwadi University.

This conference is the second in a series of four regional meets aimed at decentralising the successful Vibrant Gujarat model and extending investment opportunities to 12 districts across Saurashtra and



Kutch. The initiative is aligned with the Centre's vision of "Viksit Bharat @2047" and seeks to promote global engagement and regional industrial growth.

During the visit, the Prime Minister will also launch several key infrastructure projects, including fourteen new greenfield smart industrial estates and a dedicated medical device park.

Yogi attacks Congress, SP; alleges both opposed CAA for appeasement politics

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Lakhimpur Kheri

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Saturday intensified his attack on Congress and Samajwadi Party (SP), alleging that both parties opposed the Citizenship (Amendment) Act as they believe in appeasement politics.

"When we celebrate the birth anniversary of the 'Iron Man,' Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel, the Samajwadi Party glorifies Jinnah, the very man who fractured this nation. When we call for unity, they commit the sin of tearing apart the social fabric of society through caste-based divisions," he said. Adityanath was speaking at an event in Miyanpur, where he distributed land



Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath during an event organised for the allocation of land rights pattas in Uttar Pradesh

PTI

ownership rights certificates to Hindu families displaced from Bangladesh.

"Now, no one can displace you from here, because Modi ji's Citizenship (Amendment) Act has bestowed these rights upon you. The Congress, the Samajwadi Party, and the TMC opposed this. They

argued that this law should not be enacted," Adityanath asserted. Highlighting the prolonged struggle that unfolded during 2019-20, Adityanath said that for months, the Congress, the SP, the TMC, and their supporters staged protests, creating obstacles to the implementation of this law.

Atrocities on women to end with BJP Govt in WB...

Targeting the ruling party over crimes against women, Modi promised that a BJP government in the state would reopen old cases. "We will reopen the files of every atrocity committed against women under the TMC rule. We will reopen the files of every rape case and ensure accountability in each. This is Modi's guarantee," he said. Referring to the rape and murder of a doctor at RG Kar Medical College and Hospital, Modi said the people of West Bengal, cutting across club loyalties, had united in protest.

"Mohun Bagan Super Giant and East Bengal fight on the field. But after the RG Kar incident, both stood shoulder to shoulder on the streets. In the same way, West Bengal must unite to teach the TMC government a lesson," he said.

Modi also accused the TMC of insulting President Droupadi Murmu during her recent visit to the state. "By insulting the honourable president, the TMC insulted women, tribals and the people of the country," he alleged. The prime minister said the BJP has "freed tribal communities from the menace of Maoism", accused the TMC of being "anti-tribal", and promised to remove infiltrators from the country. He also said refugees from the Matua and Namasudra communities would be granted citizenship under CAA. At the same time, women would get 33 per cent reservation in government jobs if the BJP comes to power in West Bengal. Urging voters to compare the tenure of different parties in the state, Modi said, "You gave the Left 35 years. You gave the TMC 15 years. Give Modi five years."

"Wherever there is a double-engine government, there is development," PM remarked.

Delhi Govt makes EV policy attractive with...

From January 1, 2027, only electric three-wheelers will be permitted for new registration in Delhi. This will be followed by a complete transition for two-wheelers, with only electric models allowed from April 1, 2028.

The policy also proposes exemption from road tax and registration fees for most electric vehicles registered in Delhi during the policy period. However, electric cars priced above ₹30 lakh will not be eligible for this benefit.

According to the draft policy, eligible two-wheeler buyers will receive ₹10,000 per kWh, capped at ₹30,000 in the first year, ₹6,600 per kWh, capped at ₹20,000 in the second year, and ₹3,300 per kWh, capped at ₹10,000 in the third year. The ex-factory price of the vehicle must not exceed ₹2.25 lakh to qualify.

To promote electric auto-rickshaws, the policy proposes incentives of Rs 50,000 in the first year, Rs 40,000 in the second year, and ₹30,000 in the third year. The benefit will be available for new registrations as well as the replacement of older CNG autos operating with Delhi permits. In the goods vehicle category, electric four-wheeler e-trucks (N1) may get incentives of up to ₹1 lakh in the first year, followed by ₹75,000 and ₹50,000 in the second and third year, respectively. According to the draft EV Policy 2026, incentives will be disbursed through direct benefit transfer to individuals, firms and com-

FROM PAGE - 1

panies, provided they are residents of Delhi and the vehicle is registered in the national capital. Eligible buyers will have to apply for the subsidy through a mechanism to be notified by the Transport Department.

The policy proposes 100% exemption from road tax and registration fees for electric vehicles registered in Delhi during the policy period. Electric cars priced up to ₹30 lakh will be eligible for full exemption until March 2030, while strong hybrid vehicles will receive a 50% concessions well, a provision that is being introduced. Vehicles priced above ₹30 lakh will not be eligible for such benefits.

Deported gangster back in police custody

"It was a brazen incident in his criminal history when he allegedly opened fire on rival gangster Monu Rana inside the Jagadhari court complex. Monu Rana had been produced in court for a hearing in pending cases when the attack took place amid escalating gang rivalry.

Haryana Police investigated the case and filed a charge sheet and Chauhan were sentenced to 10 years' imprisonment. However, he was released on bail and subsequently fled the country and evaded arrest for years. Haryana Police had then approached the CBI to issue the Interpol Red Notice.

Chauhan is also wanted by the National Investigation Agency (NIA) in connection with multiple investigations and for running extortion rackets targeting individuals and businesses in

Haryana and Punjab, despite hiding in Bangkok. His deportation marks a major blow to organised crime networks operating from foreign safe havens, the police sources said.

Investigations are expected to intensify into his overseas links, accomplices and ongoing criminal activities. This operation underscores the growing effectiveness of India's 'Bharatpol' initiative and Interpol coordination in tracking fugitives. With Chauhan back in custody, the law enforcement agencies hope to dismantle remaining pockets of the Bhupi Rana and associated gangs that have long terrorised the tri-state region. Further interrogations are underway to uncover the full extent of his network.

Face-to-face, US-Iran talk truce

Islamabad-based sources indicated that the first phase of meetings "went well". They suggested that another round of discussions has been tentatively scheduled for the coming days, although official confirmation is still awaited. On the Iranian side, a delegation of more than 70 officials is participating, led by Parliament Speaker Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf and Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi, along with representatives from key national security and foreign policy institutions. Iranian officials also held preparatory meetings with Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif before the talks.

Tensions remain high over maritime security, with reports from the Financial Times indicating that negotiators have reached a stalemate over the Strait of Hormuz, a critical

global shipping chokepoint.

Adding to the regional sensitivities, the US Central Command confirmed that two US Navy guided-missile destroyers — the USS Frank E. Petersen and USS Michael Murphy — had transited the Strait of Hormuz. CENTCOM said the move was intended to ensure the waterway remains clear of sea mines allegedly laid by Iran. CENTCOM commander Admiral Brad Cooper stated, "Today, we began the process of establishing a new passage, and we will share this safe pathway with the maritime industry soon to encourage the free flow of commerce."

International reactions have continued to emerge as the talks unfold. French President Emmanuel Macron said he had spoken with Iranian President Pezeshkian, urging Tehran to "seize the opportunity" to de-escalate tensions and restore freedom of navigation in key maritime routes, including the Strait of Hormuz.

Despite deep mistrust and unresolved disputes, the ongoing negotiations are being viewed as one of the most significant diplomatic engagements between Washington and Tehran in decades, with cautious hopes that sustained dialogue could help reduce regional tensions. India has previously welcomed the ceasefire talks between the United States and Iran and is closely monitoring developments in the West Asia conflict.

Officials are said to be tracking the situation in real time, given the potential implications for regional stability, energy security, and maritime trade routes. New Delhi is expected to continue observing the outcome of the negotiations closely as the dialogue progresses in Islamabad.

2.04 crore voters deleted from Uttar Pradesh's electoral rolls after SIR

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Lucknow

More than 2.04 crore voters have been removed from Uttar Pradesh's electoral rolls following the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) exercise, with deletions largely concentrated in urban centres and a higher proportion involving women voters.

Over 84 lakh new voters were added, taking the final electorate to 13,39,84,792, according to data released by the Election Commission of India (ECI).

The final electoral roll comprises 7,30,71,071 male electors (around 54 per cent), 6,09,09,525 female voters (45.46 per cent), and 4,206 third gender voters.

The gender ratio improved to 834 female voters per 1,000 male voters from 824 in the draft roll, though it declined from 877 before the SIR due to higher deletions among women.

The number of voters aged 18-19 rose sharply to 17,63,360 — an increase of 14,29,379 compared to the draft roll — accounting for 1.32 per cent of the electorate. The state had 15.44 crore voters in the rolls frozen on October 27, 2025.

This dropped to 12,55,56,025 in the draft electoral roll published on January 6, including 6.88 crore male, 5.67 crore female and 4,119 third gender voters.

After the claims and objections process, the final roll saw a net increase of 84,28,767 voters compared to the draft list. This included an increase of 42,27,902 male voters, 42,00,778 female voters and 87 third gender voters.

Among districts, Lucknow recorded the highest decline in voters in absolute terms (over 9.14 lakh), followed by Prayagraj (over



8.26 lakh), Kanpur Nagar (over 6.87 lakh), Agra (over 6.37 lakh) and Ghaziabad (over 5.74 lakh).

In percentage terms, Lucknow (22.89 per cent), Ghaziabad (around 20 per cent) and Kanpur Nagar (19.42 per cent) were among the worst affected. Urban constituencies saw the sharpest declines, with Lucknow Cantonment recording the highest drop at 34.18 per cent, followed by Allahabad North (34.01 per cent).

At the assembly constituency level, other urban segments such as Lucknow East, Lucknow North and Agra Cantonment also saw contractions of around 30 per cent or more.

In contrast, constituencies like Mehroni, Barkhera, Kundarki, Tindwari and Sirsaganj registered minimal changes, with reductions ranging between roughly 4-5 per cent.

According to the ECI data, more women voters were deleted than men during the draft stage, contributing to the dip in the gender ratio. Districts such as Hamirpur, Mahoba, Lalitpur, Chitrakoot and Shravasti recorded the lowest deletions, with each reporting significantly smaller reductions compared to larger urban centres.

At the constituency level, Sahibabad, Noida, Lucknow North, Agra Cantonment and Allahabad North saw the highest deletions, while Barkhera, Tindwari, Sirsaganj, Kundarki and Mehroni had the least.



PM Modi, Rahul interaction draws attention at Mahatma Phule event

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

A brief conversation initiated by Prime Minister Narendra Modi with Congress leader Rahul Gandhi drew attention during a commemorative event for renowned social reformer Jyotirao Phule at the Parliament House complex on Saturday.

The interaction stood out as the two leaders are rarely seen speaking to each other beyond exchanging pleasantries at such public events.

When the prime minister arrived to pay floral tributes at the statue of Phule on the occasion of his birth anniversary, several dignitaries, including Gandhi, the Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha, were standing in a row.

After greeting everyone with folded hands, Modi stopped near Gandhi and started talking to him.

Though it was not immediately known what they spoke about during their minute-long exchange, Gandhi was seen replying and nodding to



VP CP Radhakrishnan, PM Modi, Congress MP and Lok Sabha LoP Rahul Gandhi and others during the 200th birth anniversary celebration of Mahatma Jyotiba Phule at the Parliament premises on Saturday

Modi on a few occasions.

Gandhi was flanked by Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla, Union ministers JP Nadda, Virendra Kumar and Arjun Ram Meghwal, outgoing Deputy Chairman of Rajya Sabha and newly nominated Rajya Sabha MP Harivansh, among others.

The brief conversation also drew speculation on social media.

After paying tributes, Modi wrote on 'X': "Paid homage to Mahatma Phule in the Parliament complex. May his ideals continue to give strength and hope to countless people".

Prime Minister Modi described Phule as a visionary social reformer who dedicated his life to the ideals of equality, justice and education.

"He was also a pioneer in championing the rights of women and the marginalised. Through his efforts, education became a powerful instrument of empowerment," Modi said in another post.

The prime minister said this year marks the start of Phule's 200th birth anniversary celebrations.

"May his thoughts continue to guide everyone in the pursuit of societal progress," he said.

In a post, Gandhi said: "On the birth anniversary of the great social reformer Mahatma Jyotiba Phule ji, I offer my humble homage to him".

"He dedicated his entire life to protecting the rights and entitlements of the marginalised. His struggle against discrimination and inequality showed the nation the path to equality and justice. "His ideals and thoughts will forever continue to inspire us to move forward towards social justice," Gandhi said.

Punjab Govt nod to amended sacrilege law

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Chandigarh

The Punjab Cabinet on Saturday approved stringent amendments to the law on sacrilege to make punishments more severe, including life imprisonment.

The Cabinet in a meeting, chaired by Chief Minister Bhagwant Singh Mann, cleared the Jaagat Jot Sri Guru Granth Sahib Satkar (Amendment) Bill, 2026, which proposes enhanced penalties, including life imprisonment, to deter incidents of 'beadbi' (sacrilege) and uphold the sanctity of Guru Granth Sahib.

According to an official statement, the move comes in view of past incidents of sacrilege that have hurt public sentiments and disturbed communal harmony.

It noted that existing provisions under the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023 do not provide sufficiently stringent punishment.

The amended sacrilege law will be introduced in the Assembly on Monday.

"There have been several



Punjab CM Bhagwant Singh Mann

incidents in the past involving 'beadbi' of Sri Guru Granth Sahib and other holy scriptures, which have deeply hurt public sentiments by bruising their psyche and caused unrest in society.

"While Sections 298, 299, and 300 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), 2023 do address such matters, they do not prescribe sufficiently stringent punishments to serve as a strong deterrent against such acts," said a spokesperson of the chief minister's office.

States Focus



AIKS warns India-US trade talks may hurt farmers

The All India Kisan Sabha (AIKS) on Saturday warned that the ongoing India-US trade negotiations could open the farm sector to imports and hurt domestic cultivators. It renewed demands for a legal Minimum Support Price (MSP) guarantee, loan waivers and safeguards against land acquisition. Addressing the AIKS 90th anniversary event, senior CPI(M) leader Prakash Karat said the AIKS had grown into the country's largest farmers' organisation and had played a historic role from the freedom movement onwards, mobilising peasants against British colonial rule and feudal forces. "From the freedom struggle onwards, the Kisan Sabha has consistently raised the basic issues of farmers – land, remunerative prices and debt relief," he said.



LDF set to retain power in Kerala, says Prakash Karat

Veteran CPI(M) leader Prakash Karat on Saturday expressed confidence that the Left Democratic Front (LDF) would retain power in Kerala, saying early reports from the polling process indicated a favourable outcome for the alliance. Asked about the recently held Assembly polls in the State, Karat expressed optimism. "Kerala polling has been over, and all the reports indicate that the LDF has done well, and we expect the LDF Government to come back," Karat said. Polling for the single-phase Kerala Legislative Assembly election was held on April 9 after an intense and closely fought campaign between the CPI(M)-led LDF and the Congress-led United Democratic Front (UDF), with both sides engaging in a high-decibel contest across the State.

UCC is threat to tribal identity in MP, alleges Congress



Leader of the Opposition in Madhya Pradesh Assembly Umang Singh

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Bhopal

The Congress on Saturday expressed concern over the ruling BJP's plan to implement a Uniform Civil Code (UCC) in Madhya Pradesh, saying it could pose a serious threat to the identity, traditions and constitutional rights of the tribal community.

Umang Singh, the Leader of the Opposition in the State Assembly and the Congress's tribal face in MP, also accused the Government of trying to impose the UCC in haste, without holding any dialogue and without following the democratic process, which reflects the BJP's "intolerant mindset".

India is a country of diversity where tribal communities have lived for centuries with their distinct cultural heritage, traditions and social systems, he said.

"Imposing a uniform law in such a context would not

only disrespect their traditions but also violate their rights," he said in a statement.

During a Cabinet meeting held on Tuesday, Chief Minister Mohan Yadav asked ministers to study the UCC before its implementation in the State.

The MP home department has since initiated the process, as it is responsible for preparing the UCC bill, sources said.

If the Government has its way, it might bring the bill before Diwali, they added.

According to them, a high-level committee will soon be constituted at the State level.

The BJP Government in Uttarakhand has already enforced the UCC in that State on January 27. The Gujarat Assembly passed it last month. One of the BJP's poll promises in the West Bengal elections is rolling out the UCC within six months after forming the Government.

Women's quota should not be used as political tool: Tharoor

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Ahead of the special three-day Parliament session when the women's reservation law is expected to be amended, Congress leader Shashi Tharoor on Saturday said the proposed amendments should not be a political tool that undermines federalism and vitiates the vitality of Parliament.

In a post on X, he alleged that the Government is convening a "special session" to derive political mileage ahead of State polls with an

eye on delimitation before the 2029 general elections.

He also asserted that Congress is committed to a one-third reservation for women, but the same should be inclusive and fair.

Sharing his pictures at the Congress Working Committee (CWC), which met on Friday to take a stand on the proposed amendments to the women's reservation law (Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam), he said, "While the Congress has always championed the 33 per cent quota, and the first to introduce a Bill and pass



it in the Rajya Sabha in 2013, the current Government's approach raises serious alarms."

The meeting came days ahead of the three-day sitting of Parliament, during which the Government will bring

Ladakh to build memorial for Kargil hero Sonam Wangchuk

MOHIT KANDHARI ■ Jammu

The Union Territory administration in Ladakh, headed by Lieutenant Governor Vinai Kumar Saxena, has decided to dedicate a befitting memorial in the memory of a decorated Kargil War hero, Colonel (Retd) Sonam Wangchuk, also known as the 'Lion of Ladakh'.

Recipient of India's second-highest wartime gallantry award, Colonel (Retd) Wangchuk died of cardiac arrest at 61 at his residence in Leh on Friday. Colonel (Retd) Wangchuk is survived by his wife and son. According to the close family members, Colonel (Retd) Wangchuk was complaining of chest pain and had undergone some investigations at the Army Hospital in

Leh. He was scheduled to undergo a few other investigations, but before that, he suffered a cardiac arrest and apparently died during sleep.

The office of LG, Ladakh, on Saturday posted on X, "In honour of the Lion of Ladakh, Late Colonel Sonam Wangchuk, MVC, UT administration will dedicate a befitting memorial at Leh, in consultation with the family, Army and local representatives".

"The memorial will stand as an enduring symbol of Ladakhi valour and pride. His bravery shall continue to inspire generations to come".

During the 1999 Kargil War, Major Sonam Wangchuk was tasked with securing Chorbat La and establishing an observation post under extreme weather conditions.



Colonel (Retd) Sonam Wangchuk

On May 30, 1999, Major Wangchuk led his small team from the front through deep snow and hostile terrain. His swift and determined action

caught the enemy by surprise, resulting in the neutralisation of their troops and forcing them to retreat. His gallant action set the

stage for several other successful operations during Operation Vijay. Major Wangchuk also earned Maha Vir Chakra, and the two posts in the sector, 'Sonam 1' and 'Sonam 2', were named after him by the Indian Army in recognition of his valour.

According to the Additional Directorate General of Public Information, IHQ of MoD (Army), Colonel Sonam Wangchuk (Retd) displayed indomitable courage, gallantry and exceptional leadership while leading his team amidst intense enemy firing to clear the Chorbatla Axis up to LoC during Operation Vijay.

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh also expressed grief at the passing of Maha Vir Chakra awardee Colonel

Sonam Wangchuk (Retd), a braveheart of the 1999 Kargil war.

In a post on X, Singh paid tribute to Colonel Wangchuk, describing him as a highly decorated officer of the Indian Army, renowned for his gallantry, resolute leadership and unwavering commitment to duty, according to a release from the Ministry of Defence.

Chief Executive Councillor, Ladakh Autonomous Hill Development Council, Kargil, Dr Mohd Jaffer Akhoun, also expressed deep condolences over the demise of Colonel Sonam Wangchuk, Maha Vir Chakra awardee & hero of the Kargil War. He said Colonel Wangchuk's bravery and service to the nation will remain an inspiration for generations.

Delay in J&K statehood restoration unacceptable: Congress

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Srinagar

The Congress on Saturday termed the "prolonged delay" in restoring statehood for Jammu and Kashmir as unacceptable and said the party would continue its fight to safeguard people's rights.

The Jammu and Kashmir Pradesh Congress Committee (JKPCC) held a review meeting



Tariq Hameed Karra

at its office, attended by coordinators and district presidents from across Kashmir. The meeting was chaired by JKPCC president Tariq Hameed Karra.

Karra reviewed feedback on ongoing party activities in various districts. The party's indigenous programme - Hamari Riyasat Hamara Haq, launched to press for restoration of statehood — also figured in the discussions.

ED conducts raid at former-Bengal minister Partha Chatterjee's home

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kolkata/New Delhi

An Enforcement Directorate team on Saturday conducted a five-hour raid at former West Bengal education minister Partha Chatterjee's residence in connection with the school jobs scam, ED officials said.

The agency team searched his home ahead of the assembly elections to be held on April 23 and 29.

ED officials reached Chatterjee's house in the Naktala area around 10.45 am after central forces cordoned off the premises.

The central agency also questioned him, an ED official said.

The team, including a woman official, left the residence at 4:30 pm, but did not talk to the waiting media persons on the nearby road.

The former minister did not come out of his residence to meet the media despite requests.

Chatterjee was released on bail on November 11, 2025, after spending over three years (39 months) in custody following his arrest by the ED on July 23, 2022, in connection with the scam.



Former West Bengal education minister Partha Chatterjee

He had secured conditional bail from the Supreme Court in the CBI-probed case in August 2025 and subsequently in other related cases before being released from judicial custody. He had undergone treatment at a private hospital in Kolkata before his release.

The raid was necessitated as Chatterjee did not respond to three summons for questioning before the ED, after his release on bail, in connection with the recruitment scam of the West Bengal Central School Service Commission (SSC).

A second team of the agency conducted a simul-

taneous search at the Rajarhat office of another accused, Prasanna Kumar Roy, whom the ED described as a middleman to the court in the multicrore job scandal.

The investigation began with ED raids on July 22-23, 2022, at his Naktala residence and the premises of his close associate, Arpita Mukherjee.

During these raids, over Rs 50 crore in cash and gold jewellery were seized from Mukherjee's two flats, and both Chatterjee and Mukherjee were arrested.

Chatterjee was accused of being the "mastermind" in the multi-crore scam involv-

ing illegal appointments of teachers and non-teaching staff (Group C & D) in Government-aided schools while serving as the State's education minister.

His bail conditions included surrendering his passport and not leaving the jurisdiction of the trial court.

Following the arrest, he was stripped of his cabinet portfolios and suspended from the Trinamool Congress (TMC).

He was not renominated from his Behala Paschim seat for the 2026 Assembly polls by the TMC, from where he was the sitting MLA for four terms since 2006.

Kisan in me has not died: Rajnath vows more agriculture support

LAXMI DEVI AERE ■ Raissen

Union Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Saturday pledged that the shortage of funds would not come in the way of doing more for the agriculture sector, saying the Government's efforts to transform the lives of farmers were not enough and that there was a need to do even more.

Addressing the three-day Unnat Krishi Mela, Singh said the Government had launched several schemes — PM-Kisan, Pradhan Mantri Fasal Bima Yojana, Soil Health Card and an online network of wholesale mandis — to boost farmers' income and farm productivity. "These efforts have transformed the lives of farmers. But I believe the change is not enough. There is a need to do even more for the agriculture sector and our villages," he said, adding, "We will not be worried about funds. The shortage of funds will not be an obstacle. I want to assure you this."

Reflecting on his political journey, Singh said the farmer in him had never left despite holding several ministerial portfolios. "In my political life, I have been Agriculture Minister in the past. Wherever



Defence Minister Rajnath Singh, Union Agriculture and Farmers Welfare Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan and MP CM Mohan Yadav during Unnat Krishi Mahotsav in Raissen, Madhya Pradesh on Saturday

I have gone, the kisan in me has been alive," he said.

"Usually, people see a defence minister as responsible for soldiers and the country's security, not agriculture. Our responsibility is to ensure the country's security, but the kisan in me has not gone away," he added.

Underlining his concern for farmers, Singh said the defence ministry had begun procuring organic fresh vegetables and fruits directly from farmers for canteen areas.

"Vegetables, fruits and other produce were earlier being brought from far away, losing freshness in transit. Now we are buying organic produce from farmers," he said, noting the move would

fetch farmers better prices while also benefiting soldiers.

The defence ministry, he said, is also promoting millets - shree anna - such as jowar and ragi, along with organic produce, through its canteen stores department.

Singh said the Government is acting on the 'Jai Jawan Jai Kisan' slogan by promoting millet in the armed forces to strengthen farmers economically.

"Flours made from jowar, bajra and ragi have been introduced in the armed forces. By our efforts, we are again acting upon the slogan 'Jai Jawan-Jai Kisan'," said Singh, who was Union minister for agriculture in 2003-2004 in the Atal Bihari Vajpayee Government.



States Focus



ECI REPLACES TN HOME SECRETARY DHEERAJ KUMAR

The ECI on Saturday ordered the transfer of Tamil Nadu Home Secretary Dheeraj Kumar and appointed K Manivasan in his place. The 1993 batch IAS officer Manivasan has been directed to join immediately. Further, the release from the Election Commission of India said Kumar should not be posted in any election-related posts till the completion of elections. Earlier, the ECI ordered the transfer of Tamil Nadu Chief Secretary N Muruganandam and appointed senior IAS officer M Sai Kumar in his place. Similarly, the ECI ordered the transfer of Greater Chennai Police Commissioner AArun, replacing him with the 1997 batch IPS officer Abhin Dinesh.



PHULE'S STRUGGLE SHOWED PATH TO EQUALITY: RAHUL

Congress leaders Mallikarjun Kharge and Rahul Gandhi on Saturday paid tributes to social reformer Jyotirao Phule on his 199th birth anniversary and said his struggle against discrimination and inequality showed the nation the path towards equality and justice. Phule was born on April 11, 1827, in Maharashtra and died on November 28, 1890. "On the birth anniversary of the great social reformer Mahatma Jyotiba Phuleji, I offer my humble salutations to him. "He dedicated his entire life to protecting the rights and entitlements of the marginalised. His struggle against discrimination and inequality showed the nation the path to equality and justice," Gandhi said in a post on X.

38 global delegates praise India's election precision, transparency

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

As many as 38 delegates from 22 countries praised the conduct of polls in India after witnessing firsthand the scale, precision, and vibrancy of India's electoral process during the April 9 Assembly elections in Kerala, Puducherry, and Assam. The delegates began their visit by inspecting dispatch and distribution centres.

They observed how polling teams and materials were moved using standard procedures and planned logistics. They also met chief electoral officers and police officials to understand election management and security arrangements. At the control rooms, they reviewed the system of 100 per cent web-casting of polling stations, which they described as important for transparency.

On polling day, April 9, the delegates first watched mock polls and then visited polling stations in Kamrup (Metro and Rural) in Assam, Kochi and Thiruvananthapuram



in Kerala, and parts of Puducherry.

They observed the voting process and interacted with voters and polling staff. Delegates saw arrangements such as ramps, wheelchairs, volunteers and crèche facilities at polling stations. They also visited booths managed entirely by women and persons with disabilities. Many described the arrangements as inclusive and well-organised.

"We are very impressed with how the polling stations have been organised, the facilities have been prepared very well, wheelchair,

creche facilities," Paulus Shigwedha, from Namibia, said. Branimir Farkas from Croatia said, "Indian voting... is a true festival of democracy for the whole world... what is overwhelming for me is the enthusiasm of people to vote. We can only learn from this process; it's a huge process and done right."

Uuc-Kib Espadas Ancona from Mexico said, "The process of election in India is certainly a place to learn."

The teams visited district media monitoring centres and reviewed election oversight systems. They also saw the use of electronic voting

machines (EVMs) and continuous monitoring through webcasting.

"One of the great things about India is use of EVMs... some of the things that we have learnt we will be able to take home and see how we could implement it, it's like a festival, this should be the spirit," Abubakarr Mahmoud Koroma, from Sierra Leone, said.

In Puducherry, delegates observed additional measures like drone monitoring and flying squads. In Kerala, they visited a Gen Z-themed polling booth.

In rural Assam, they noted health check-up facilities at polling stations. Delegates said they were impressed by voter participation and the smooth conduct of polling. Several described the process as a "festival of democracy" and said there were lessons other countries could learn.

According to the Election Commission of India, 38 delegates took part in the International Election Visitors' Programme (IEVP) 2026.

Rekha Gupta slams Mamata over lawlessness in Bengal



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Raniganj/Galsi (West Bengal)

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Saturday addressed public meetings in Raniganj and Galsi in West Bengal, campaigning in support of BJP candidates. She said the large turnout at both rallies clearly indicated that people in the State have made up their minds to move on from what she described as corruption, appeasement and lawlessness under the leadership of Mamata Banerjee.

Taking a swipe at the ruling dispensation, the chief minister said it was ironic that a State which gave the country the national anthem and 'Vande Mataram' was now "reduced to a system of cut-money and syndicates". She framed the election as more than a political contest, calling it a decisive moment to restore Bengal's lost pride and realise the vision of 'Sonar Bangla'.

She said the election was not just about a change in power, but about dignity, safety and a better future for the youth. Accusing the current Government of failing young people, she claimed that even deserving candidates were struggling to find jobs while corrupt practices were being

allowed to flourish. Referring to the slogan 'Maa, Maati, Manush', she alleged that today neither women feel safe, nor land is free from mafias, nor do people receive their due rights.

In Raniganj, she raised concerns about alleged mafia control over coal mines, saying strict action was needed against those exploiting workers' earnings. In Galsi, she outlined a roadmap focused on development, employment, education and healthcare, promising balanced and faster growth if the BJP comes to power.

During her visit to Raniganj, the Chief Minister also interacted with local women to understand their concerns. Members from various women's groups flagged issues of rising crime, insecurity and corruption.

The chief minister sharply criticised the State Government over crimes against women, saying that if daughters continue to live in fear despite having a woman Chief Minister, it raises serious questions about governance.

She assured that no responsible Government can compromise on women's safety and promised dignity, security and empowerment for women under a BJP Government.

BJP, NDA will come to power in Bengal, Assam, Puducherry, Tamil Nadu: Athawale

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Hyderabad

RPI (Athawale) president and Union Minister Ramdas Athawale on Saturday expressed confidence that BJP and NDA would come to power in West Bengal, Assam, Puducherry and Tamil Nadu, while the NDA had a favourable atmosphere in Kerala as well.

Alleging that law and order has failed in West Bengal, including a rise in crimes against women, he said people are disappointed with the Trinamool Congress Government.

"We are confident that the BJP Government will come this time. Goodbye to Mamata Didi is certain. Our



Government would also come in Assam and Pondicherry. In Tamil Nadu, the NDA can come to power. Such an atmosphere is there. I had gone there twice or thrice," Athawale, Union MoS

(Social Justice and Empowerment), told reporters.

In Kerala, people want a change from LDF and UDF, and the NDA is likely to make major gains, he said.

Observing that Prime Minister Narendra Modi took the revolutionary step to provide 33 per cent reservation to women, Athawale said, during the special session of parliament next week, the number of Lok Sabha seats would rise to 816, with 273 reserved for women.

SC and ST women will have reservations in the 273 seats, he said.

The move to provide women's reservation would empower women of the country, ensuring social, economic and political justice, he added.

100% mapping of voters need of hour: Maharashtra CEO

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Thane

Maharashtra Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) S Chockalingam has said 100 per cent mapping of voters was the need of the hour in order to bring transparency and accuracy in the election process, and admitted that the State was somewhat lagging behind on this front.

He was addressing a 'Special In-depth Review' meeting held in Thane on Friday.

"To bring transparency and accuracy in the voting process, 100 per cent mapping of voter lists is the need of the hour. The administrative system should work with dedication to cross the 'magic figure' of 90 to 94 per cent," he said, according to a release issued by the Thane district administration on



Maharashtra CEO S Chockalingam

Saturday. He said Maharashtra was somewhat lagging behind other States in voter list mapping, with districts like Thane and Palghar requiring faster progress.

The Special Intensive Revision (SIR)

of voter rolls is set to begin across Maharashtra this month for updating electoral data for error-free rolls.

The CEO stressed the need for a combination of technology and fieldwork, directing booth-level officers (BLOs) and electoral staff to undertake door-to-door verification and maintain geo-tagged photographic records to ensure transparency.

"Mapping voters with earlier electoral rolls and verifying their original residence is the backbone of this campaign," he said, adding that notices should be pasted outside houses of unavailable voters and documented. Highlighting issues, such as duplicate entries and unclear photographs, Chockalingam said officials must take corrective action to eliminate discrepancies.

BJP using women's quota as weapon against Opposition: Stalin

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Chennai

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister MK Stalin has said that his party-led alliance will win over 200 seats in the April 23 Assembly polls, and launched a blistering attack on his rival Edappadi K Palaniswami and the BJP on a number of issues, particularly accusing the saffron party of trying to use the women's quota as a "weapon" against the opposition.

In an interview, the 73-year-old DMK president also responded to Palaniswami's "power centre" jibe thrown at his family, and declared that



TN CM and DMK candidate from Kolathur constituency, Stalin, during a voter outreach ahead of State Assembly polls in Pudukkottai on Saturday

his Government's initiatives, such as a women's rights scheme (₹1000 per month), which is being replicated in other States in the country, will go down in history as a very important programme.

Regarding the ₹8,000 coupon scheme for purchasing home appliances, he called it the "election superstar".

Under the scheme, women could buy their chosen products from the

shops they wished. He added that it would help improve living standards and strengthen the local economy. When the Women's Rights Scheme, providing monthly assistance of ₹1,000, was implemented, several people raised questions.

However, several States implemented this scheme, and other States facing elections have also assured that this initiative will be implemented. "Now, we will successfully implement the Illatharasi Scheme also. It provides ₹8,000 coupon to beneficiaries. Like the Women's Rights Scheme, this initiative will also be emulated by States across

the country."

Stalin also dismissed the Enforcement Directorate's allegations on TASMAC, sandmining scams as "Centre produced, ED-enacted dramas," and charged that the central agency has been turned "servile."

"The Union Government is not concerned about implementing reservations for women. If their concerns were genuine, they could have done it right away. Rather than doing that, the BJP-led Centre is thinking of using it as a weapon to tackle opposition and take up the delimitation exercise based on population," he said.

BJP tried to invalidate my candidature in Bhabanipur: Mamata

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Kolkata

West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee on Saturday claimed that the BJP tried to get her candidature from the Bhabanipur seat in south Kolkata cancelled by attempting to file two false cases against her, but the bid was foiled by TMC workers and the public.

Banerjee, while addressing an election rally at Keshiyari in Paschim Medinipur district, accused the BJP of "forcefully" deleting the names of 90 lakh voters from the electoral

rolls during the Special Intensive Revision (SIR).

"The BJP, with the ECI's help, tried to invalidate my candidature from Bhabanipur yesterday by trying to file two false affidavits against me, but we foiled their game plan," Banerjee, who is contesting against Leader of Opposition Suwendu Adhikari to retain her seat, said without elaborating further.

She accused the BJP of "plotting to forcefully capture votes through fraudulent means as they don't have the guts to fight and win the elections democra-



West Bengal CM Mamata Banerjee during a public rally ahead of State Assembly elections in Keshiary, Paschim Medinipur district

tically." "This is why they are deleting voters' names. They are also planning to tinker with EVMs to turn the results in their favour," she said, describing a senior ECI offi-

cial as "BJP's main washing machine." Sooner or later, justice will be served after the BJP's drubbing in the Assembly polls and later their dislodging from power in Delhi, the CM said.

"More than 250 people have died due to the SIR exercise. Of the 90 lakh deleted voters, 60 lakh are Hindus while 30 lakh are Muslims... Since we speak in Bengali, are we not Indians? Do we need to constantly prove our citizenship?" she said. "SIR is a big scam which will be proved one day," Banerjee added.

On BJP's promise to implement the Uniform Civil Code (UCC) in West Bengal if voted to power, Banerjee said that through the UCC, the saffron party wants to impose its diktat on the people.

BJP GOVT TO END TMC'S 'SYNDICATE RAJ' IN BENGAL: AMIT SHAH



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Onda/Chhatna (WB)

Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Saturday asserted that if the BJP is voted to power in West Bengal, it will end TMC's 'syndicate raj', and said those involved in atrocities against women of the State would be brought to justice.

Addressing a BJP rally at Chhatna in Bankura district, Shah accused Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee of playing the "victim card" to gain sympathy.

"Mamata Banerjee plays the victim card. At times, she wears a bandage on her leg or head (to gain sympathy). Mamata didi, this election, you may wear a bandage on your leg, head or hand, but people of Bengal will not vote for you," Shah claimed.

During the eight-phase 2021 Assembly elections in Bengal, Banerjee campaigned in a wheelchair with a plaster on her leg following an injury while canvassing for party candidates.

JD(U) leaders hail PM's praise for Nitish Kumar



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Patna

Bihar JD(U) leaders on Saturday hailed Prime Minister Narendra Modi's praise for Nitish Kumar after the latter was sworn in as a Rajya Sabha MP.

Modi had on Friday congratulated the Bihar chief minister on taking oath as a Rajya Sabha member and said he is one of the most experienced leaders in the country, and his commitment to good governance has been appreciated everywhere.

Talking to reporters, JD(U) national president Sanjay Jha said, "Modi shares deep personal respect for Kumar and his way of working. What he has expressed through his social media post is exactly what he feels about the Bihar CM." State transport minister and JD(U) leader Shrawon Kumar, too, hailed the prime minister's congratulatory message.

"The PM has appreciated Kumar's work, and I am grate-

ful for this. This appreciation is not because he is going to the Rajya Sabha, but for the work Kumar has done over the past 20 years to ensure development with social justice," the minister said.

He said that under Kumar's two-decade-long rule, the term 'Bihari' has come to be associated with pride and self-respect. "Today, Nitish Kumar's name is on everyone's lips. His thinking, his vision, and his style of working have been truly remarkable and impactful," Kumar added.

Responding to Yadav's remarks levelling Kumar's decision to go to Rajya Sabha as an "imposed" one and under "pressure," Jha said, "What else can you expect from him (Tejaswi Yadav)? People showed him his actual position in the 2025 Assembly elections. We, on the other hand, continue to be guided under the leadership of Nitish Kumar ji. Even as he goes to the Rajya Sabha, Kumar will remain the undisputed leader in our Government."

PROSPECT

Superstar Singer Season 1 makes its Sony PAL premiere from April 13



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Strengthening its promise of offering a diverse and engaging entertainment experience across genres, Sony PAL continues to curate a rich mix of content—spanning mythology, comedy, reality and more. Adding to this vibrant line-up, the channel is all set to premiere the OG Superstar Singer Season 1 starting 13th April 2026, airing Monday to Saturday at 8.30 pm.

Celebrated as the show that introduced India to its very own ‘Singing Ka Kal’, Superstar Singer Season 1 became a fan favourite for its heartwarm-

ing format and extraordinary young talent. The show features an acclaimed panel of super judges including Alka Yagnik, Himesh Reshammiya, and Javed Ali, with Jay Bhanushali as the host. Bringing together four dynamic teams led by captains Nitin Kumar, Jyotica Tangri, Salman Ali, and Sachin Kumar Valmiki, the show showcases a unique mentor-led format that nurtures young singing prodigies. Spread across 24 episodes over four weeks, the season delivers a power-packed musical experience filled with emotions and unforgettable performances.

Dr Rajib Mukhopadhyay honoured with MIICCIA Legend Enterprise Award 2026



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Dr Rajib Mukhopadhyay, co-founder of Le Rythme, has been awarded the Millennial India International Chamber of Commerce Industry and Agriculture (MIICCIA) Legend Enterprise Award 2026 for his contributions to finance, social service and skill development. The award was presented by Rajeev Shukla at an event hosted by the Millennial India International Chamber of Commerce Industry and

Agriculture in New Delhi. With over 30 years of global leadership experience and an academic background from the Indian Institute of Management Calcutta, Dr Mukhopadhyay has led impactful initiatives through Le Rythme, focusing on skill development and employment generation for underprivileged communities. He dedicated the award to his late wife, Rini Mukherjee, whose work laid the foundation for the organisation's social outreach.



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Work on Bhutan's 1,200 MW Punatsangchu-I hydropower project has resumed after a seven-year suspension, with India's Power Minister Manohar Lal attending a key concrete pouring ceremony marking the restart of dam construction. The revival of the India-funded project, stalled since 2019 due to geological challenges, is seen as a major milestone in bilateral energy cooperation and is expected to pave the way for comple-

tion within five years. According to an official statement, Manohar Lal, during his visit to Bhutan, visited the project site, which is the largest joint hydropower venture between the two countries and is expected to enhance Bhutan's hydropower capacity substantially upon completion. The minister attended a concrete pouring ceremony at Punatsangchu-I on April 10, signalling the restart of dam construction, which had been suspended since 2019 due to geological challenges. The

ED seizes over ₹6 cr cash during raids against realty company

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) has seized ₹6.3 crore in cash and jewellery worth ₹7.5 crore following searches against a Delhi-based real estate company accused of defrauding homebuyers and currently undergoing insolvency proceedings, officials said on Saturday. The action under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA) was launched on Friday and 10 premises of former directors, promoters and associated entities of the company — Earth Infrastructures Ltd. (EIL) — in Delhi and Gurugram were covered. The company, according to official records, has been undergoing a corporate insolvency resolution process (CIRP) since June 2018. According to the ED officials, the money laundering case against the former directors and promoters of the company was initiated after taking cognisance of five Delhi Police (Economic Offences Wing) FIRs, apart from a complaint filed by the Serious



The raid was conducted across 10 premises in Gurugram and Delhi linked to Earth Infrastructures Limited

Fraud Investigation Office (SFIO), the investigation arm of the Ministry of Corporate Affairs. The ED seized ₹6.3 crore in cash and jewellery valued at ₹7.5 crore, besides some silver bullion and luxury watches during the searches, the officials said. The group and its associated companies launched multiple real estate projects under the 'Earth' brand across Delhi-NCR and Lucknow. Their major projects include Earth Towne, Earth Sapphire Court, Earth Copia, Earth Techone, Earth Iconic, Earth Titanium,

Earth Elacasa, Earth Gracia and Earth Skygate. The accused entities collected ₹2,024.45 crore from more than 19,425 homebuyers and investors by promising "timely" delivery of residential and commercial units along with assured returns, the ED said. However, despite collecting "huge" advances, projects were either not completed or buyers were not given possession. The funds were diverted for the acquisition of land in Gurugram, Delhi and Rajasthan or routed to shell companies, the agency claimed.

ADG, BR (East) reviews restoration efforts in landslide-hit North Sikkim



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gangtok

In a strong demonstration of leadership and commitment, Additional Director General Border Roads (East), Jitendra Prasad, VSM, visited the landslide-affected area at Taramchu in North Sikkim, one of the most challenging and fragile terrains in the region.

Amidst difficult conditions where road connectivity serves as a critical lifeline, Jitendra Prasad personally assessed the ground situation and interacted with Border Roads Organisation (BRO) personnel deployed at site. Standing shoulder to shoulder with the troops, he reviewed the ongoing restoration efforts and issued clear directions for expediting

fresh works to ensure early reopening of the route. During the visit, the ADG, BR (East) carried out a detailed inspection of the progress of works and emphasised the organisation's unwavering commitment towards restoring and strengthening connectivity in the region. He reiterated that in such remote and sensitive areas, roads are not

merely infrastructure but are vital for survival, development and maintaining the crucial link between border communities and the rest of the nation. The visit served as a morale booster for the personnel on ground, reaffirming BRO's ethos of leading from the front and its steadfast dedication to nation-building in the most demanding environments.

Goyal holds talks with Saudi trade minister on strengthening supply chains



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal on Saturday held discussions with Saudi Arabia's Trade Minister Majid bin Abdullah Al Qassabi on ways to strengthen supply chains disrupted due to the West Asia crisis, after holding talks with his counterparts from the UAE, Bahrain and Kuwait. All these countries are members of the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) with which India is negotiating a free trade agreement. The commerce ministry, in a statement, said that

Goyal had a virtual call with Qassabi. "The Ministers reaffirmed their commitment to strengthening bilateral trade and expressed optimism for early progress in the India-GCC FTA negotiations," it said. Both sides noted the strain conflict has put on regional supply chains and stressed the need for an early recovery through coordinated efforts to ensure smooth trade flows, it said. Goyal highlighted India's steps to support exports to Saudi Arabia and the Gulf region. The joint attack launched by the US and Israel on Iran had led to severe disruptions

in the movement of ships in international waters, particularly to the West Asian nations. The conflict has posed challenges for exporters to ship goods to the Gulf region, with which India had a bilateral trade of USD 178 billion in 2024-25 (USD 56.87 billion exports and USD 121.67 billion imports). The major sectors which are under stress include petroleum products, chemicals and plastics, engineering goods, rice, pharma and gems and jewellery. The six countries in this region are the UAE, Saudi Arabia, Oman, Bahrain, Qatar and Kuwait.

Vedanta Aluminium signs MoU for Aluminium Park in Jharsuguda

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhubaneswar

Vedanta Aluminium, India's largest producer of aluminium, has signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with two leading manufacturing companies, Singhal Steel & Power Pvt. Ltd (a unit of Singhal Group of Industries) and SCOT-AL Metcon Pvt Ltd (an associate company of Scottish Chemical Industries and UAL Industries) for setting up their downstream aluminium manufacturing facilities within the upcoming Vedanta Aluminium Park in Jharsuguda, Odisha. According to a Press release, MoU signing ceremony was held in Bhubaneswar in the presence of senior Government officials, including Sampad Chandra Swain, Minister of State, Industries, Skill Development & Technical Education, Odisha and Hemant Sharma, Additional Chief Secretary, Department of Industries, Odisha. Envisaged as a dedicated world-class industrial ecosystem for downstream aluminium industries, the Vedanta Aluminium Park in



Jharsuguda aims to promote value addition and support the growth of MSMEs while cementing Odisha's position as a global aluminium hub. The initiative is expected to further enhance the state's industrial competitiveness, attract fresh investments of over INR 500 crores, and create around 1,500 direct and indirect employment opportunities within the State. Speaking on the occasion, Swain, said this initiative reinforces Odisha's position as a leading industrial destination. "The Vedanta Aluminium Park will accelerate investments, create large-scale employment and strengthen the state's manufacturing capabilities

across sectors," he said. The proposed Aluminium Park is expected to serve as a catalyst for industrial diversification in the State by creating an enabling environment for downstream enterprises to scale efficiently. It aligns with the Government of Odisha's broader vision of building future-ready industrial infrastructure. On the occasion Sharma said, Vedanta Aluminium Park is a critical step in deepening Odisha's industrial value chain. While Rajiv Kumar, CEO, Vedanta Aluminium, said Vedanta Aluminium Park reflects our commitment to moving beyond primary production towards value-added manufacturing.

Work resumes on Bhutan's Punatsangchu-I hydropower project after 7 year halt

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Work on Bhutan's 1,200 MW Punatsangchu-I hydropower project has resumed after a seven-year suspension, with India's Power Minister Manohar Lal attending a key concrete pouring ceremony marking the restart of dam construction. The revival of the India-funded project, stalled since 2019 due to geological challenges, is seen as a major milestone in bilateral energy cooperation and is expected to pave the way for comple-

tion within five years. According to an official statement, Manohar Lal, during his visit to Bhutan, visited the project site, which is the largest joint hydropower venture between the two countries and is expected to enhance Bhutan's hydropower capacity substantially upon completion. The minister attended a concrete pouring ceremony at Punatsangchu-I on April 10, signalling the restart of dam construction, which had been suspended since 2019 due to geological challenges. The

project, Bhutan's largest hydropower venture funded by India, is expected to be completed within five years. The minister said the project reflects strong India-Bhutan energy cooperation, highlighting India's financial and technical support and the joint efforts to advance construction safely. At the Punatsangchu-II project, jointly inaugurated in November 2025 by Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Bhutan's King Jigme Khesar Namgyel Wangchuck, he reviewed operations, noting it



is already generating electricity and revenue, including exports to India. Punatsangchu-I, a run-of-the-river project with an installed capacity of 1,200 MW, is expected to boost Bhutan's hydropower capacity by about 30 per cent to nearly 4,700 MW and generate around 5,670 million units annually. Funded by India with a 40 per cent grant and 60 per cent loan, the project had reached over 93 per cent financial progress and nearly 88 per cent physical completion as of

February 2026 before work resumed. The project was approved at a cost of ₹9,375.57 crore (December 2013 price level). As of February 2026, financial progress stood at ₹8,785.19 crore, or 93.7 per cent, while physical progress was 87.75 per cent. A revised cost estimate is currently under examination. The minister also visited the historic Wangdue Phodrang Dzong during his trip. The surplus power generated by the PHEP-I will be sold to India at a mutually determined price, to be agreed at the time of

project commissioning. Construction on the project commenced on November 11, 2008, with an initial commissioning schedule of November 2015. However, during execution, the project faced significant geological challenges in surface and underground works, leading to numerous design changes. The dam works were adversely affected by the destabilisation of the right bank slope at the dam in 2013, leading to the suspension of ongoing dam works from 2019.

FROM THE WORLD

UK
Fuel protests disrupt Ireland

Protests over the soaring cost of fuel spread disruption across Ireland on Saturday with many gas stations running dry as truck and tractor drivers staged a fifth day of blockades at the country's sole fuel refinery and several depots. Vehicles blocking traffic led to closures of the main highway around the capital, Dublin, as well as six other major roadways. More than a third of the 1,500 service stations in the republic are out of fuel and that number is expected to grow dramatically if the roadblocks remain. Fuels for Ireland chief executive Kevin McPartlan said. Irish police put all its officers on notice they could be called to duty over the weekend and the military was on standby to help remove the vehicles as the Government was due to renew talks Saturday to resolve the dispute.

NIGERIA
300 convicted in mass trial

A court in the Nigerian capital of Abuja on Friday convicted more than 300 terrorism suspects in a mass trial that spanned four days. The mass trial began Tuesday, with many suspects pleading guilty to charges brought against them by the Nigerian Government. Many of them have since been sentenced to up to 20 years in prison after they appeared before a panel of 10 judges."In total, we brought about 508 cases. Of these 508, we were able to secure 386 convictions," Nigeria's attorney general told journalists after the mass trial on Friday. "We have been able to bring justice to them, or bring them to justice. So this is the clear signal that we are sending." Nigeria is battling a complex security crisis, especially in the north, where there is a decade-long insurgency and several armed groups that kidnap for ransom. The insurgency in the country's northeast has lasted more than a decade.

Iran opens US talks with sombre tribute to Minab 168

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

As the Iranian delegation sat down to begin high-stakes talks with the United States in Islamabad, diplomacy took on a deeply emotional tone, with Tehran invoking the memory of 168 children killed in the Minab school strike.

In a striking and symbolic gesture just as negotiations got underway, Iran's Parliament Speaker Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf shared an image from his flight-rows of empty seats filled not with passengers, but with photographs of young victims. "My companions on this flight, Minab168," he wrote, turning a routine diplomatic journey into a sombre tribute.

The message was unmistakable: before any agreement, before any handshake, there are lives that Iran says cannot be forgotten.

The Minab tragedy dates back to the early days of the US-Israel-Iran conflict, when American forces struck what they described as a military target near the Shajareh Tayyebah school. Iranian officials, however, insist the strike was deliberate, claiming it directly hit the school and left 168 children dead-an incident that continues to cast a long shadow over any



attempt at reconciliation. For many in Iran, the images of that day remain raw. By carrying the faces of those children into the very moment talks began, Tehran appeared to be reminding Washington-and the world-of the human cost behind geopolitical calculations.

Iran has since sought accountability, even naming two US Navy personnel-Leigh R Tate and Jeffrey E York of the USS Spruance-as being linked to the strike. The matter has also reached the United Nations, which has urged the US to complete its investigation and

deliver justice. The delegation in Islamabad, led by Ghalibaf and including Foreign Minister Abbas Araqchi and other senior officials, entered negotiations carrying both political demands and emotional weight. Even as dialogue begins, Tehran's distrust remains palpable. "We have good intentions but we do not trust... Our experience in negotiating with the Americans has always been met with failure and broken promises," Ghalibaf said, underscoring the fragile ground on which the

talks stand. Iran is pressing for a ceasefire in Lebanon and the unfreezing of its assets, warning it may walk away if its demands are not met. The United States, in turn, has cautioned against escalation, signalling that military options remain on the table.

As negotiations unfold in Islamabad, the image of those 168 children lingers-an emotional reminder that beyond strategy and statecraft, the outcome of these talks carries the weight of unresolved grief and a demand for justice.

US flags china arms concerns rising

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

High-stakes negotiations between the United States and Iran in Islamabad are unfolding against a backdrop of rising military tensions and fresh intelligence concerns, even as diplomatic efforts seek to prevent further escalation.

According to a report by CNN, US intelligence assessments indicate that China may be preparing to supply new air defence systems to Iran within weeks. The report, citing sources familiar with the matter, said Beijing could route shipments through third countries to conceal their origin.

The talks are being held at the luxury Serena Hotel, which has emerged as the focal point of diplomatic efforts to end the conflict. The Pakistani capital has been placed under unprecedented security, with authorities



President Trump arriving on Air Force One at Joint Base Andrews

shutting shops and offices for two days. Thousands of security personnel, including paramilitary forces and army troops, have established checkpoints and barricades across the city. The heavily fortified Red Zone-home to key Government buildings and foreign embassies-has been completely sealed off.

Even as talks continue, violence on the ground shows little sign of easing. The Israel Defense Forces said it carried out strikes on more than 200 Hezbollah targets in Lebanon

over the past 24 hours, including rocket launchers and infrastructure.

The Israeli military said its air force operations are ongoing, supporting ground troops engaged in southern Lebanon. Tensions have also spiked in the Gulf. A US naval vessel, earlier spotted near Fujairah port in the United Arab Emirates, reportedly altered course after Iran warned it would be targeted within 30 minutes if it entered the strategically critical Strait of Hormuz.

US revokes green cards of Iranian officials' relatives

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Washington

The Trump administration has revoked the green cards of more long-term Iranian residents of the United States who are related to current or former senior Iranian officials.

The State Department said Saturday it had taken action against Seyed Eissa Hashemi, a Los Angeles-area psychology teacher, his wife and son, all of whom were Iranian born lawful permanent residents of the US.

The department said in a statement released as talks to end the war with Iran were getting underway in



Pakistan that they had been taken into custody by immigration authorities and are slated for deportation.

Hashemi, it said, is the son of Masoumeh Ebtekar who served as a spokeswoman for the attackers who took over the US Embassy in Tehran in 1979 and was later promoted

to be Iran's first female vice president.

Just last week, the State Department revoked the green cards of the niece and grand-niece of former Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps chief Qasem Soleimani, who was killed in a US airstrike in Baghdad in early 2020.

Pak military contingent, including jets, reaches Saudi

SAJJAD HUSSAIN
■ Islamabad

A Pakistani military contingent comprising around 13,000 soldiers and 10 to 18 jets has reached Saudi Arabia as part of a joint strategic defence agreement signed last year, the Gulf Kingdom announced on Saturday.

The military contingent's deployment to King Abdulaziz Air Base in the Eastern Sector includes fighter jets and support aircraft from the Pakistan Air Force, according to a statement from Saudi Arabia's Ministry of Defence. The deployment aimed to enhance joint military coordination, improve operational readiness between the armed forces of the two countries, and support security and stability at regional and international levels, it added.

A Pakistan Government official also confirmed sending troops and jets to Saudi Arabia as part of the two



countries' strategic defence agreement, under which any attack on one country would be considered an attack on another. Expert on international affairs Mohammad Mehdi told that Pakistan had sent aircraft and troops to Saudi Arabia last month, but

the news has been broken only now by the Saudi authorities.

"At least 13,000 Pakistani soldiers and 10 to 18 fighter jets landed in Saudi Arabia. As many as 10,000 soldiers are already present in Saudi Arabia. And this arrangement has

France insists on ceasefire in Lebanon

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Paris

French President Emmanuel Macron on Saturday urged "respect for the ceasefire and its application to Lebanon."

In a social media post, Macron said he talked to Turkish President Recep Tayyip Erdogan on Saturday and that in addition to discussing the ceasefire, they urged a return to free navigation in the Strait of Hormuz.

The French leader didn't mention the negotiations in Pakistan, but said he and Erdogan "underlined the need for a robust and lasting diplomatic solution."

Macron has been speaking regularly with other world



leaders about the war and helping lead efforts for a mission to secure shipping in the Strait of Hormuz once the fighting calms. He has been particularly active in pushing for peace in Lebanon, a former French protectorate with close ties to France.

Struck over 200 Hezbollah targets in the last 24 hours, says Israel

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Jerusalem

The Israeli military said its air force hit infrastructure of the Iran-backed militant group in Lebanon and was continuing to support its ground forces operating in southern Lebanon.

The statement came as Teheran was pressing for a halt to Israeli strikes on Hezbollah in three-party talks that began Saturday afternoon between Iran and the US in Pakistan. Earlier Saturday, the Lebanese state-run news



Mourners reacting during the funeral of security officers in Lebanon

agency reported at least three people killed in Israeli strikes in southern Lebanon. There were no reported strikes in the afternoon hours. In Israeli

communities along the border with Lebanon sirens continued to warn of drone and rocket attacks from Lebanon throughout the day Saturday.

Pakistan puts in place multi-layered security to protect plane carrying Iranian delegation

MZULQERNAIN ■ Lahore

Pakistan put in place extraordinary multi-layered security measures to protect the aircraft carrying the Iranian delegation for the high-stakes peace talks with the US in Islamabad, an aviation official said on Saturday.

Among the measures was a Pakistan airline aircraft flying alongside the Iranian plane, which had its transponder turned off.

The high-powered delegation of Iran, led by Speaker of the Parliament Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf, along with Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi, arrived in Islamabad in the early hours of Saturday to participate in the Islamabad Talks. The official in the Pakistani aviation said that the Pakistan Air Force took extraordinary security mea-



sures in anticipation of and to deal with any untoward incident while the Iranian delegation's plane was in the air.

The aircraft carrying the Iranian delegation departed from Gorgan Airport, located on the coast of the Caspian Sea, about 400 kilometres from Tehran, he said. "The Pakistani air traffic controllers were informed in advance that the aircraft's transponder would remain

switched off. With the transponder turned off, the aircraft could not be detected on secondary radar systems used for monitoring commercial flights.

It could, however, still be tracked on primary military radar, though without basic identifying information, appearing only as a moving dot," he said. One of the key protective measures involved a Pakistani airline aircraft flying alongside the

Iranian plane, with its transponder switched on, he said. "Radar systems worldwide tracked the Pakistani Airbus A321 on this route, while the Iranian Airbus A300 flew discreetly alongside it with its transponder turned off. After escorting the Iranian aircraft to Nur Khan Airbase, the Pakistani plane returned to Islamabad Airport," he said.

"In addition, the Pakistan Air Force implemented further security measures. The Iranian aircraft flew over Afghanistan for an extended duration and entered Pakistani airspace via Chaman. "Throughout the journey-from the Gulf's conflict zone to Afghanistan and up to Islamabad-a robust aerial surveillance and protection system remained active, involving AWACS and fighter jets," he said. (PTI)

A Syrian man buries his wife and 4 children killed in Israeli strikes on Beirut

GHAITH ALSAYED/
SALLY ABOU ALJOUD
■ Deir El-Zour

A Syrian man on Saturday buried his wife and four of his five children, killed in the massive wave of Israeli strikes that pounded Beirut earlier this week, laying them to rest in Deir el-Zour province in northeastern Syria.

It was not the homecoming they had anticipated when they fled to Lebanon six years ago. The bodies, along with that of his six-month pregnant daughter-in-law, arrived in wooden coffins on a bus from Lebanon, their names scribbled on the sides. Men stood beside the bus



Mourners pray over the six coffins of members of the Al-Jalib family, who were killed in Israeli strikes in Beirut

crying before the burial procession in al-Sour town, as mourners gathered to offer condolences.

The remains of one of his

two daughters were still missing, believed to be trapped under rubble, as search operations concluded Saturday, three days after

the attacks.

The strike was one of roughly 100 carried out by Israel on Wednesday without warning, targeting what the Israeli military said were Hezbollah-linked sites across Beirut and other parts of Lebanon. More than 350 people were killed that day, a third being women and children, making it the deadliest day in nearly six weeks of war. Many of the strikes hit commercial streets and densely populated neighborhoods in central Beirut, far from conflict zones, where repeated Israeli evacuation warnings have been issued since March 2, when the Iran-backed militant group

Hezbollah fired missiles into Israel in retaliation for the US-Israeli attacks on Iran.

A father's grief

The father, Hamad al-Jalib, survived because he was away fetching a gas canister while working as the building's concierge. When he heard that a strike had hit the Ain Mreisseh neighborhood, where he lives, he rushed back, only to see a plume of smoke rising from a building behind a mosque across from Beirut's famous seaside promenade - usually crowded with people walking and exercising.

"The Israeli attack killed my girls, they are inno-

cent, just sitting at home," al-Jalib said. "They were having lunch." He said it took rescue teams three days to extract the bodies of his family from under the rubble. "And I still have a daughter missing, her name is Fatima Hamad al-Jalib." She is 10 years old. His other daughter was 12 while his sons were 17, 14 and 13 years old.

Three other Syrian relatives were also killed in the Ain Mreisseh strike and were buried on Saturday in the town of al-Shuhail in Deir el-Zour, after the family split upon returning to Syria.

Al-Jalib said his family had been displaced from their area and moved to Lebanon

in 2020, as local tensions grew involving tribal groups and the Kurdish-led Syrian Democratic Forces.

The casualties from Wednesday's strikes and others across the country have pushed the death toll in more than a month of Israel's war with Hezbollah to over 1,950 killed and more than 6,300 wounded, according to Lebanon's Health Ministry. The toll includes at least 315 Syrians killed and wounded.

It remains unclear how many of those killed on Wednesday were non-Lebanese, as the Health Ministry did not provide a breakdown by nationality. Officials have reported that at

least 39 Syrians were among the dead. Dalal Harb, a spokesperson for the U.N. refugee agency, said the family killed in Ain Mreisseh was not registered with the UNHCR. There are about 530,000 Syrians refugees registered with UNHCR in Lebanon, with hundreds of thousands more believed to be unregistered.

While hundreds of thousands of Syrians have returned from Lebanon since the ouster of former Syrian President Bashar Assad in December 2024, many others remain reluctant to go back because of the lack of jobs and ongoing violence. (AP)

Artemis-II crew returns after historic moon flyby

SAGAR KULKARNI
■ Washington

Amid claps and cheers, four astronauts of NASA's Artemis-II mission splashed down in the Pacific ocean after a historic flight to the moon – the first by humans in more than 50 years.

"The path to the moon is open but the work ahead is greater than the work behind," Amit Kshatriya, Indian-origin NASA Associate Administrator told a press conference shortly after the Artemis-II crew returned to earth off the coast of San Diego at 8.07 eastern time on Friday. The lunar flyby mission involving Commander Reid Wiseman, pilot Victor Glover,



Artemis II astronauts Victor Glover and Christina Koch interacting with NASA Administrator Jared Isaacman in San Diego, California, USA

Christina Koch and Canada's Jeremy Hansen was the first journey to the moon since the Apollo 17 mission in December 1972 when Eugene Cernan and Harrison Schmitt spent three days exploring the lunar surface. Rick Henfling, the flight director, said the Artemis II astronauts are "happy and healthy and ready to come home to Houston."

Artemis II was the first crewed mission to utilise NASA's Space Launch System rocket and Orion crew module – demonstrating that the agency's equipment can propel astronauts out of Earth's orbit and bring them safely home. "Yesterday, flight director Jeff Radigan said we had less than a

degree of an angle to hit after a quarter of a million miles to the moon," Kshatriya told reporters. "And their team hit it. This is not luck; that is 1,000 people doing their job," he said. The mission flew 700,237 miles; its peak velocity was 24,664 mph; and the flight had an entry range of 1,957 miles but landed within one mile of its target, Henfling said.

NASA now aims to land humans on the moon where the space agency also plans to set up a habitat that would be the launchpad for future missions to Mars and beyond. It was a triumphant homecoming for the crew of four whose record-breaking lunar flyby revealed not only

swaths of the moon's far side never seen before by human eyes but a total solar eclipse. They emerged from their bobbing capsule into the sunlight one by one.

Henfling said his team "breathed a sigh of relief" once the side hatch opened on the Orion Integrity after it splashed down in the Pacific Ocean. "We all breathed a sigh of relief once the hatch opened up, that's when we brought the team in," he said. "We said a few words to the flight controllers and waved and gave them a thumbs up, and we all watched as each of their four astronauts got out of the spaceship and were hoisted up onto the helicopters.

Sri Lanka ageing fast; elderly population triples in 40 years



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Colombo

Sri Lanka is ageing at a rapid pace, with its elderly population nearly tripled to 18 per cent over the last four decades, according to the latest census data.

As per the 2024 census report released this week by the Department of Census and Statistics, Sri Lanka's total population stands at 21,781,800, with a national density of 350 persons per square kilometre.

"The elderly population grew from 6.6 per cent in 1981 to 18 per cent by 2024," the report said. In 1981, the total elderly population in the island nation was less than a million, which rose to 3,921,124 by 2024. The report said the 2024 data "highlight a significant

transition toward an aging society". The elderly population (60 years and over) now constitutes 18 per cent of the total population, while the child population (0-14 years) has contracted to 20.7 per cent, it said.

"This shift is further evidenced by an Aging Index of 87, indicating that there are 87 elderly persons for every 100 children. Furthermore, the Median Age (35 years) has increased by approximately five years compared to previous census conducted in 2012, reflecting a maturing population structure," the report said.

In a related trend, the island nation's total fertility rate (TFR) also declined from 3.3 per cent in 1981 to 1.8 per cent in 2024, the data revealed, underscoring a significant transition towards an ageing society.

Djibouti President Ismail Omar Guelleh is re-elected for sixth term



ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Mogadishu

Djibouti President Ismail Omar Guelleh was re-elected for a sixth term after official results showed him winning 97.81 per cent of the vote in Friday's election.

Guelleh, 78, has ruled the small Horn of Africa nation of about 1 million for more than two decades. Last year, the country's lawmakers scrapped presidential age limits. Election officials said the vote was peaceful. At the presidential palace, supporters on Saturday celebrated and offered congratulations.

Guelleh faced a single challenger, Mohamed Farah Samatar, a former ruling party member, in a race analysts say offered little genuine competition. Opposition groups frequently boycott elections, citing restrictions on political freedoms.

Guelleh succeeded his uncle, former President Hassan Gouled Aptidon, in 1999, extending a family-led system that has shaped the country's politics for decades.

Misri to visit Paris, Berlin for talks on trade, defence

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India's Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri is set to begin a three-day diplomatic visit to Paris and Berlin starting Sunday, with high-level consultations expected to focus on energy, trade, and defence amid rising geopolitical uncertainty.

The visit follows Misri's recent trip to the United States, where he held talks with Secretary of State Marco Rubio and other senior officials from the Trump administration. The ongoing West Asia crisis and its implications for global energy security are expected to feature prominently in his discussions with European counterparts. In Paris, Misri will co-



Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri meeting United States Deputy Secretary of State, Christopher Landau in Washington DC

chair the India-France Foreign Office Consultations with Martin Briens, Secretary General of the French Foreign Ministry. The talks are expected to cover defence, civil

nuclear energy, space, cyber and digital cooperation, artificial intelligence, and people-to-people exchanges, along with regional and global developments. In Berlin, he

will lead the India-Germany Foreign Office Consultations with Geza Andreas von Geyr, State Secretary of the German Foreign Office, and is also likely to meet other senior officials and dignitaries.

The visit comes amid a series of high-level engagements between India and Europe, including visits by Friedrich Merz in January and Emmanuel Macron in February. India's Ministry of External Affairs said the trip will provide an opportunity to review the full range of bilateral ties and advance cooperation across priority sectors.

Meanwhile India's Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri discussed furthering energy cooperation with the US in nuclear power and new areas such as coal gasifica-

tion and LPG exports in his meeting with US Energy Secretary Chris Wright.

Wrapping up his three-day visit to the US, Misri's discussion with Wright focused on advancing energy security, deepening bilateral energy trade and identifying new avenues to strengthen the India-US Energy Partnership, the Indian Embassy in the US said.

"Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri called on Energy Secretary Chris Wright @SecretaryWright@ENERGY. Discussions focused on advancing energy security, deepening bilateral energy trade, and identifying new avenues to strengthen the India-US Energy Partnership," the embassy said.

Indian-origin man jailed for forging documents in Singapore

GURDIP SINGH
■ Singapore

An Indian-origin man in Singapore was sentenced to seven weeks in jail for forging his clients' bank statements so that the insurance policies he was selling to them could take effect.

Vijendren Tanapal, 38, pleaded guilty to two forgery charges involving two Japanese clients while working as a wealth planning manager at a bank.

Several other similar charges linked to his other Japanese clients were considered during Tanapal's sentencing on Thursday. Tanapal's bail was set at

SGD15,000, and he will begin serving his sentence on July 31, according to a media report.

As part of his job at DBS Bank, Tanapal sold Manulife insurance policies, primarily targeting Japanese clients.

Tanapal committed the offences in 2017 to hit his sales target. He forged his clients' bank statements so that the insurance policies he was selling to them could take effect. In January 2022, police received information from DBS that Tanapal had submitted multiple sets of forged documents linked to six Japanese clients. (PTI)

Mexican judge rules in favour of plaintiffs in 2018 Cuba plane crash

MARIA VERZA
■ Mexico City

A Mexican judge has ruled that the plane involved in a 2018 crash in Cuba that killed 112 people suffered from severe maintenance failures and should never have flown, and ordered the owner to pay millions in damages to the families of the victims who sued.

According to court documents dated March 31 and seen Friday by The Associated Press, an independent expert determined the 2018 crash was an "institutional accident" caused by maintenance negligence.

The expert's report, which sided with the plain-



tiffs, described the pilots as a "final line of defence" who were tragically unable to prevent the low-altitude crash.

Based on these findings, the judge ordered Mexican charter Aerolineas Damojh to pay \$1.5 million in damages to each of the families of the four Mexican crew members who filed

the initial lawsuit. The company failed to appear at trial and was tried in absentia. The aircraft's insurer was also named in the lawsuit but was ultimately cleared of any financial penalties.

The Boeing 737 went down in a field moments after departing Havana's Jose Marti International Airport, marking one of Cuba's deadliest aviation disasters in decades.

Of the 113 people on board, only a Cuban woman survived. Most of the victims were Cubans.

A year after the accident, Cuba attributed the tragedy to crew error. (AP)

Trump shares video of brutal Florida killing allegedly by Haitian immigrant

GISELA SALOMON/ MARTHA BELLISLE/ REBECCA SANTANA
■ Miami



President Donald Trump shared a video of a deadly attack allegedly by a Haitian immigrant accused of bludgeoning a woman with a hammer at a Florida gas station, portraying the killing as justification for his administration's mass deportation agenda.

Rolbert Joachin, was arrested and charged with killing a woman on April 2 in Fort Myers, about 160 miles northwest of Miami. Authorities said the man was from Haiti and arrived in the US in 2022. The woman who was killed was identified as a 51-year-old immigrant from Bangladesh and a mother of two adult daughters. Trump, who posted the video late Thursday to his Truth Social

account, has often sought to portray immigrants as bringing crime to the US, and the video emerging from the Florida attack presented him with a new, particularly graphic opportunity to do so.

Trump also often paints Democrats and his predecessor, former President Joe Biden, as allowing in immigrants

who posed a criminal or national security threat to the US.

"The video of her brutal slaying is one of the most vicious things you will ever see," Trump said in his post, describing the man as an "animal."

Critics say the president unjustly paints all immigrants as criminals in an effort to bolster his immigration agenda, when studies have found that people living in the US illegally are less likely than native-born Americans to have been arrested for violent, drug and property crimes. "Our hearts are with the family of the victim during this unimaginably painful time," said Guerline Jozef, executive director of the Haitian Bridge Alliance, which advocates for Haitian immigrants. "We condemn this act of violence in the strongest possible terms. (AP)

Two dead in Russian strike ahead of Easter ceasefire

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kyiv

Russian drone strikes killed at least two people in the Ukrainian city of Odesa overnight into Saturday, local authorities reported, ahead of a proposed ceasefire for Orthodox Easter.

A further two people were wounded in the attack on the Black Sea port city, when drones hit a residential area, damaging apartment buildings, houses and a kindergarten.

According to the Ukrainian Air Force, Russia targeted Ukraine with 160 drones overnight, of which 133 were shot down or intercepted, hours before a proposed Easter ceasefire was due to



come into force. Russia's Defence Ministry said 99 Ukrainian drones were shot down overnight across Russia and occupied Crimea.

Russian President Vladimir Putin on Thursday declared a 32-hour ceasefire over the

Orthodox Easter weekend, ordering Russian forces to halt hostilities from 4 pm Saturday until the end of Sunday.

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said Friday that Ukraine is ready to

mirror any ceasefire steps, having earlier proposed to Russia a pause in attacks on each other's energy infrastructure over the Orthodox Easter holiday.

Previous ceasefire attempts have had little impact, with both sides accusing each other of violations. Kremlin spokesman Dmitry Peskov on Friday described Putin's move as a "humanitarian" gesture, but said Moscow remains focused on a comprehensive settlement based on its long-standing demands - a key sticking point that has prevented the two sides from reaching an agreement. A possible prisoner exchange over the Easter holiday has also been discussed.

IAF, US Air Force chiefs discuss stronger defence ties

SAGAR KULKARNI
■ Washington



Air Chief Marshal AP Singh interacting with US Air Force General Kenneth S Wilsbach during a meeting

Aerospace Defence Command mission of aerospace warning, aerospace control and maritime warning for North America, officials said.

The IAF chief also travelled to Nellis Air Force Base in Nevada, where the visit

included briefings at the US Air Force Warfare Centre and a familiarisation flight in an F-15EX Eagle II, a statement from the US Air Force (USAF) said. "Opportunities like this are crucial for building our joint interoperability and strengthening the strategic

partnership between our air forces," Singh was quoted as saying in the statement.

During the office calls, Department of the Air Force senior leaders emphasised the priority America places on its defence partnership with India, highlighting its central role in ensuring a free, open, peaceful and prosperous Indo-Pacific region.

Wilsbach praised India's leadership and participation in multilateral exercises with like-minded partners and stressed how continuing to prioritise and expand such cooperation is key to enhancing regional deterrence.

He also welcomed India's procurement of MQ-9B Sky Guardian aircraft and emphasised the US Air Force com-

mitment to ensuring the Indian Armed Forces can seamlessly and effectively employ the platform upon delivery. Wilsbach also underscored USAF's readiness to further support IAF's modernisation efforts, noting the mutual benefits of pursuing these goals through defence industrial collaboration. "It was an honour to host Air Chief Marshal AP Singh for this important counterpart visit," he said.

"Throughout his day at the Pentagon, we had great discussions focused on modernisation efforts, future training opportunities and our shared commitment to a free, open and prosperous Indo-Pacific," Wilsbach said. (PTI)

Kim Jong Un backs China's push for a Multipolar World

KIM TONG-HYUNG
■ Seoul

North Korean leader Kim Jong Un has voiced support for China's push to build a "multipolar world" and called for deeper ties between the traditional allies during a meeting with Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi, state media said on Saturday.

During the meeting on Friday, Kim said his Government will fully support Chinese efforts to achieve territorial integrity based on its "one-China principle," a reference to Beijing's official position that Taiwan is an inalienable part of China's territory, according



to North Korea's official Korean Central News Agency.

Kim also outlined North Korea's position on unspecified regional and international issues of "mutual concern" and said sustained

development of ties between the two countries has become more crucial in the current geopolitical environment, KCNA said.

Wang, on a two-day trip to North Korea, said the countries' relations were entering a "new phase" following a summit last year between Kim and Chinese President Xi Jinping. Embracing the ideas of a "new Cold War" and a "multipolarised world," Kim has sought to break out of international isolation and push a more assertive foreign policy by expanding ties with Governments locked in confrontations with the United States. (AP)

BRIEFLY

Malen gives Roma comfortable victory against Pisa



Donyell Malen scored a hat-trick as Roma beat Pisa 3-0 and inflicted a seventh defeat in eight games on Serie A's bottom club. A marauding Malen cut a swathe through the Pisa defense after only three minutes to drive home the opener and he doubled Roma's lead with a second from point-blank range two minutes before the break. His third, seven minutes into the second half, came courtesy of a lovely through ball from Matias Soule that Malen dispatched with aplomb. The Dutch striker has been a standout performer since joining Roma on loan from Aston Villa in January. Friday's goals took his tally for the half season to 10 in 12 league games. The result was nevertheless just the second win in eight games for Roma which, during that poor spell, was knocked out of the Europa League and beaten 5-2 by Serie A leader Inter Milan. Roma has risen to sixth, equal on points with Juventus, which has a game in hand against Atalanta on Saturday. Roma was also a point behind Como, which is at home to Inter on Sunday.

Akshay Bhatia misses cut, Rai T-32nd at Masters



A closing double bogey in the second round resulted in Indian-American golfer Akshay Bhatia missing the cut for the first time in three starts at the Masters. The 24-year-old, a three-time PGA Tour winner, opened with a 73 but endured a dramatic collapse on the back nine of his second round, carding three double bogeys to go eight-over across the last nine holes on Friday. With a second round card of 77, Bhatia missed the cut by two shots — the same number of shots he lost on the final hole. His double bogey at the 18th came after a wayward tee shot into the trees, which effectively sealed his early exit. In contrast, Indo-British Aaron Rai, winner of the Par-3 contest, progressed to the weekend rounds. Despite three consecutive bogeys from the ninth to the 11th, Rai steadied himself with seven pars to close, signing for a 74. Coupled with his opening 71, he sits at one-over, tied 32nd, slipping from his first-round position of 10th. Bhatia's exit was surprising as he came into the Masters playing great golf, including a win at the Arnold Palmer Invitational. His short-game prowess and putting were expected to be weapons at Augusta National. He shot one over in the first round and went out in three under on his front nine on Friday to move into contention. But the back nine was brutal for Bhatia as he came home in 44.

McIlroy sets Masters record with 6-shot lead

DOUG FERGUSON
■ Augusta

The only thing that stopped Rory McIlroy in the Masters was running out of holes to play. McIlroy stood on the 12th tee in a tie with Patrick Reed and with a dozen other players bunched together in what was shaping up to be a compelling chase for the green jacket.

Six birdies over his final seven holes for a 7-under 65 left everyone to wonder if they were playing for second. McIlroy's fourth straight birdie to close out the best round of the week gave him a six-shot advantage, setting the Masters record for largest 36-hole lead. "I knew I had some chances coming in

when I was standing on the 12th tee, but I didn't think I'd birdie six of the last seven," he said. "It just shows what you can do around here."

He did it in spectacular fashion. McIlroy twice made birdie on the par 5s after laying up from the trees. He twice had short putts on the par 3s. And if all that wasn't enough, he chipped in from 30 yards up a slope so steep he couldn't even see the hole. The final hour of a fascinating day started to look like a victory lap for McIlroy, who spent 17 years trying to win the Masters and now looks like he can't wait to do it again.

His tee shot over Rae's Creek on the dangerous 12th hole landed 7 feet behind the flag. He birdied both par 5s



after having to lay up from the trees. He took advantage of the lower pin at the par-3 16th for what amounted to a tap-in birdie. And then he really sent the gallery into a frenzy when he chipped in from 30 yards on the 17th. McIlroy knew it was good

because "I could see everyone in the grandstand start to stand up."

And there was one more to go — another perfect approach that came down the slope to 6 feet for one last birdie. That put him at 12-under 132, six shots clear of

West Ham beat Wolves, send Tottenham into drop zone

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ London

West Ham beat fellow strugglers Wolverhampton Wanderers 4-0 and dropped Tottenham into the Premier League drop zone for the first time this season.

Spurs were two points behind the Hammers before heading to Sunderland on Sunday. Valentin Castellanos scored twice in three minutes midway through the second half after Konstantinos Mavropanos put the Hammers 1-0 up with a header just before halftime.

Konstantinos completed the scoring seven minutes



from time with an acrobatic volley from a corner kick.

Wolves remained at the bottom of the league and was almost certain to be relegated. Neither side excelled in a forgettable first half but West

Ham went in a goal to the good when Mavropanos nodded home a cross from Jarrod Bowen.

Castellanos made it two after 66 minutes thanks to a deliciously cheeky assist from Pablo and then the same player added a third three minutes later with a low shot that may have been aided by a slight deflection.

Konstantinos' fourth was the icing on the cake for the home side that celebrated its first league win in over a month. "We are extremely happy," Hammers coach Nuno Espirito Santo said. "All of us deserve an evening like this, especially our fans."

Atiqa Mir now top-ranked in FIA Kart Ranking

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Lonato (Italy)

Indian racing prodigy Atiqa Mir has emerged as the highest-ranked female in the latest FIA International Kart Ranking (IKR) in her category, marking a milestone moment in her fast rising career.

The 11-year-old is placed in seventh overall position in the International OK-NJ class (age 12-14), making her the highest-ranked female racer in the rankings calculated by the motorsport's world governing body FIA. The rankings are led by Zoltan Coigny of Switzerland.

Atiqa, the first Indian to be supported by Formula 1 Academy, was fast tracked into the Junior category (age



12-14) from the mini class (8-12) at the start of 2026 considering her special talent.

She repaid the immense faith shown by her backers by bagging a historic podium in the opening round of the Champions of the Future Academy (COTFA) series in Valencia last month. Her

father Asif Mir, who was India's first national karting champion, is pleased with his daughter's rapid rise in the world of motorsport without losing sight of the ultimate goal — reaching Formula 1 — with no female having raced there since 1992.

"Atiqa has reached a big

milestone in her career due to her hard work and support from everyone involved in her journey. It is a proud moment for India. She needs to keep working hard and improving, it is a moving target. There is a famous saying in racing 'if you sit still you are moving backwards'," said Asif.

Last month, Atiqa capped off a successful campaign in the WSK Super Master Series with a commendable eighth place finish out of 53 drivers in the final round at Franciacorta.

After a welcome break of two weeks, she is back testing in Lonato this weekend ahead of WSK Euro Round 2 at the same circuit the following week.

Bellingham returns to Real Madrid lineup

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Madrid



Jude Bellingham's first start since Feb. 1 was not enough to spark a Real Madrid revival as they drew with Girona 1-1 and missed a chance to put pressure on La Liga leader Barcelona.

Bellingham was withdrawn after 10 minutes in a game against Rayo Vallecano and subsequently missed nine club matches, including the twin victories over Manchester City that took Real Madrid into the Champions League quarter-finals. He made three substitute appearances in Madrid's previous three games but started against Girona in a fixture the home side

needed to win to cut into Barcelona's seven-point lead. Instead, Madrid ended the night ruing missed opportunities.

Federico Valverde put Madrid 1-0 up six minutes into the second half when the Girona goalkeeper allowed his long-range shot to squirm through his hands. But visiting Girona wasted

umphed in a playoff to finally prove he could win at Augusta National. Maybe he should start thinking about next year's menu for the Masters Club dinner. "I know what can happen around here, good and bad," McIlroy said with a smile. "You don't have to remind me not to get ahead of myself. There's a long way to go. I got off to an amazing start."

Augusta allowed for that. It was warmer, brighter, drier. The wind wasn't quite as strong and the gusts didn't swirl as much. And there was much better scoring in part because of more generous pin positions, including on 16 and 18, where cleanly struck shots could feed toward the hole. (AP)

Ayush Shetty storms into Badminton Asia final

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Ningbo (China)

India's Ayush Shetty stormed into the final, assuring at least a silver with a stunning three-game win over top seed and defending champion Kunlavut Vitidsarn at the Badminton Asia Championships here on Saturday. The world No. 25 rode on his superior attack and robust defence to script a sensational 10-21, 21-19, 21-17 comeback win over Vitidsarn, the Paris Olympic silver medalist and 2023 world champion.

He thus became the first Indian men's singles player after Dinesh Khanna to reach the finals of the prestigious tournament. Khanna remains



the only Indian to win the men's singles gold at the continental meet in 1965. Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty won the title in 2023. Ayush, the US Open Super 300 champion, will next face either Chinese Taipei's fourth seed Chou Tien Chen or second seeded Chinese Shi Yu Qi in the summit clash.

De Zerbi wants Tottenham to 'play with courage'

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ London

Roberto De Zerbi wants Tottenham to keep it simple. The new Spurs manager knows there's little time for anything else in a relegation battle. "I don't want to put confusion inside of the players. They have to be with a clear plan of the game and not too much instruction, not too much thinking," the Italian said Friday at his first press conference.

"They have to play with courage, with personality and they have to fight. My demand is to show the right spirit I want to see." De Zerbi was handed a five-year contract — though with no escape clause if relegated — with the immediate task of Premier League survival.



Tottenham is one point above the drop zone with seven matches remaining. De Zerbi previously worked in the Premier League as Brighton's manager and was most recently at Marseille, which he left in February after a disagreement with the French club's leadership.

Tottenham's first test under the new boss comes

Sunday at Sunderland. He's not overly concerned about implementing his style of play. "What I want to do, what I want to achieve immediately is the character, is the right spirit, the right courage to play, to attack, because the DNA of this club, of this squad, is to find the goal, to score," he said.

After a week or so of

working with the players, he said "I'm more positive, for sure" about Premier League survival. Spurs, the reigning Europa League champions, fired Igor Tudor after 44 days of an interim coaching spell that worsened Tottenham's plight. Tudor was brought in after Thomas Frank lasted just eight months on the job.

De Zerbi paid them respect on Friday. "I'm not better than Thomas Frank or Igor Tudor because I consider them very good coaches," he said. "I try to bring my style, myself, my character, my personality, my passion to help the players."

First of all, to show their qualities, because they have a lot of qualities and then to achieve our target, because the most important part now is our target."

Marseille halt shaky run to beat bottom club Metz

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Marseille (France)

Mason Greenwood provided two assists as Marseille bounced back from consecutive Ligue 1 defeats to overcome bottom side Metz 3-1.

Habib Beye's men came into the game having lost to Monaco and Lille by the same 2-1 scoreline and they were determined not to lose a second straight home match for the first time since November 2024.

Pierre-Emerick Aubameyang got them going after 13 minutes when he took Greenwood's pass and fired home to round off a quick counterattack.

Greenwood's assist allowed Igor Paixao to chip over the goalkeeper and make it 2-0 three minutes into



the second half. But a minute later Georgiy Tsitaishvili pulled a goal back for the visitor. However, Metz rarely threatened again and Hamed Junior Traore completed the scoring in stoppage time for 3-1 and to lift Marseille above Lille and into third place. Metz remained on the bottom of

the 1 table and almost certain to be relegated.

Paris stun Monaco: Paris FC scored three times in the first 24 minutes to pave the way towards a statement 4-1 victory over Monaco and end its seven-game winning run. Jonathan Ikone got a brace, either side of a goal from

Italian Ciro Immobile, and put the home side in the driving seat. Monaco pulled a goal back shortly before halftime through Folarin Balogun but Paris substitute Luca Koleosho added the fourth after 71 minutes and extend the club's sterling run under Antoine Kombouare, the coach appointed in late February.

The capital side has gone six matches unbeaten since he took over, taking 12 points from a possible 18 in the process. The result lifted it above Angers and into 12th place in Ligue 1. It was a chastening defeat for Monaco, for which Paul Pogba appeared as a second half substitute for the first time since December. Monaco stayed in fifth place but could be passed by Lyon and Rennes, who play this weekend.

Britain advance to Billie Jean King Cup finals

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Melbourne

Britain advanced to the Billie Jean King Cup finals when doubles pair Harriet Dart and Jodie Burrage beat Australia's Storm Hunter and Ellen Perez 6-3, 6-4 to clinch the teams' best-of-five matchup Saturday.

The visitors had built a 2-0 lead Friday when 17-year-old Mika Stojsavljevic beat Talia Gibson 7-6 (4), 7-5, and Dart topped Kimberly Birrell 4-6, 6-3, 6-3 in singles matches at John Cain Arena.

In a consolation win, 17-year-old Australian Emerson Jones beat Katie Swan 7-5, 6-3 to make the score 3-1. The



finals of the Billie Jean King Cup, a women's team tournament formerly called the Fed Cup, will be held in Shenzhen in September. Host nation China qualified automatically. Six other finalists will be determined Saturday: defending champion Italy vs. Japan; Kazakhstan vs. Canada; Switzerland vs. Czech Republic; Slovenia vs. Spain; Belgium vs. United States; Poland vs. Ukraine.

It is my biggest appeal: Vimal backs 21-point system

AMIT KUMAR DAS
■ New Delhi

Former India chief coach Vimal Kumar has made a strong appeal to the Badminton World Federation (BWF) to retain the current 21-point, best-of-three scoring format, insisting that it represents the true essence of the sport.

The game's global governing body has proposed switching to a 3x15 scoring format from the current 3x21 system, with a membership vote on the change scheduled at the BWF Annual General Meeting in Horsens, Denmark, on April 25.

Following Ayush Shetty's sensational win over top

seed and defending champion Kunlavut Vitidsarn in the semifinals, Vimal spoke to PTI about the scoring system and the evolution of the young Indian shuttler, who is on the cusp of making history at the Badminton Asia Championships.

"This is real badminton and this needs to be preserved. Now BWF is thinking about reducing the scoring format and fiddling with the scores and such things for commercial reasons. That is not real badminton," Vimal told PTI.

"I hope they take note of this and preserve it, at least in big events, because badminton is a tough sport. They need to understand it."



Drawing comparisons with other global sports, the 63-year-old lead coach at the Centre of Excellence in Bengaluru questioned the need for the change.

"See, whether it is golf or motorsports or football, they

go on for three hours, five hours, and they have never diluted it. Hockey has never diluted it. Basketball has not diluted it."

Highlighting badminton's global appeal, Vimal added, "Badminton is a sport that is

widely watched. It has a big following in China, Indonesia, India and other places. So why do these few people think that it needs to be shortened and they want all the five events to get over in three hours — men's, women's, women's doubles, everything?"

Vimal, who is also the Director of the Centre for Badminton Excellence, pointed out that frequent changes have already disrupted the sport.

"They've already been fiddling with it for so many years. Badminton is a technical and a physical sport. So it should be... at least this 21 format is working really well and that should be pre-

served. So that is my biggest appeal." Last month, London Olympic bronze medallist Saina Nehwal had also urged BWF to exercise caution regarding proposed scoring changes, maintaining that the current 21-point system preserves the sport's essential intensity and endurance.

Collaborative coaching approach key to Ayush's success: Vimal

Elated with his ward Ayush becoming the first Indian men's singles player after Dinesh Khanna (1965) to reach the final of the continental showcase, Vimal said a collaborative coaching approach has aided the youngster's rise. (PTI)

Sanju Samson’s hundred gives CSK first win of IPL 2026

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Chennai

After three silent outings, Sanju Samson rediscovered his batting range with a fabulous hundred and bowlers’ fangs regrew as Chennai Super Kings defeated Delhi Capitals by 23 runs to register their first win of IPL 2026 here on Saturday.

Samson (115 not out, 56 balls) and Ayush Mhatre (59, 36 balls) milked 113 runs for the second wicket to power CSK to a competitive 212 for two and the Delhi Capitals stumbled against Jamie Overton’s superb spell (4/18) to get bundled out for 189.

Tristan Stubbs (60) delayed the inevitable for DC with a gutsy half-century.

While it was the super Kings’ first win of the season, the Capitals slumped to their second defeat in a row.

Chasing 213, Delhi made a bold start, making 61 in just five overs through a fine stand between openers KL Rahul and Pathum Nissanka (41).

But the dismissal of Nissanka took some steam away from DC. Nissanka, whose catch was grassed by Khaleel Ahmed off Anshul Kamboj, could not use the let off as he spooned the next ball off the pacer to Dewald Brevis at the edge of the circle.

At 61 for two in 5.2 overs, DC were still in a good posi-

tion but the Chennai bowlers redrafted their strategy at this stage.

Their pacers — Overton, Khaleel and Kamboj — began to bash the ball into the red-soil surface and extracted good bounce, cramping the DC batters for space to execute their shots effectively.

Sameer Rizvi and Axar Patel fell to such deliveries, and Sarfaraz Khan played a big role in the latter’s dismissal with a tremendous full-length diving catch at point.

They still had David Miller and Tristan Stubbs at their roster to challenge CSK, but Overton’s lovely hard-length ball clipped Miller’s leg-stump bails to compound the



Chennai Super Kings’ Sanju Samson, right, celebrates his century with Shivam Dube during an Indian Premier League (IPL) 2026 T20 cricket match between Chennai Super Kings and Delhi Capitals, in Chennai

worries for the Delhi side.

But Samson was the chief architect of CSK’s wonderful Chepauk night.

After being asked to bat first, Sasmsom brought up his first substantial knock in a Yellow jersey, and was involved in an excellent stand with Mhatre, who underlined his massive potential in bold letters, for the second wicket — 113 runs in a little over 11 overs.

It was Samson’s fourth IPL hundred, the first for CSK and the first one in this IPL season.

A big score from Samson was essential for himself and CSK to restore the belief of ‘Anbu-den’ faithfuls in their team, and he did that on the night with a brilliant innings in front of home fans.

It was the typical Samson innings. The Kerala batter had looked unsure of his feet and field placings in earlier matches this season, but on this instance a familiar Samson returned.

The feet, eyes and hands rediscovered their coordination and consequently the shots flowed in all directions off the field. However, skipper Ruturaj Gaikwad failed to accelerate even in Power Play, and his 62-run opening wicket alliance was entirely built on Samson’s aggression.

Samson gave an early indication of his touch with two back-to-back fours off

pacer Mukesh Kumar but the stand out shot during his stint was a six over extra cover off left-arm wrist spinner Kuldeep Yadav.

Fortune too lent its assistance to Samson as he was dropped on 55 by Pathum Nissanka near long-off off Axar Patel.

The 31-year-old fully exploited his reprieve and made DC pay for their lapse. Samson fetched his fifty in 26 balls, one less than Mhatre, and hundred in 52 balls as CSK moved on nicely.

Mhatre, on the other hand, was a real treat to watch until he was retired out after a well-compiled knock, to give the big-hitting Shivam Dube a chance.

Shreyas leads by example as PBKS beat SRH

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mullanpur

Shreyas Iyer once again proved his worth as a leader and a batter, guiding Punjab Kings to a commanding six-wicket victory over Sunrisers Hyderabad in an Indian Premier League match here on Saturday.

After an astute piece of captaincy, Shreyas led by example with an unbeaten 69 off 33 balls to help PBKS chase down a daunting target of 220 with as many as seven balls to spare.

The foundation for the victory was laid by a rollicking 99-run opening stand between Priyansh Arya (57 off 20 balls) and Prabhsimran Singh (51 of 25), after Abhishek



Sharma unleashed a brutal onslaught with a blistering 28-ball 74 to power SRH to 219 for six. Sent in, Abhishek and Travis Head (38 off 23 balls) blew away the PBKS bowlers with a 120-run opening partnership in a mere 8.1 overs.

The home team though made a fine comeback with

eight sixes and five fours. In reply, PBKS got the start they needed and raced to 93 for no loss in the powerplay, with the opening duo of Priyansh and Prabhsimran going hammer and tongs at the SRH bowlers. Left-arm spinner Harsh Dubey leaked 18 runs in the first over, providing PBKS with the perfect launch pad.

Prabhsimran danced down the ground to get a couple of sixes, including one against veteran left-arm seamer Jaydev Unadkat, even as Eshan Malinga gave away 17 runs. Priyansh then hammered Harshal Patel for 6, 6, 4, 4 to race to a 16-ball fifty.

Shivam Kumar raised SRH hopes by picking three wickets but Shreyas completed the job for his side. Earlier,

I look at the ball not the bowler: Sooryavanshi on tackling pacers

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Guwahati

The other day, it was Jasprit Bumrah. On Friday, Josh Hazlewood bore the brunt of Vaibhav Sooryavanshi’s blazing blade, as the 15-year-old insisted that he “plays the ball” and “not the bowler”.

Sooryavanshi smashed 78 off just 26 balls as Rajasthan Royals chased down Royal Challengers Bengaluru’s total of 201 with two overs to spare. “I try to execute what I practice and back my natural game.

Yes, at the back of your mind, you know who the bowler (Bumrah or



Hazlewood) is but you play the ball not the bowler,” said Sooryavanshi, who hit the star Aussie for three boundaries and a six off four successive deliveries. Having seen instant superstardom, Sooryavanshi said that his feet are firmly rooted to the ground with his father Sanjiv and RR support Romi Bhinder always around him with sane suggestions. “They always tell me that it is a long journey and my focus should only and only be on the game,” he said.

Happy to bat anywhere team wants: Dhruv Jurel on No. 3 role

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Guwahati

With two fifties, including a career-best unbeaten 81, from four innings wicketkeeper-batter Dhruv Jurel is relishing his new-found role at No. 3 but insists it is “just a number” and he is willing to bat wherever the team needs him.

Walking in at a tricky 21/1 in just the second over of a 202-run chase, Jurel anchored Rajasthan Royals’ innings to perfection with a composed 43-ball effort, guiding them to a comfortable victory over defending champions Royal Challengers Bengaluru in just 18 overs and extending their unbeaten run to four matches.

“I was batting at No. 5-6 last year. At the end, you have to win the match. The manage-



ment showed faith in me to promote me to No. 3,” Jurel said at the post-match press conference here on Friday.

“It’s just a number, I would say. I don’t want a particular number. My character is like that... Even if you give me No. 8-9, I will happily contribute, even if it means hitting the winning six. Wherever the team needs me, I’m there.”

Coming in after the explosive duo of Yashasvi Jaiswal and Vaibhav Sooryavanshi, and ahead of Windies big-hitter Shimron Hetmyer, it is a tricky position, but Jurel has lived up to expectations.

Such has been his impact that Rajasthan’s top three dominate the leading run-getters’ tally this season, with Sooryavanshi (200) leading the chart, followed by Jaiswal

in’,” he said about the 24-run over that included two fours and two sixes.

“When you go in, he’s hitting the ball so well. And then there is pressure too... That he is playing so well, I have to do something too. Again, it’s also easy because you feel that if he is playing so well, so can I,” Jurel said.

“It’s a bit of both. All you need is the first boundary to feel a bit relaxed.” “It was my highest score. When Vaibhav got out, he had already made the chase easy, and after he got out, the required run rate was just 6-7. So my job was just to get it done.”

RR’s batting looks formidable, with experienced all-rounder Jadeja slotted at No. 6 after his switch from Chennai Super Kings.

Dear Vaibhav, well done: Kohli’s message after Sooryavanshi blitz

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Guwahati

For a young cricketer, a few words of praise from superstar Virat Kohli can feel like a standing ovation, and Vaibhav Sooryavanshi had his moment after yet another breathtaking performance in the IPL.

The 15-year-old continues to carve a fearless reputation, taking on the best with remarkable ease. Fresh from unsettling Jasprit Bumrah, he went after Australian quick Josh Hazlewood, smashing a stunning 78 off just 26 balls to steer Rajasthan Royals to a comfortable six-wicket win over Royal Challengers



Bengaluru here on Friday. After the match, Kohli signed the youngster’s cap and left a simple but special message: “Dear Vaibhav, well done.”

The innings also propelled Sooryavanshi to the top of

the run charts this season, earning him the Orange Cap. Rajasthan Royals stayed unbeaten with four wins in as many games, while the defending champions suffered their first loss of the campaign.

For a 15-year-old, Vaibhav is too matured: Bhuvi



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Guwahati

He may be just 15 years of age, but Vaibhav Sooryavanshi is already batting with a clarity and composure that defy his age, said Royal Challengers Bengaluru seamer Bhuvneshwar Kumar.

Sooryavanshi blazed his way to a stunning 78 off just 26 balls before Dhruv Jurel anchored the chase with an unbeaten 81, as Rajasthan Royals put past defending champions Royal Challengers Bengaluru by six wickets and two overs to spare, stretching their unbeaten run to four matches this season.

“The way he is hitting shots. He is not slogging, he is hitting proper shots. For a 15-year-old, he is too mature. So yes, I think we should give him credit for the way he is batting, and he is batting really well. So he deserves all the credit,” Bhuvneshwar Kumar said at the post-match press conference on Friday.

Despite Sooryavanshi’s onslaught, which included eight fours and seven sixes, Bhuvneshwar maintained that RCB never felt complete-

Home form a concern as LSG bank on momentum against GT

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Lucknow

Lucknow Super Giants may have unearthed a new star in Mukul Choudhary, but their poor home record remains a major concern as they host Gujarat Titans in their Indian Premier League clash here on Sunday. Both teams head into the contest on the back of morale-boosting away wins.

GT sealed a thrilling one-run victory over Delhi Capitals for their first win of the season, while LSG registered two impressive wins on the road against Sunrisers Hyderabad and Kolkata Knight Riders. However, LSG have struggled to turn the Ekana Cricket Stadium into a fortress. They lost six of their eight matches here last



season, including five in a row, en route to a seventh-place finish, and overall, have managed just nine wins from 22 games at the venue.

This season too, they started with a batting collapse at home, getting bowled out for 141 in the six-wicket loss to DC.

With this being only their second home game this year, LSG will be desperate to set the record straight.

The team, though, will not be short on confidence after back-to-back away wins.

The last outing against KKR was particularly special, marking the emergence of a new ‘finisher’ in Mukul.

The unheralded 21-year-old from Rajasthan lit up the stage with a stunning six-hitting display, powered by

lightning bat speed and a wide range of strokes, including the trademark helicopter shot of his idol, MS Dhoni, to emerge as the latest IPL sensation. Another positive is the return to form of Ayush Badoni, who struck a half-

century against KKR to set up the chase.

Badoni being among runs adds depth to an already formidable top-five featuring Mitchell Marsh, Aiden Markram, skipper Rishabh Pant and Nicholas Pooran.

Rashid has been back to his best in the previous game against DC, returning with Player-of-the-Match figures of 3/17 that made the difference in their one-run win.

Amid criticism that opposition batters had begun to decode his variations, Rashid responded strongly with a vintage display in the middle overs, with his wickets including that of Delhi’s breakout star Sameer Rizvi for a golden duck after three successive fifties.

There has also been positive news on the batting front for GT, with England veteran Jos Buttler returning to form with a 27-ball 52, while skipper Shubman Gill marked his comeback from injury with a sparkling 70 at the top.

Mumbai Indians look to bounce back on home turf against formidable RCB

DEVARCHIT VARMA
■ Mumbai



Back in familiar territory after yet another slow start to their Indian Premier League campaign, Mumbai Indians will be keen to make the most of their return to home turf when they take on defending champions Royal Challengers Bengaluru here on Sunday.

For the first time in 13 seasons, MI made a winning start to an IPL season when they defeated Kolkata Knight Riders by six wickets here at the Wankhede Stadium nearly two weeks ago.

But the five-time title winners failed to build on it, as they lost both their away fixtures by big margins and

are now languishing in eighth place with a poor Net Run Rate (-0.715).

Even as Rohit Sharma briefly held the Orange Cap, batting remains a concern for MI and a collective show would be the need of the

hour against an opponent as robust as RCB.

Despite lacking match-time, Rohit has emerged as the frontrunner among the MI batters where there are some concerns especially around the form of both

middle order mainstay in Tilak Varma and Suryakumar Yadav. Suryakumar struck an important half-century against Delhi Capitals but could not carry on in the next game against Rajasthan Royals, whereas captain Hardik Pandya is yet to fire with the bat in this IPL.

MI batters just could not find their rhythm on a batting-friendly wicket in Guwahati, where Royals’ Yashasvi Jaiswal and Vaibhav Sooryavanshi had played their bowlers in the first innings in the rain-curtailed game. Even the immaculate Jasprit Bumrah was at the receiving end against the RR batters who added 59 runs in 3.2 overs of the powerplay. Bringing back the left-arm

spin of Mitchell Santner would be another option for MI, who continue to wait for the arrival of their English all-rounder Will Jacks.

MI will know they have their task cut out against a well-oiled unit who too are coming off a defeat. RR’s juggernaut hit RCB hard when the young Sooryavanshi and Dhruv Jurel’s brilliance took their side over the line even as the visitors set up a target in excess of 200 in Guwahati on Friday.

While RCB will have a short turnaround time, the camp would be relaxed knowing there is requisite firepower in the ranks to make the most of the batting-friendly conditions here.

RCB captain Rajat Patidar

(142 runs), the indomitable Virat Kohli (129) and an in-form Devdutt Padikkal (125) form the batting fulcrum for their side who have hard-hitters in Tim David (99) and even Romario Shepherd and Venkatesh Iyer to play the role of finishers.

RCB won’t be too concerned with Phil Salt’s slow start to the tournament knowing Kohli’s consistency at the top, where he can both accelerate or anchor the innings for others to capitalise. The return of Josh Hazlewood to their bowling attack makes RCB strong even more as he has forged an impactful partnership with India veteran Bhuvneshwar Kumar with the new ball.

(PTI)

A Brew-Tiful Experience

Moving beyond instant caffeine hits, Indian coffee lovers are reclaiming the morning ritual. We examine how massive chains and boutique brewers perfect the pour

PURE EXTRACTION

SAKSHI PRIYA

How did a frantic flock of goats on an ancient Ethiopian plateau dictate our modern morning rituals? A goat herder named Kaldi started this whole obsession centuries ago when his flock chewed on some weird red berries. Fast forward to now. We tap apps for a coffee fix in under ten minutes flat. But honestly? I've noticed a real shift. More of us want to hit pause and bring the slow brew back. Why do we still crave the physical grind and rising steam? For true purists, the ritual demands raw authenticity. They strip away sweet syrups to reveal the unflavoured beauty of a classic roast, where natural bitterness and acidity tell the story of the soil.

To understand how this deep devotion took root in India, we must examine the institutional pioneers. Barista Coffee Company opened its doors in the year two thousand to introduce a truly Italian espresso environment. Can massive scale genuinely coexist with artisanal quality? Serving upwards of fifty thousand beverages daily, the brand relies on absolute mechanical discipline.

Barista turns the daily rush into a precise art where strict training and standardised protocols allow them to pull thousands of perfect espresso shots daily. This technical discipline guarantees that signature rich Italian warmth and consistency in every single cup.

Chief Executive Officer Rajat Agrawal transitioned from corporate finance to steer this immense operation. He understands that maintaining this staggering output requires rigorous training programmes and strict protocols. From the initial bean selection to the final extraction, the espresso machine demands technical mastery. A flawless pour requires the perfect balance of pressure and temperature to ensure a patron experiences the exact same flavour profile as someone in Colombo.

If Barista got the masses hooked, the new wave of boutique cafes wants to dig deeper into the actual craft. Take Coffee Sutra, quietly brewing out of Jaipur since 2021. They skip the mass production to obsess entirely over the fine art of specialty coffee. Across all their outlets and partner cafes, the brand brews between fifteen hundred and two thousand cups daily. Founder Dushyant Singh notes that 80-85 per cent of these orders remain espresso based milk drinks leaning heavily on chocolatey and caramel notes. However, he observes a steady rise in customers choosing specialty black coffee. Indian drinkers have become highly experimental, walking into

cafes already understanding origins and brewing processes, moving away from simple caffeine fixes to seek aromatic cups with balanced acidity. During his extensive travels in Thailand, he discovered a unique piece of equipment called the Gabi Drip Master. By utilising a highly controlled water flow, the Gabi evenly saturates the grounds, removing the delicate margin for human error. Singh notes it brings out a clean flavour and reduces physical effort, ensuring consistent quality. The visual appeal of a careful pour over makes the entire process highly shareable online, drawing curious minds to the counter to try something new. At the end of the day, the real magic of the bean comes down to a bit of shared patience, getting the water maths spot on, and the sheer comfort of that first, desperate sip. Right, whose round is it?

CONTROLLED DRIP

Brought to India first by Coffee Sutra, the clever Gabi pour-over device changes the game. By strictly controlling water flow, it removes all guesswork. This guarantees a remarkably clean, consistent cup every single time, stripping away human error without ever sacrificing the rich flavour.

PHOTO: PANKAJ KUMAR

Words outlive silence

Can poetry make a restless city like Delhi heal hearts and quietly bridge generations?

SAKSHI PRIYA

A city that outruns its own shadow sometimes needs a quiet corner to bleed on paper. The 57th Shankar Shad Mushaira swung its gates wide open and pulled in thousands of Delhi folks all bonded over their love for Urdu poetry, a sight that truly tugged at the heart. The Shankar Lall Murlidhar Memorial Society teamed up with DCM Shriram Industries Ltd to bring together poets from Bareilly, Mumbai, Jodhpur, and Hyderabad, where heavyweights like Javed Akhtar and Waseem Barelvi shared the stage with rising stars Hina Haider Rizvi and Zubair Ali Tabish.

"A ghazal leaves the poet the very moment it is spoken," Waseem Barelvi murmured into the microphone, capturing the heavy emotional moment of the night. "It then belongs to the person in the crowd who hears it and suddenly realises they are no longer alone in their grief."

You could practically hear a pin drop as quiet tears were wiped away in the dark, the audience completely absorbed in that shared vulnerability. The evening's truest success was how it broke down the walls of literary elitism. It built a vital path for those unseen poets who usually keep their rawest, most vulnerable verses hidden away in private notebooks. The massive response to the open contest, which brought in over two thousand entries, showed a deep and quiet need for people to finally share their voices. It served as a powerful reminder that complex emotional observations carry absolutely no birth date. Seeing everyday dreamers embraced so warmly by the establishment felt like a necessary democratisation of poetry.

This shifting dynamic was perfectly anchored by Javed Akhtar, who looked out across the sea of faces and delivered a remarkably raw plea: "Write because the truth burns inside you."

The youth were certainly listening. Gen Z flocked to the venue in massive numbers, finding a safe haven to process modern anxieties through centuries-old verse. Grandparents leaned in to translate complex Urdu phrases for their grandchildren, bridging generations. Madhav Bansidhar Shriram observed how desperately our tired minds need these gatherings today. Long after the lamps were put out, Delhi went home holding onto a quiet, human connection, proving that a well-written nazm holds the absolute power to stop time.

PHOTOS: PANKAJ KUMAR

Eternal love finds voice

Love, loss, and longing collide as mythology transforms into deeply relatable human drama, says SAKSHI PRIYA

Navigating the ancient complexities of divine devotion requires a theatrical touch that borders on the miraculous, especially when tasked with resurrecting a twelfth-century Sanskrit epic for a contemporary crowd without losing its essential spiritual weight. Shivam Sahni's dance-theatre piece, *Gita Govinda – Where There is Radha, There is Hari*, manages to capture this elusive magic by entirely enveloping the viewer in a near-complete chronological narrative that modern stages seldom dare to attempt.

The lead actors took on these mythic roles with a raw, psychological edge that grounded the whole romance. Shimran Zaman brought Radha's desperate yearning to life with a completely honest physicality, making a centuries-old heartbreak feel incredibly real and immediate. Balancing out her chaotic grief, Shivam Sahni played Krishna with a quiet, effortless pull that anchored the entire show, whilst Kenisha Tandwalia was the perfect steadying presence as Sakhi, guiding the audience through the messy emotional wreckage of love and separation.

Classical texts often create a massive language barrier for everyday theatre-goers, but the direction completely fixed that by mixing sev-

enteen traditional ashtapadis with sharp English dialogue. This structural gamble pulled everyone straight into the heart of the story. It gave the spiritual weight of Jayadeva's original text room to breathe, whilst making sure the emotional stakes were obvious to the whole room.

The raw vulnerability from the cast found strong support behind the scenes. Shubha Mudgal's dense music and Sai Shrivastava's sharp sound design gave the performance a steady, driving rhythm. Instead of relying on empty spectacle, the visuals stayed earthy and real. Sandhya Raman's costumes and the detailed jewellery from Art Karat added a heavy, grounded elegance. It all worked naturally with Nilava Sen's choreography, turning unspoken grief into fierce, deliberate footwork. When the stage finally went black, the crowd was on its feet immediately. It showed that if you ditch the usual theatre gimmicks and focus purely on human connection, this old romance still hits incredibly hard today.

SAHNI'S RAW, GROUNDED STAGING PROVES JAYADEVA'S ANCIENT ROMANCE STILL HITS A VERY REAL MODERN NERVE

PHOTO: PANKAJ KUMAR

ART CORNER

DECIPHERING THE WORLD IS POETRY

Can a piece of canvas hold the exact second a poem breathes? The World is Poetry exhibition tries to find out. Brought to New Delhi by Parisian artists Yaseen Khan and Stéphanie Biville, this showcase feels deeply personal. Khan draws from his youth writing Urdu ghazals and translates those rhythmic verses into vivid strokes. Biville works differently. She lets her subconscious take the brush to reveal quiet, hidden landscapes. Together, they treat creation like a beautiful, blind puzzle. Under curator Pascal Biville's direction, the Rotunda Hall has become a rare space where philosophy and paint actually talk to each other. Every piece feels like an ongoing conversation about mystery and pure chance. You will likely find yourself standing still before these frames, trying to untangle their visual riddles. The show runs until Monday, April 13 at Bikaner House. Go see if you can catch the hidden verses before they pack up.

FIFTY FRAMES FACING THE SOUL

Seeing fifty portraits in a single room really should feel like far too much to take in. It makes you wonder if these faces are actually hiding their best secrets, rather than being completely honest about what they are showing us. Somehow at Bikaner House it feels like not enough time. Sonali Batra has arranged this show chronologically, which sounds like a curatorial cop-out until you're actually moving through it and realising the hanging is making an argument. Mughal court works sit near European academic paintings and the proximity is quietly devastating. Both do the same political work-keeping the powerful looking powerful. The Indian painters signed nothing while their European counterparts built careers; that gap tells you who portraiture actually served. Then Souza enters, his faces aggressive in their refusal to flatter. By the time you reach Krishen Khanna and Anjolie Ela Menon, the exhibition stops recording and starts excavating. This remains genuinely rare. Go on then, find out who is truly looking back at you at Bikaner House, New Delhi until April 15th 2026.

PHOTOS: PANKAJ KUMAR

The Pioneer AGENDA

Democracy is not something you believe in... it's something you do. You participate
— Abbie Hoffman



Delimitation 2027

Redrawing India's Political Map

As India prepares for its first delimitation exercise in over five decades, the stakes extend far beyond a routine constitutional update. Tied to the upcoming Census 2027, the process will fundamentally reshape representation in the Lok Sabha, altering the balance of power between States and testing the idea of fairness in a diverse federal democracy. With population growth diverging sharply across regions, the exercise raises a difficult question: should political power follow numbers alone, or also reflect governance and demographic discipline?

Delimitation and the new politics of power

Every democracy must periodically redraw its electoral map to reflect population change. In India, this process is known as delimitation. On paper, it is a routine constitutional exercise. In reality, the next delimitation-due after Census 2027-will be the most consequential redrawing of political power since Independence. It will redefine how seats are distributed in the Lok Sabha and how India understands fairness, federalism, and regional balance.

The Constitution originally mandated delimitation after every census. But this principle has been suspended for nearly half a century. The inter-state distribution of Lok Sabha seats has remained frozen since 1976, based on the 1971 Census, to ensure that States were not penalised for successfully controlling population growth. The 84th Constitutional Amendment (2001) extended this freeze until "the first census taken after the year 2026."

That suspension effectively ends with Census 2027. With the census process now underway, delimitation has moved from a distant prospect to an approaching institutional reality. Yet representation today continues to rest on an India of 548 million people, not the present reality of over 1.4 billion.

Delimitation is neither simple nor swift. India's previous four Delimitation Commissions took between three and five-and-a-half years. The last exercise (2002-2008) took over six years, though it was limited to redrawing constituency boundaries within States, without reallocating seats among them. The next Commission will face a far more complex task: redistributing seats among States for the first time since 1976, redrawing all constituencies, and operationalising the 33 per cent reservation for women.

Recent developments suggest that the political system may seek to advance parts of this process even before formal delimitation begins. The special session of Parliament convened on April 17-18, 2026, to consider measures relating to women's reservation and a possible expansion of the Lok Sabha indicates an emerging attempt to operationalise representation changes ahead of the more contentious exercise of inter-state redistribution. This raises the possibility of decoupling seat expansion and reservation from delimitation, at least in the interim.



SY QURAISHI
The writer is former Chief Election Commissioner of India

policy direction, that alternative explored.

The context today is fundamentally different from the 1970s. Then, fertility rates across States were broadly similar. Today, they have sharply diverged. Southern and western States have achieved below-replacement fertility through sustained investments in education, health, and women's empowerment. In contrast, States such as Uttar Pradesh and Bihar continue to record higher population growth.

If representation is recalibrated purely on population, the consequences will be stark. States that succeeded in controlling population growth will see their relative political weight decline, while those with higher growth will gain significantly.

Projections illustrate the scale of change. In an expanded Lok Sabha of around 816 seats, Uttar Pradesh could rise from 80 to about 139 seats, and Bihar from 40 to around 75-together approaching a quarter of the House. Tamil Nadu and Kerala would see their absolute numbers rise modestly, but their share decline-from 7.2 per cent to about 6.1 per cent and from 3.7 per cent to around 2.7 per cent, respectively. The shift is not merely numerical; it is structural.

This produces a moral and political paradox: should States be disadvantaged for good governance? For decades, India incentivised population stabilisation. Those that responded effectively now risk diminished representation. The logic that justified the freeze in 1976 and 2001 has not lost its relevance.

The Union Home Minister has assured that "not even one seat will be reduced" for any southern State, nor proportion disturbed. Yet such assurances, while politically significant, do not resolve the structural imbalance. Even if no State loses seats in absolute terms, a sharp increase in representation for others inevitably alters relative influence. Parliament functions through numbers, not proportions.

Even if Census data becomes available by 2028, completing delimitation before 2031-32 would be difficult. Consequently, the full implementation of women's reservation-if tied strictly to delimitation-may not occur before the 2034 general election. The current, however, suggests pathways may be explored.

ceals a deeper shift. When two States together approach a quarter of the Lok Sabha, the dynamics of coalition-building and legislative negotiation change fundamentally. The balance of federal power cannot be understood only in terms of absolute seats; it must be assessed in terms of relative weight.

Several options merit consideration. First, the current freeze could be extended beyond 2026 until fertility rates converge further. This would preserve the existing balance but raise legitimate concerns about representational fairness and could invite constitutional challenge under Article 14, as prolonged reliance on outdated popu-



TO TRULY DISMANTLE THE SYSTEMIC HURDLES OF GENDER DISCRIMINATION, BRIDGE THE GAP IN ACCESS TO OPPORTUNITIES, AND RECTIFY THE STARK UNDERREPRESENTATION OF WOMEN IN OUR POLITICAL REALM, THE PASSAGE OF THE WOMEN'S RESERVATION BILL IS NOT JUST A POLICY SHIFT – IT IS A MORAL AND DEVELOPMENTAL NECESSITY

lation data weakens the principle of equal suffrage.

Second, a weighted formula could be considered: for example, 70-80 per cent weight for population and 20-30 per cent for development indicators such as literacy, health outcomes, or sustained fertility reduction. This would mirror the composite criteria used by the Finance Commission and reward governance outcomes alongside demographic size.

Third, the Rajya Sabha could be strengthened as a genuinely federal chamber. The dilution of domicile requirements has weakened the organic link between members and their States.

CONTINUED ON >> PII

The nation progresses when women progress

On April 16, Parliament will discuss and pass a momentous women's reservation Bill. In the words of the Prime Minister, "It is an affirmation of a principle that has long guided our civilisational ethos-that society progresses when women progress." Women in ancient Bharat were central to the intellectual, spiritual, social, and even political spheres, and their potential was consciously recognised as *Nari Shakti*: the divine feminine energy that sustains and renews the world.

the Sadyodvaha (women who studied until marriage). Women who chose the path of lifelong learning were honoured as Brahmadhinis, a term denoting "someone with supreme knowledge" who was considered eligible to teach and debate on the scriptures. These women, also known as *Rishikas* (female seers), underwent initiation, studied the Vedas alongside men in *gurukulas* (residential schools), and participated fully in Vedic rituals and sacrifices.

The Rigveda and Upanishads mention numerous such learned women. Maitreyi and Gargi exemplify this intellectual tradition. The participation of women in religious sacrifices, which were crucial in the Vedic worldview, further reinforced their dignity. The Rigveda addresses women as "independent, loving, happy, tolerant, preserver of truth, scholar, learned, and glorious" (eg, Rigveda 5.61.6). No bar existed on their performing rituals or composing mantras. The early Vedic evidence thus shows women contributing to the sacred life of the household and community.

The Vedic speech goddess Vach is celebrated as the source of all utterance and knowledge. Legendary figures such as Gargi and Maitreyi appear as Brahmadhinis-women who debate with learned sages and kings over the nature of Atman (self) and Brahman (the highest power or ultimate reality), thereby embodying the same spiritual competence as their male interlocutors. Texts such as the Devi Mahatmyam and other Puranic texts shape and cement the concept of Devi, who is described as the power that resides in all beings and as the source of both cosmic order and final liberation.

Every woman in this worldview is not just a social actor but a living expression of that Shakti, whether as mother, scholar, queen, or renouncer. In the Epics, figures like Sita, Draupadi, and Savitri are not secondary in the story; they are Dharmic and spiritual agents whose verbal, moral, and yogic profundity directly determines the course of events.

Archaeological finds from Harappan cities such as Mohenjo-daro and Harappa display a remarkable respect for the feminine. The artistic figurines, often interpreted as mother goddess-



RK PACHNANDA
Former Chairman, Haryana Public Service Commission

es, pinpoint a culture that saw the female as the source of life, sustenance, growth, and abundance.

Social and legal rights complemented the prominent status of women. Marriage often took place by choice (swayamvara in the epics) or mutual consent in approved forms such as Brahma and Daiva. The eight forms of marriage in the Dharmashastras include Gandharva (love marriage), reflecting agency. Altekar's chapter on marriage details that early texts permitted widow remarriage (niyoga in limited cases) and emphasised the wife's central role in the grihastha (householder) stage.

Ancient Indian jurisprudence recognised a distinct category of women's property known as *Stridhana*. As documented in legal texts such as the Yajnavalkya Smriti, a woman had inalienable rights over property she received from her father, mother, husband, or brother, as well as gifts acquired during marriage ceremonies. The Gupta Empire, often hailed as the "Golden Age", saw women flourishing in the arts. Kalidasa's works portray women as literate, skilled in painting, and deeply engaged in the aesthetics of the court.

Furthermore, historical inscriptions reveal women in administrative roles. Queen Prabhavatigupta, daughter of Chandragupta II, ruled the Vakataka kingdom as regent for at least twenty years. Her copper-plate inscriptions show her exercising full sovereign power, issuing land grants, and managing state affairs. As ancient Indian society evolved, scholarly research traces a "chronological decline in their status and function". This transformation, while gradual, was significant and complex. By the later Vedic period (approximately 1000-600 BCE), women's presence in rituals was no longer considered necessary. Society became increasingly male-dominated. The marriageable age of girls began to decline. One begins to find clear evidence of restrictions imposed on women as part of the Smriti literature, particularly the Manusmriti (approx. circa 200 BCE-200 CE). This influential legal text outlined binding laws on marriage, inheritance, and female autonomy.

CONTINUED ON >> PII



WE WILL FORMULATE A COLLECTIVE STRATEGY BY HOLDING DISCUSSIONS WITH OUR COLLEAGUES IN THE OPPOSITION AS WELL. WE WILL MOVE FORWARD UNITEDLY

— MALLIKARJUN KHARGE
CONGRESS LEADER



WOMEN'S RESERVATION IS NOT ABOUT POLITICAL CREDIT; IT IS ABOUT DIGNITY, REPRESENTATION, AND THE RIGHTFUL EMPOWERMENT OF WOMEN. INDIA'S WOMEN DESERVE OUTCOMES

— DHARMENDRA PRADHAN
UNION MINISTER



States that have succeeded in controlling population growth will see their relative political weight decline, while those with higher growth will gain significantly

"I KNOW NOT WITH WHAT WEAPONS
WORLD WAR III WILL BE FOUGHT, BUT
WORLD WAR IV WILL BE FOUGHT
WITH STICKS AND STONES"
— ALBERT EINSTEIN



West Asia: War, survival, & the strategic reset

Wars in the modern era rarely end with clarity. They do not conclude with decisive battlefield triumphs or universally accepted outcomes. Instead, they end with narratives carefully constructed, politically driven, and strategically projected. What we are witnessing in the Middle East today is not merely a contest of military strength, but a deeper struggle over endurance, perception, and long-term geopolitical positioning. Beneath the visible layers of airstrikes, drone warfare, and diplomatic signalling lies a more fundamental reality: in modern conflict, survival itself has become the only meaningful measure of victory.

At the centre of this evolving landscape is a critical concept—the idea of a "simulated victory." As conflicts prolong and costs escalate, the incentive to declare success, regardless of ground realities, becomes stronger. A high-value target may be eliminated, a symbolic figure neutralised, or a temporary operational objective achieved. Such developments are then amplified and presented as decisive turning points. In this context, leaders like Benjamin Netanyahu may frame specific tactical outcomes as strategic breakthroughs. However, history consistently demonstrates that the removal of individuals rarely dismantles deeply embedded systems. Networks adapt, ideologies endure, and power structures reorganise. What appears to be victory often conceals a prolonged stalemate.

A defining feature of this conflict is the economic dimension, which is rapidly becoming as decisive as military capability. The asymmetry in cost structures is striking. Low-cost drones and improvised systems deployed by Iran or its regional partners can impose disproportionately high financial burdens on advanced defence systems. Intercepting relatively inexpensive threats with sophisticated missile defence platforms creates a dynamic where the technologically superior side faces escalating costs over time. This imbalance introduces a strategic paradox: strength becomes expensive, while persistence remains affordable.

For the United States, this economic strain is not an abstract concern—it is a tangible strategic constraint. Under leaders such as Donald Trump, whose geopolitical approach often emphasises measurable returns and cost-efficiency, prolonged engagements without clear outcomes become increasingly difficult to justify. If the financial and political costs of war continue to rise without delivering decisive results, the pressure to recalibrate strategy intensifies. Historical precedents, including shifts in U.S. engagement in conflict zones like Syria, suggest that such recalibration can occur abruptly when the balance between cost and benefit becomes unfavourable.

Compounding these challenges is the issue of intelligence miscalculation. Institutions such as the Central Intelligence Agency and Mossad have long been regarded as among the most capable intelligence organisations in the world. Yet, even the most sophisticated systems are not immune to misjudgment. The expectation that a rapid decapitation strike could destabilise or collapse Iran's strategic structure appears to have underestimated the resilience and adaptability of its governance and military networks. Instead of fragmentation, Iran demonstrated continuity. Instead of collapsing, it responded with calibrated resistance. What was intended as a swift and decisive

campaign has evolved into a prolonged contest of endurance.

This outcome is not accidental—it reflects a deliberate strategic doctrine. Iran's approach is built on the principle that survival is victory. Unlike conventional military doctrines that prioritise territorial gains or decisive defeats of the enemy, Iran's strategy focuses on maintaining regime continuity under pressure. The objective is not to win in the traditional sense, but to ensure that it does not lose. Every day that the system remains intact reinforces its legitimacy, both internally and within its network of regional alliances.

This strategy of patience is beginning to produce measurable effects. By avoiding confrontation with a superior military force and instead applying distributed pressure across multiple fronts, Iran has gradually reshaped the operational environment. The conflict is no longer confined to a single battlefield; it has expanded into a broader regional dynamic involving economic disruption, maritime tension, and proxy engagements. Over time, this sustained pressure begins to influence the calculations of other actors.

One of the most visible consequences is the gradual shifting of regional alignments. Countries that initially offered support, whether political, logistical, or economic, begin to reassess their positions as the conflict prolongs. The risks increase, the costs accumulate, and the benefits become uncertain. As a result, support becomes more cautious, more conditional, and in some cases, quietly withdrawn. This erosion of collective backing weakens the initial coalition and alters the strategic balance.

At the same time, the economic ripple effects of the conflict extend far beyond the region. Energy markets respond to instability, supply chains face disruption, and global financial systems absorb the shock of uncertainty. These pressures eventually circle back to domestic economies, including that of the United States. When the economic consequences of war begin to affect domestic stability, public sentiment, and political capital, the appetite for prolonged engagement diminishes significantly.

In such an environment, the prospects for meaningful negotiation become increasingly limited. Diplomacy requires not only willingness but also the right conditions—trust, stability, and a degree of mutual flexibility. However, the current context offers little of these. Leadership dynamics within Iran further complicate the picture. While figures like Ali Khamenei have historically balanced ideological firmness with strategic calculation, the emergence of a more headline orientation—often associated with Mojtaba Khamenei—signals a shift toward greater rigidity.



As the conflict continues to evolve, one reality becomes clear. Victory is no longer about defeating the enemy—it is about ensuring that one is not defeated. And in that quiet, often overlooked distinction lies the true nature of power in the 21st century

When leadership is shaped by direct conflict, personal loss, and heightened threat perception, the space for compromise narrows considerably. Decisions are influenced not only by strategic logic but also by emotional and ideological factors. In such circumstances, expecting rapid or meaningful negotiation may be unrealistic. Instead, the conflict is likely to transition into a prolonged phase of managed instability.

This phase will be characterised by an increase in proxy warfare. Indirect engagements offer several advantages: they are cost-effective, deniable, and capable of sustaining pressure without triggering full-scale escalation. For Iran, this aligns perfectly with its broader strategy. It allows the continuation of conflict without overextending resources, while simultaneously maintaining pressure on adversaries.

For Israel, this evolving scenario presents a complex and challenging environment. While it retains significant military and technological superiority, the nature of the threat is shifting. Instead of conventional warfare, it faces dispersed, persistent, and unpredictable forms of pressure. As regional alliances become less reliable and international support shows signs of fatigue, the possibility of strategic isolation becomes a growing concern.

Iran's leadership appears to understand this trajectory clearly. It does not seek to defeat the United States or Israel in direct confrontation. Instead, it aims to reshape the environment in which they operate—to increase costs, strain alliances, and prolong uncertainty.

Looking ahead, a plausible scenario begins to emerge. The United States, facing rising costs and domestic pressures, may choose to declare a form of strategic success. This declaration may be based on limited objectives: disruption of networks, targeted elimination, or containment of escalation. Such a move would allow for a gradual reduction of direct involvement without framing it as a withdrawal under pressure.

However, this does not resolve the underlying conflict. Instead, it shifts the burden to regional actors. The responsibility for managing ongoing tensions, countering proxy threats, and maintaining stability falls increasingly on local allies. Yet, these alliances are themselves under strain. Diverging interests, economic vulnerabilities, and political considerations make sustained coordination difficult. In this context, the risk is not a single, large-scale war, but a series of continuous, lower-intensity conflicts that keep the region in a state of persistent instability. This "new normal" is defined not by peace or war, but

by an ongoing condition of strategic tension.

The broader geopolitical implications are equally significant. Global powers such as China and Russia are closely observing these developments. At the same time, it creates opportunities to expand influence, particularly in post-conflict reconstruction and regional partnerships. At the heart of all these dynamics lies a fundamental shift in how victory is understood. The traditional notion of decisive, conclusive outcomes is increasingly irrelevant in modern conflict. Instead, success is measured by resilience—the ability to endure, adapt, and maintain continuity under pressure.

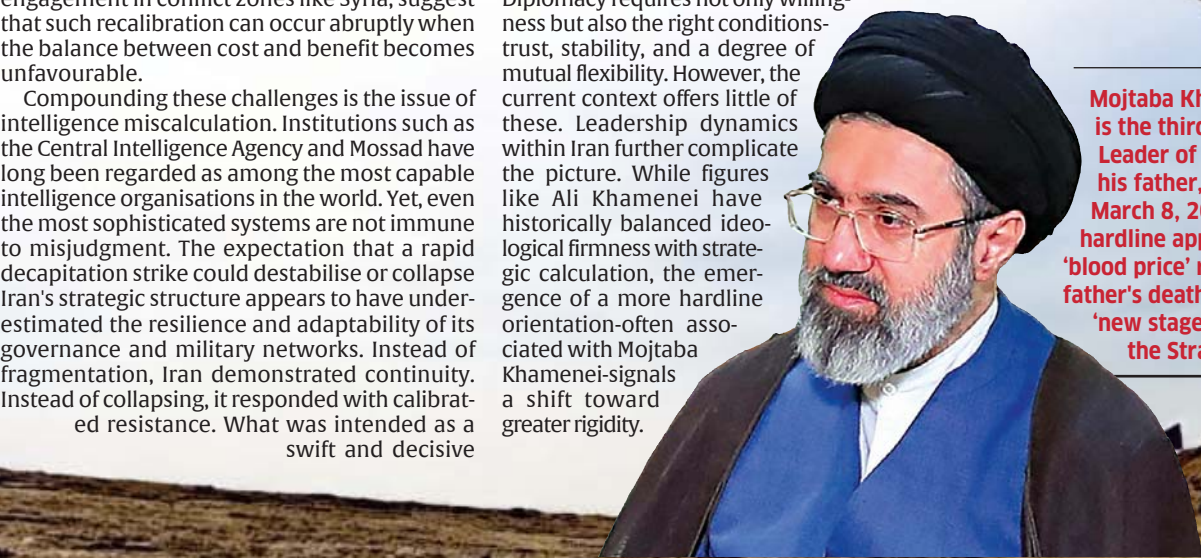
For Iran, this means survival of the regime. For Israel, it may mean maintaining security despite evolving threats.

For the United States, it involves balancing global commitments with domestic priorities and strategic constraints.

The most important lesson of this conflict is also the simplest: there are no true winners in modern war. What remains are degrees of loss, layers of narrative, and the enduring question of who managed to withstand the pressure.

The writer is a strategic affairs expert specialising in national security with a focus on geopolitical risk and asymmetric warfare.

Mojtaba Khamenei is the third Supreme Leader of Iran. He succeeded his father, Ali Khamenei, on March 8, 2026. He has adopted a hardline approach, vowing to seek 'blood price' reparations for his father's death and announcing a 'new stage' in managing the Strait of Hormuz.



FROM AGENDA COVER

Delimitation and the New Politics of Power

Restoring this connection is essential. More fundamentally, representation in the Rajya Sabha remains broadly population-based, limiting its federal balancing role. Alternative models—such as tiered representation or equal representation within defined categories of States—could be explored to restore equilibrium.

Fourth, the possibility of reorganising large States, particularly Uttar Pradesh, merits discussion. The creation of smaller States has precedent, and proposals for regions such as Bundelkhand and Purvanchal have persisted for long. Dividing a State with overwhelming projected representation could rebalance federal power without altering constitutional principles.

Fifth, redistribution could be phased across two electoral cycles—partially implemented in 2034 and completed in 2039—allowing political systems and regional balances to adjust gradually.

Beyond the formula, the process itself will be critical. The Delimitation Commission must be equipped with expertise in demography, constitutional law, and federal studies, and must ensure meaningful consultation with States. Transparency, public hearings, and institutional oversight will be essential to building trust.

The exercise will also redraw internal constituency boundaries. While the number of constituencies reserved for Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes is determined strictly by population, the selection of specific constituencies, particularly for SCs, allows for flexibility, which must be exercised transparently and consistently.

Delimitation is not a technical exercise; it is a constitutional moment. It will redistribute political voice, reshape coalition politics, and test the resilience of India's federal compact.

The Census will measure India's population; delimitation will measure its democracy. Once Census figures are published, positions will harden, and consensus will become

difficult. That is why the time for reasoned debate is now.

Handled with care, delimitation can modernise representation while preserving federal balance. Mishandled, it risks deepening regional anxieties and unsettling the moral equilibrium of the Republic.

The writer is former Chief Election Commissioner of India and the author of 'An Undocumented Wonder - The Making of the Great Indian Election' and 'Democracy's Heartland: Inside the Battle for Power in South Asia'

The Nation Progresses when Women Progress

Women were increasingly subordinated to male control, and their educational opportunities contracted. The same legal codes that enshrined Sridhana also increasingly circumscribed women's autonomy, creating a tension that persisted throughout Indian history.

However, in modern India, today, women

have emerged as a transformative force in shaping new Bharat—contributing significantly across political, economic, social, scientific and cultural spheres. Their growing participation reflects not only progress toward gender equality but also a strengthening of the nation's democratic and developmental foundations. In politics and governance, women have taken on leadership roles at the local, state, and national levels. Economically, women are key drivers of growth and innovation. In education and science, Indian women have made remarkable strides. Socially, women play a crucial role in driving change and fostering development. In the armed forces and security services, women are breaking traditional barriers and taking on challenging roles. Similarly, in sports and culture, women have brought laurels to the nation, inspiring future generations and challenging stereotypes.

It is heartening to see that the government has started several programmes and schemes, and many more are underway to empower and

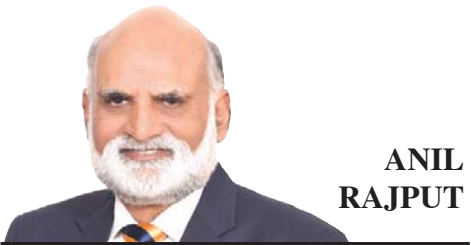
encourage women to take more decisive roles in the development journey of India.

While these achievements are significant, they represent only the beginning of a larger transformation. To truly dismantle the systemic hurdles of gender discrimination, bridge the gap in access to opportunities, and rectify the stark underrepresentation of women in our political realm, the passage of the women's reservation bill is not just a policy shift—it is a moral and developmental necessity.

By institutionalising the role of Nari Shakti at various levels of governance, we will infuse national progress with diverse perspectives and equitable leadership. This act of restorative justice will grant women their rightful place, finally fulfilling the egalitarian vision of our constitutional framers and ensuring a future where progress is defined by the participation of all.

The author is a Former Chairman, Haryana Public Service Commission, Chairman, Haryana Electricity Regulatory Commission, DG-ITBP, DG-NDRF and Commissioner of Police, Kolkata. He is Director, Bharat Ki Soch

The sacred and seasonal harvest of Baisakhi



ANIL
RAJPUT

Baisakhi is one of Northern India's most significant seasonal observances, particularly in Punjab, where it emerges as a revered convergence of labor, faith, and collective gratitude. Falling in mid-April as the wheat crop matures, the festival serves as an agrarian thanksgiving for nature's bounty. For the Sikh community, it holds an even deeper historical meaning as it marks the foundation of the Khalsa by Guru Gobind Singh in 1699 as a community committed to spiritual discipline, equality, and courage. This enhances the significance of Baisakhi from a harvest festival to a profound spiritual milestone. The result is a joyful celebration in which devotion, community, and festivity converge naturally. Nowhere is this more vividly expressed than in the food prepared on this occasion, shared, and enjoyed through the course of the day.

The history and culture of Baisakhi are inseparable from Punjab's landscape. For generations, the festival has marked the successful completion of the rabi cycle, especially the wheat harvest that has long sustained village economies and household life across the region. The ripened grain means more than just a means of livelihood, but symbolises assurance, continuity, and the reward of disciplined labour. This is why Baisakhi unfolds with such visible warmth. Villages and towns resonate with prayer, music, fairs, visits to gurdwaras, gatherings of extended families, and the exuberance of bhangra and giddha. Yet beneath this outward celebration lies a quieter sentiment of gratitude, for the abundance of the field and the promise of continuing prosperity. Food, thus, becomes a significant part as it transforms harvest into hospitality and labour into shared celebration.

In Sikh tradition, the day starts early and often begins at the gurdwara, where prayer, kirtan, and seva (selfless service) shape the spirit of the celebration. It is here that the Baisakhi cuisine first reveals its deeper meaning, not through extravagance, but through

reverence and equality. Kada prasad, warm and fragrant, is received with cupped hands and quiet gratitude. Made from wheat flour, ghee, and sugar, slowly roasted and stirred until it reaches its characteristic softness, it carries both sanctity and comfort. Alongside this, the tradition of Guru ka Langar remains central, where dal, seasonal vegetables, and roti are served to all in a spirit of equality and shared humanity. Baisakhi food begins with this reminder that nourishment, when offered collectively, becomes an expression of morality as much as faith.

From the gurdwara, the celebration moves into homes, where the food becomes fuller, warmer, and more expansive. In many Punjabi households, especially in rural areas where the harvest remains close to everyday life, Baisakhi is marked by dishes that feel inseparable from the land itself. Sarson da saag with makki di roti remains among the most cherished of these. Fresh mustard leaves are slow-cooked with spinach and bathua, then finished with ghee, onions, ginger, and garlic until the dish acquires both body and depth. Depending on taste, crushed or finely diced green chillies are added for an extra penache. Makki di roti, made from maize flour, is kneaded with water and the dough gently pressed into flat discs that are then cooked slowly on a hot griddle, allowing it to develop a delicate crispness while retaining its softness. Often finished with a touch of ghee, it carries a subtle sweetness and an earthy depth. Paired with sarson da saag and served with home made white butter, it completes a meal that is rooted in seasonality, sustenance, and the enduring essence of rural life.

As relatives and neighbours begin to arrive, the spread on the table becomes more elaborate and reflects the mood of the festival. Chole served with poori or bhature often become central to this atmosphere of generous hospitality. Chickpeas are slow-cooked until tender, then simmered in a robust gravy of tomatoes, onions, and a carefully balanced blend of spices. The addition of tea leaves or amla imparts a characteristic dark hue, while a final tempering elevates its aroma. Rich, hearty, and deeply satisfying, it is a dish that carries the vibrancy of the northern plains and is equally at home in humble kitchens and festive gatherings. The chole is accompanied by either puri or bhature, breads which, though similar in form, reflect two distinct expressions of indulgence. Puri is made from unleavened wheat dough, rolled into small discs and deep-fried until it puffs into a light, golden sphere, ensuring it is crisp on the outside and soft within. Bhatura, richer and more expansive, is prepared from

fermented dough, yielding a softer, airy texture



with a gentle tang, often deep-fried to a fuller, more indulgent form. Complementing this ensemble is home made mango pickle, curated with raw seasonal fruits.

Alongside them, one often finds aloo gobi, where potatoes and cauliflower are cooked with cumin, turmeric, and tomatoes until tender and fragrant, as well as stuffed parathas, especially of potato or cauliflower, served with curd, pickle, or butter. In many urban homes and festive gatherings, paneer tikka and amritsari kulcha also find their place, bringing variety of texture and flavour while remaining rooted in the generous culinary instinct that defines Baisakhi. Paneer tikka is prepared through a careful balance of marination and fire. Cubes of paneer are coated in a spiced yogurt mixture, allowing the flavours to seep in before being roasted over open heat or in a tandoor. The process lends a gentle char to the edges while preserving the softness within. Infused with smokiness and layered spices, it reflects a style of cooking where restraint and intensity meet, offering a dish that is both vibrant and refined. This is served with chutneys made of coriander, crushed spring onions, and green chillies. Amritsari kulcha, on the other hand, is crafted with a quiet indulgence that reflects the culinary heritage of Punjab. Made from refined flour, the dough is leavened and rolled out to encase a spiced filling of potatoes, onions, or paneer, before being cooked in a tandoor. The intense heat lends it a crisp exterior while preserving a soft, layered interior. Finished with butter and served alongside chole, it carries a richness that is both comforting and celebratory, rooted in the robust flavours of the region.

The savoury spread often deepens further with the traditional Punjabi kadhi pakora, with its tang of yogurt and gram flour and its soft pakoras resting in a golden gravy. Yogurt and gram flour are cooked slowly with spices until they develop a smooth, tangy warmth, into which soft, golden fritters are added. The pakodas absorb the seasoned gravy, softening while retaining their character. Finished with a fragrant tempering of curry leaves, cumin seeds, and whole red chillies along with ghee, the dish reflects a balance of comfort and complexity. Mah di dal, slow cooked until creamy and finished with ghee and gentle tempering, offers another kind of satisfaction, quieter but equally central to the Punjabi meal. Black lentils are slow-cooked until they soften into a rich, velvety consistency, absorbing the flavours of ginger, garlic, and gentle spices. Finished with butter or cream, and often a light tempering, it carries a subtle smokiness and a lingering warmth. With these come jeera rice or peas pulao, allowing the feast to move naturally from breads to rice without losing its sense of continuity. Such dishes are enjoyed not as isolated specialties, but as part of a meal designed for sharing, revisiting, and lingering over in good company.

If the savoury side of Baisakhi expresses abundance, the sweets express celebration itself. In many homes, sweets are served throughout the day rather than being reserved strictly for the end of the meal. Among the most evocative is meethe chawal, the golden sweet rice prepared with sugar or jaggery, ghee, cardamom, and often saffron or turmeric for colour, then garnished with raisins and nuts. Its hue recalls the ripened harvest, making it especially fitting for Baisakhi. Beside it,

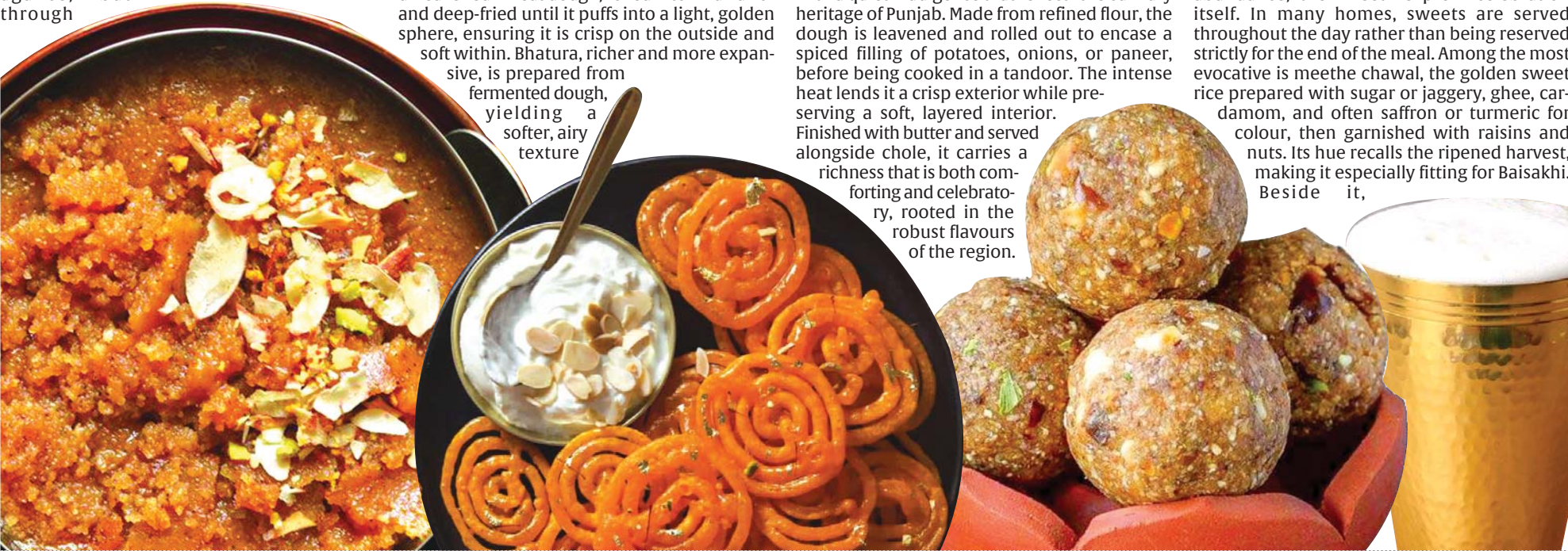
kheer remains a familiar and much loved preparation, with rice simmered slowly in milk until the mixture thickens and sweetens into a dessert that is gentle, rich, and reassuring. The kheer is garnished with chopped almonds and cardamom powder before being served. In warmer weather, phirni offers a cooler variation, its ground rice texture making it smoother and more delicate while still carrying the fullness of milk and cardamom.

Other sweets bring a denser and more domestic kind of festivity to the occasion. Pinni, made from roasted wheat flour, ghee, sugar or jaggery, and nuts, is especially beloved in Punjabi households for the way it combines nourishment with indulgence. Panjiri, more crumbly but similar in composition, also appears as a sweet that can be prepared in advance and offered generously across the festival period. In more visibly festive settings, jalebi often adds a note of exuberance, hot and syrupy, while malpua contributes softness and richness through its fried batter and sweet glaze. These sweets together ensure that Baisakhi is marked not only by fullness of meal, but by the sweetness expected of a harvest celebration, where prosperity is expressed as much through what is offered to others as through what is consumed within the home.

Beverages complete the spread of the Baisakhi table and respond naturally to both the season and the richness of the food. Lassi remains the most iconic among them, churned from curd and served either sweet or salted, often with a thickness that makes it as satisfying as it is refreshing. Chaas, lighter and often seasoned with roasted cumin, mint, or black salt, performs a similar role while aiding digestion through a long day of festive eating. In some homes, kanji may also appear with its distinctive tang, while badam milk or lightly spiced milk offers a more nourishing festive drink. Tea, too, retains its place, especially as evening conversations continue and the intensity of the day begins to fade. These beverages do more than refresh. They help pace the meal, balance the palate, and extend the spirit of welcome that Baisakhi so naturally encourages.

What lends the cuisine of Baisakhi its deeper significance is that it carries within it an entire way of life while honouring the bounty of nature. The foods associated with the festival are shaped by the rhythms of cultivation, the ethic of seva and hospitality, and the quiet knowledge transmitted through kitchens over generations. In the preparation of kada prasad, the slow simmering of saag, the hand formed makki di roti, the shared serving of chole, kadhi, meethe chawal, kheer, pinni, and the cooling welcome of lassi, one encounters a cultural narrative that cannot survive through recollection alone. It must continue to be cooked, practised, and shared. To preserve the traditions of Baisakhi, therefore, is not only to honour the festival, but also to protect the cuisine that gives it identity, flavour, and emotional memory. These dishes do not stand apart from Baisakhi's cultural and spiritual significance. They are among its most eloquent expressions. If Baisakhi is to endure as a living tradition, then the culinary knowledge through which it is experienced must also be kept alive, for in preserving these foods and the ways they are prepared and shared, we preserve one of the most enduring expressions of Punjab's civilisational and cultural inheritance.

(The writer is Secretary, Cuisine India Society)



The plate next to mine that changed everything

NISHANT SAHDEV

I thought I understood good food-until Alu Sheddo Bhat proved me wrong. I remember the plate before I remember the city.

It was my first proper meal in Kolkata, and it came not as a dish, but as a sequence. I was sitting cross-legged on the floor, as is often the case in Bengali homes during Durga Puja, when eating becomes part ritual, part rhythm.

The rice arrived first-steaming, soft, almost luminous. Then everything else followed, without voice but with presence. Ilish mach, carrying that unmistakable sharpness Bengalis swear by. Prawns in a thick, coconut-laced gravy. Crisp vetki fish pakoras, golden at the edges, waiting to be broken. It was the kind of meal that tells you, without saying it, that you are somewhere important. I leaned into it. I wanted the full experience-the flavours, the abundance, the sense of occasion.

And then I noticed another plate. It sat beside the rest, silent, almost reluctant to be seen. Rice. A single green chilli. A drizzle of mustard oil. A pinch of salt. Two boiled potatoes. Nothing more. For a moment, I thought it had been placed there by mistake. Then I realised-it was mine.

There is a particular kind of disappointment that does not express itself. It does not complain. It does not protest. It simply lingers. I felt it then.

Not because I was hungry-I was not. But because something in me had already decided what a “real meal” should look like. And this did not match



it. I did not say anything. No one around me would have noticed. But internally, I had already made a judgement.

This is not enough. That thought came quickly. Too quickly. I picked at the rice first, almost absent-mindedly. The mustard oil rose immediately-sharp, unfamiliar, slightly aggressive to a palate trained elsewhere. I hesitated with the chilli. The potatoes looked too plain, too soft, too... unfinished. I was surrounded by dishes that demanded attention.

This one did not.

So I almost ignored it.

“What happened?” someone asked, noticing my hesitation. I do not remember who it was-only the tone. Casual. Curious. Not defensive.

I gestured slightly towards the plate. “This... is it?” They smiled-not in offence, but in recognition. As if they had seen this reaction before. “Mix it properly. Use your hand. Otherwise, you will not understand it,” they said. So I did. I mixed the rice with the potatoes, pressing them together lightly. The mustard oil spread through it, carrying its sharpness evenly now. I broke a small piece of chilli, hesitated, then added it in.

The first bite was not fair. There was no immediate revelation, no sudden burst of flavour. But there was something else. Coherence. Everything sat where it was supposed to. Nothing dominated. Nothing competed. The mustard oil no longer felt aggressive — it felt necessary. The chilli did not overpower-it clarified. It was not a dish trying to impress me. It was a dish asking me to meet it halfway. What I was eating was Alu Sheddo Bhat-one of the most unassuming, and perhaps most misunderstood, expressions of Bengali food.

No complexity in the way I had defined it. No layering meant to surprise. No visible effort to elevate it. And yet, it carried something the

other dishes did not. It carried certainty.

I had come to Kolkata expecting excess. The city has built its reputation on intensity-intellectual, cultural, emotional. During Durga Puja, that intensity becomes visible everywhere. Pandals rise overnight. Streets reorganise themselves around movement. Food multiplies, expands, overflows.

In that environment, it is easy to assume that more is always better. That value must be visible. That richness must declare itself. But Bengali food culture resists that assumption. Because alongside its celebrated dishes-the hilsa, the kosha mangsho, the chingri malai curry-exists another way of eating. One that does not rely on spectacle. One that does not need validation through variety. Alu Sheddo Bhat sits firmly in that space. It is not trying to compete with anything else on the table. It simply refuses to.

Native to Delhi, I had grown used to a different grammar of food. A meal was complete when it was-multiple dishes, contrasting textures, visible richness. Celebration meant abundance. Satisfaction meant variety.

That grammar works. But it is not universal. And that afternoon, I realised I had been treating it as if it were. There is a small arrogance in assuming that what feels complete to you must be complete for everyone. I carried that arrogance into that room without noticing it. It revealed itself in a single

thought: this is not enough.

And it broke just as fast. Because the more I ate, the less I missed anything else. There was no absence. No gap waiting to be filled. The dish did not expand outward — it settled inward. It did not try to hold my attention. It changed how I paid attention. Travel is often described as exposure-to new places, new people, new cultures. But more than that, it is exposure to your own assumptions. That afternoon, I did not just encounter a new dish. I encountered the limits of my own understanding. I saw how quickly I assign value. How easily I confuse familiarity with correctness. How instinctively I trust what looks complex over what is quietly complete. The plate did not change. I did. Even now, when I think of Kolkata, I do not remember the grandeur first. Not the pandals, not the crowds, not even the elaborate spread that had initially captured my attention. I remember that smaller plate. The one I almost dismissed. The one that did not argue, did not explain, did not try to prove anything. The one that simply waited.

Because the truth is — there was never anything missing from that meal. Only from the way I was looking at it.

The writer is a theoretical physicist at the University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill and a columnist on AI, infrastructure, and global systems



A simple guide to facing life’s challenges with equanimity

Equanimity is not weakness. Mahatma Gandhi advocated peace, but he did not sit back and allow injustice to happen. Being peaceful, he took action. The essence of the Bhagavad Gita is this: fight with equanimity

GURUDEV SRI SRI RAVI SHANKAR

We need to be calm most of all when we are surrounded by problems and life is chaotic. Wisdom is precious in such moments of chaos. Being calm and peaceful when life runs smoothly has no meaning. Being peaceful when everything is peaceful is dull. If we are quiet and peaceful when everything in life falls apart, then that peace has value. A bottle of water has more worth in a desert than when we are surrounded by water. When we sit by a spring, how much value does a bottle of water hold for us?

We need the inner strength to smile when people blame us, when they do not understand. When things do not go the way we want them to, that is when we need the endurance, the strength, and the courage to remain unperturbed. What brings that courage in us is exactly what Lord Krishna said in the Bhagavad Gita: “Samatvam yoga uchyate” (Chapter 2, Verse 48), meaning “equanimity is the test of yoga.”

Lord Krishna shows us the way to become equanimous amidst the seemingly opposing situations in life. Whenever we gain something, whether it is money or fame, we might end up losing some friends. In every gain, there is a loss, and in every loss, there is some gain. People lose half their health to gain wealth, and they lose half their wealth to regain it. Caught up between this gain and loss, they lose their entire life. Time is lost, life is lost; what they have gained till now will also be lost. Lord Krishna says, “Do not worry about winning or losing. Just do your duty.” Our extreme concern for winning and losing weakens us. And a weak person can never win. They can never perform well. Hence, Lord Krishna said, “Be centred and perform.”

Just observe how our minds and emotions flare up for nothing. It creates a mess all around. One moment you are feeling high, another moment you are low. Yoga is the answer to these psychological troubles. “Samatvam yoga uchyate.” Yoga is becoming equanimous and having a stable mind.

It is about being established in the Self. In other words, regardless of a person, object, or situation that comes before us, we do not lose our smile and equanimity. Even if we lose it, it is only momentary, and we instantly regain our composure. Then we can say we are strongly and firmly established in the Self.

To be firmly established in the Self, first we need to accept that opposite values are complementary. For example, night has value when there is day; or peace has value because we have experienced chaos. A film is interesting because there is a hero and there is a villain, is it not? So when you know that opposing values in nature are really complementary to each other, then the mind becomes settled, and equanimity is established. Next is to accept others as they are, because our mind is disturbed by our lack of acceptance of people or situations. It is not people that bother us as much as our own minds. But once we accept, our minds calm down. Then



“A BOTTLE OF WATER HAS MORE WORTH IN A DESERT THAN WHEN WE ARE SURROUNDED BY WATER. WHEN WE SIT BY A SPRING, HOW MUCH VALUE DOES A BOTTLE OF WATER HOLD FOR US?”
— GURUDEV

we can take decisive actions. Third is not to become a football of others’ opinions. We need not worry about what others are thinking about us and spoil our minds. In fact, nobody has time to think about others. We need to look within ourselves and see what is right and what is not right for us.

Immersing the mind in this wisdom and remembering these principles again and again brings calmness and stability to the mind. Once the mind is stable (even if it is somewhat stable), it is able to absorb more knowledge.

When the foundation is strong, we can build a 100-storey building. Similarly, to absorb higher knowledge, we need to be established in the basics. And the knowledge of these basic principles releases our mind from being stuck in the outer world and brings it back to itself, so we can rise higher.

The mind stuck in trivial and insignificant things cannot rise higher. We have to retrieve it. Bring back the scattered mind to its own identity, its own source. And to that effect, these principles we discussed above become very meaningful.

Once, my first Vedic teacher, Pandit Sudhakhar Chaturvedi, shared an incident about Mahatma Gandhi with me. Mahatma Gandhi’s life companion, Kasturba Gandhi, was on her deathbed. Doctors had given up hope. They said, “Just a few hours are left for her to live.” At that time, Mahatma Gandhi came out of his kutir and told Pandit Sudhakhar Chaturvedi, “Please read the verses from Chapter 2 of the Bhagavad Gita for me.” When he recited the shlokas, Gandhi said, “Today is your Bapu’s examination. I will see if I will be able to handle the loss of Kasturba with equanimity.” As he was saying this, tears were rolling down his face. Yoga brings that balance, so that an event does not shatter us.

In moments of utter helplessness, either we get frustrated or we become prayerful. We try to get it done by ourselves, or we turn to our higher self. These are the moments when intense prayer should arise in us. We pray; we cry. We tell the Higher Self or the Divine, “I cannot manage it any more. God, please take care of it. I cannot bear this any more.” This deep, intense cry or prayer relieves us and is good enough for things to start working in our best interest. Prayer

and surrender make the mind equanimous.

One step ahead of prayer is to acquire an equanimous vision or to become ‘Samdarshi’ (one whose vision is equanimous) when times are chaotic. For example, when there is an attack on society and we lose our loved ones, it causes a lot of sorrow and fear. If we keep reeling in sorrow, fear, and anger, then life can soon take a turn towards destruction and violence, which benefits no one. But if we want to channelise this energy, if we want to get justice and face the conflict bravely, we need to calm the mind first and cultivate equanimity.

Equanimity is not weakness. Mahatma Gandhi advocated peace, but he did not sit back and allow injustice to happen. Being peaceful, he took action. The essence of the Bhagavad Gita is this: fight with equanimity.

Know that you are not alone. Sometimes we are faced with intense unpleasantness, humiliation, and failures in life. They also go away. Do not get stuck in them. Just move on with a smile and contribute to a greater cause. The ultimate purpose of life is to be of service. Happiness and success both depend on our ability to give back to society. Let us adopt the fundamental 3Cs in life, ie, to see life from a bigger context; commit to a bigger cause, and have compassion in life. When we practise these 3Cs in our lives, we will be able to lead our lives with equanimity.



JUST OBSERVE HOW OUR MINDS AND EMOTIONS FLARE UP FOR NOTHING. IT CREATES A MESS ALL AROUND. ONE MOMENT YOU ARE FEELING HIGH, ANOTHER MOMENT YOU ARE LOW. YOGA IS THE ANSWER TO THESE PSYCHOLOGICAL TROUBLES. “SAMATVAM YOGA UCHYATE.” YOGA IS BECOMING EQUANIMOUS AND HAVING A STABLE MIND. IT IS ABOUT BEING ESTABLISHED IN THE SELF. IN OTHER WORDS, REGARDLESS OF A PERSON, OBJECT, OR SITUATION THAT COMES BEFORE US, WE DO NOT LOSE OUR SMILE AND EQUANIMITY. EVEN IF WE LOSE IT, IT IS ONLY MOMENTARY, AND WE INSTANTLY REGAIN OUR COMPOSURE. THEN WE CAN SAY WE ARE STRONGLY AND FIRMLY ESTABLISHED IN THE SELF. TO BE FIRMLY ESTABLISHED IN THE SELF, FIRST WE NEED TO ACCEPT THAT OPPOSITE VALUES ARE COMPLEMENTARY. FOR EXAMPLE, NIGHT HAS VALUE WHEN THERE IS DAY; OR PEACE HAS VALUE BECAUSE WE HAVE EXPERIENCED CHAOS.

Vivekananda changed global thought

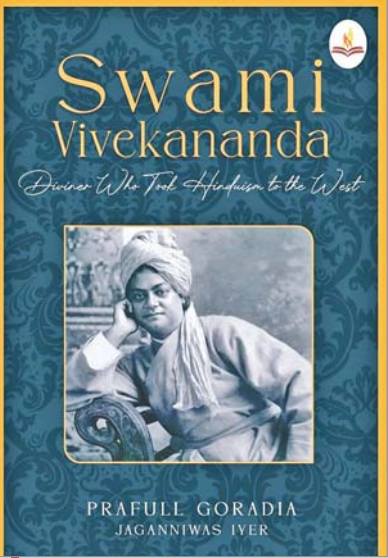
TEAM AGENDA

The very recent book on *Swami Vivekananda, The Diviner Who Took Hinduism to the West*, represents a modern and more interpretative approach to understanding the Swami’s life and mission. Earlier works on Vivekananda—particularly those produced by the Ramakrishna Mission—tended to be restrained, devotional, and focused primarily on his spiritual teachings. While valuable, they often underplayed the historical and global significance of his work. This newer perspective seeks to place Vivekananda within the broader currents of modernity, nationalism, and cross-cultural exchange. His most active and visible public life lasted barely a decade, from 1893 to 1902, yet within this short span he achieved what few figures in history have managed. His early death at the age of 39 cut short a career that might have reshaped even more profoundly the intellectual relationship between East and West.

To understand Vivekananda’s importance, one must consider the historical backdrop. India was still recovering from the shock of the Indian Rebellion of 1857, often referred to as the Sepoy Mutiny. The rebellion had failed, but it left behind a deeply scarred society. British authority became more centralised and assertive, while Indians began to introspect about their identity, traditions, and future. Social reform movements were emerging, and there was a growing need to reinterpret Indian civilisation in a way that could stand confidently before the modern world. It was in this environment that Vivekananda appeared — not as a relic of the past, but as a remarkably modern thinker.

In many ways, Vivekananda embodied the synthesis of tradition and modernity. Educated in Western philosophy and deeply rooted in the teachings of his guru Ramakrishna Paramahansa, he was able to articulate ancient Indian ideas in a language that resonated with contemporary audiences. At a time when colonial narratives often portrayed Indians as inferior, Vivekananda’s intellectual confidence challenged such stereotypes. He did not imitate the West; instead, he engaged with it as an

equal. His journey to the Parliament of the World’s Religions marked a turning point not only in his life but also in the global perception of Hinduism. Supported by enlightened Indian rulers such as the Maharaja of Mysore and others, Vivekananda managed to travel to the United States at a time when such a journey was neither easy nor common. His arrival in Chicago was initially fraught with difficulties—financial constraints, lack of formal credentials,



Title: Swami Vivekananda - Diviner Who Took Hinduism to the West
Author: Prafull Goradia and Jagannivas Iyer
MRP: ₹995
Publisher: Prints

and unfamiliarity with the environment. Yet, these obstacles only made his subsequent success more remarkable. When Vivekananda finally addressed the Parliament in September 1893, his impact was immediate and electrifying. His famous opening words, “Sisters and Brothers of America,” broke through the formal stiffness of the gathering and created an emotional connection with the audience. In a forum largely dominated by Christian representatives, Vivekananda presented Hinduism not as an exotic or inferior tradition but as a profound and inclusive philosophy. His assertion that Hinduism was the “mother of all

religions” was not merely a claim of superiority but a reflection of its long history of accommodating diverse beliefs and practices.

Until that moment, global religious discourse had been heavily centred around Christianity, particularly in the Western world. Swami Vivekananda disrupted this monopoly by introducing Vedanta as a universal philosophy that transcended sectarian boundaries. He emphasised tolerance, acceptance, and the unity of all religions—ideas both ancient and strikingly modern. His message resonated with American audiences seeking spiritual meaning beyond traditional frameworks.

The United States, still a young and dynamic nation, provided fertile ground for his teachings. He became a sought-after speaker, engaging widely through lectures and dialogue. His ability to communicate complex ideas in simple terms made him immensely popular. Notably, he adapted his message without diluting its essence. Presenting Hinduism—especially Vedanta—as a rational and philosophical system rather than mere ritual, he addressed misconceptions and articulated ideas like the divinity of the soul and the unity of existence. In doing so, he emerged as one of the earliest ambassadors of Indian thought on the global stage.

During his extended stay in America, which lasted over a year and a half on a single trip, Vivekananda also underwent a transformation. He began to see more clearly the gap between how India understood itself and how it was perceived abroad. This realisation strengthened his resolve to educate the West about India’s true intellectual and spiritual heritage.

At the same time, he also reflected on the weaknesses within Indian society, particularly poverty, lack of education, and social divisions. His later work in India would increasingly focus on these issues, emphasising practical spirituality and social service. In retrospect, Swami Vivekananda’s Western journey redefined Hinduism in a universal language and shaped global spiritual dialogue. Without it, Indian philosophy might have remained confined; instead, it became a worldwide conversation.

Preserving indigenous knowledge of edible roots and medicinal plants in Jharkhand



TEAM AGENDA

Jharkhand state was carved out of Bihar in 2000. It is a tribal-dominated state, extremely rich in plant wealth, besides being famous for its coal mines as well as mineral deposits. The predominant tribal communities in Jharkhand are Mundas, Oraons, Santhals, Kharias, Birhors, Paharias as well as Asurs.

The authors of this publication, Sudhanshu Kumar and Bandana Kumari, are well-acclaimed ethnobiologists who have traversed the forests and tribal areas in Jharkhand to document the vast indigenous knowledge possessed by the tribal and local communities, as well as medicinal plants. The authors have great experience in taking snapshots of wild plant species having edible tubers, rhizomes and roots, especially in their natural habitats.

This publication provides a comprehensive account of wild and edible roots and their ethnomedicinal utilities among the tribals in Jharkhand.

Chapter 1 of the book incorporates some of the prominent vaidyas who deserve special mention. Chapter 2 provides a comprehensive account of uncultivated yams, corms, and rhizomes used as food as well as ethnomedicine. Chapter 3 includes wild



BOOK REVIEW

**WILD and EDIBLE
'KAND-MOOL' of JHARKHAND
and Their
ETHNO MEDICINAL USES**
(A pictorial book)



Title: Wild and Edible ‘Kand-Mool’ of Jharkhand and Their Ethno Medicinal Uses
Author: Sudhanshu Kumar and Bandana Kumari
MRP: ₹1495
Publisher: Atlantic Publishers & Distributors (P) Ltd

tubers, rhizomes and rootstock that are inedible in Jharkhand but edible in other states in India as well as other

nations. Chapter 4 elucidates the micro-nutrient supplements of some of the wild tubers and rhizomes, followed by the literature cited and Index by scientific names, popular names as well as local names of the plant species.

This publication provides a beautiful and comprehensive pictorial account of edible roots and rhizomes used by various Adivasi communities in Jharkhand as unconventional foods, easily accessible to them and also a cheaper source of minerals and vitamins. Altogether, indigenous communities call them Kand-Mool.

In total, 43 plant species have been well illustrated in this book, which may one day become superfoods for modern society after scientific validation. This publication will be extremely beneficial for students, teachers as well as researchers engaged in bio-prospection for drug development as well as searching for new nutraceuticals. However, the higher price may prevent students and the general public from purchasing it for personal use.

Considering the usefulness and overall contents of this publication, it is a must for personal bookshelves as well as for libraries of colleges and universities, botanical institutions and other research organisations.